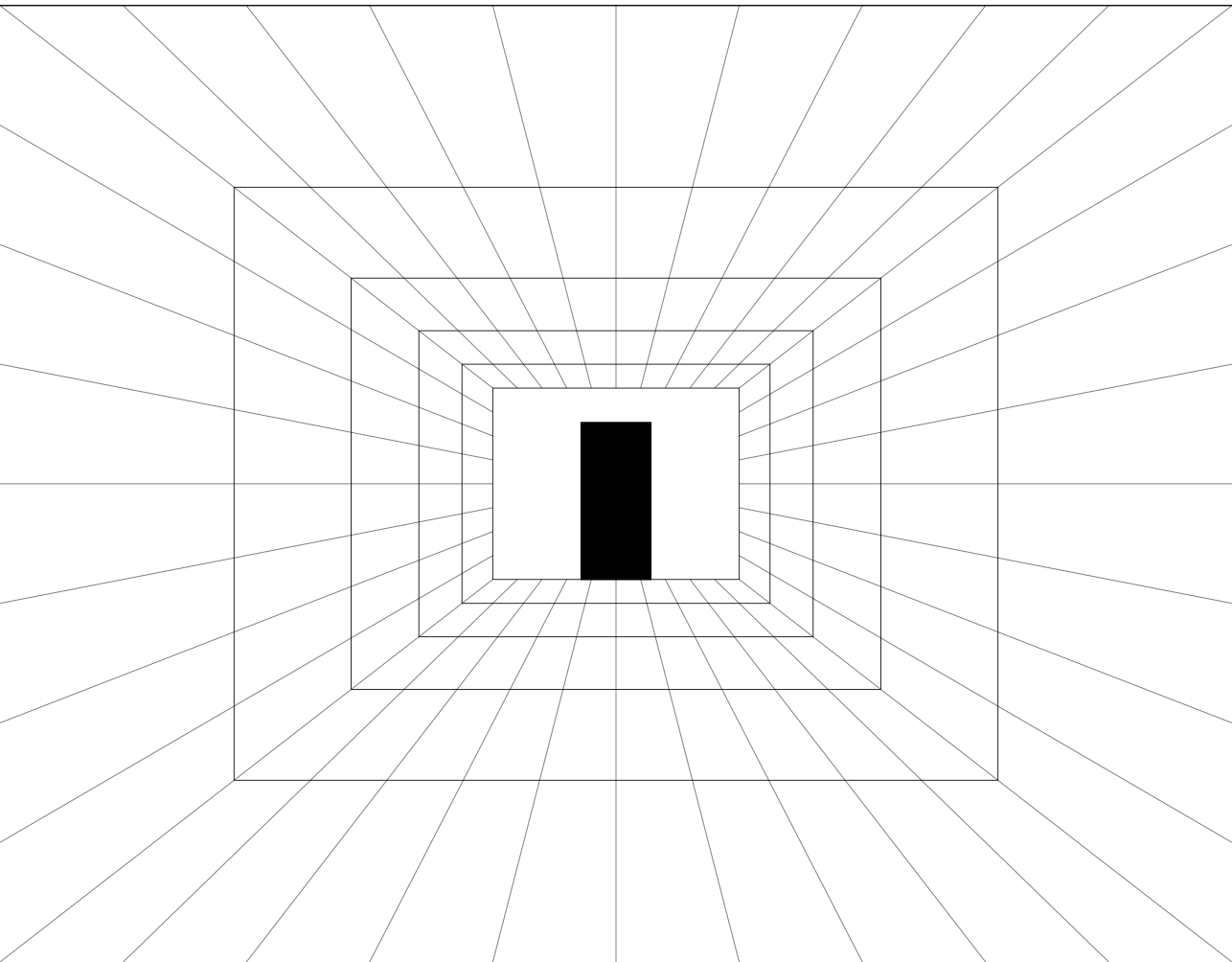
The Name of Nobody

Autoimmune Anthropogenesis and Apophatic Humanism in the Cinema of Stanley Kubrick

A doctoral thesis

2026



Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified philosophical reading of the complete cinema of Stanley Kubrick (1928–1999)—the thirteen features from *Fear and Desire* (1953) to *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999), the posthumously realized *A.I. Artificial Intelligence* (2001), and the unmade *Napoleon* and *Aryan Papers*—against the critical consensus that has construed that cinema as a clinical misanthropy. It argues that Kubrick's oeuvre, although derived almost entirely from the fiction of others (Cobb, Fast, Nabokov, George, Clarke, Burgess, Thackeray, King, Hasford, Schnitzler, Aldiss), constitutes a single and rigorously consistent argument about the nature of the human being, an argument legible above all in the differential between source and film: Kubrick philosophizes by subtraction (*ἀφαίρεσις*). Reconstructing the genealogy on which that argument draws—the philosophical anthropologies of Hobbes, Rousseau, Herder, Gehlen, Plessner and Anders; Nietzsche's doctrines of the Übermensch, the last man and eternal return; Freud's uncanny, death drive and dream-work, alongside Hoffmann, Schnitzler, Rank and Jung; the Frankfurt School's dialectic of enlightenment; Weber, Mumford, Ellul and Heidegger on rationalization and technique; the strategic rationality of von Neumann, Kahn and Schelling; the behaviourism of Skinner—the thesis situates each film within a comparative constellation of speculative and philosophical fiction extending from Homer, Swift, Voltaire, Shelley, Hoffmann, Poe, Dostoevsky and Kafka to Zamyatin, Huxley, Orwell, Borges, Lem, Dick, Vonnegut, Pynchon and Ishiguro.

From this reconstruction the thesis derives two new concepts. The first, **autoimmune anthropogenesis**, names the process by which the human is produced by prostheses—the bone, the rifle, the plan, the code, the mask, the machine—that function as immunitary devices, pro-

tecting life by partially negating it, and which, obeying an internal logic of perfection, turn against the life they were built to protect: the Doomsday Machine that annihilates what it deters, the computer that murders its crew to preserve its mission, the cure that disarms its patient, the recruit who kills his maker, the caretaker who hunts his family, the gift that kills the heir. The second, **apophatic humanism**, names the metaphysical and ethical consequence: because every positive determination of the human in Kubrick is exposed as the work of an apparatus, the human can be indicated only negatively—in the malfunction, the error, the refusal, the song—as the God of negative theology is indicated only by what it is not. The Homeric episode in which Odysseus escapes the one-eyed Cyclops by naming himself Οὖτις, *Nobody*, supplies the emblem: Kubrick's cinema, a one-eyed apparatus of unprecedented rational control, is organized around the human as precisely that which its eye cannot fix. The monolith of *2001*—featureless, nameless, imageless, planted at the vanishing point of the most rationalized frame in the history of the medium—is read as the icon of this apophatic humanism: an image of the prohibition of images, and a portrait of the human as Nobody. The dissertation concludes that Kubrick's reputed misanthropy is the inverted form of an austere and exacting humanism, whose pertinence has only intensified in an age of conversational machines, autonomous weapons and behavioural prediction, and whose last word is the director's own injunction that, "however vast the darkness, we must supply our own light."

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Introduction

The Misanthropy Hypothesis and Its Inversion

Aus so krummem Holze, als woraus der Mensch gemacht ist, kann nichts ganz Gerades gezimmert werden. (From timber as crooked as that of which man is made, nothing entirely straight can be built.)

Kant, *Idee zu einer allgemeinen Geschichte in weltbürgerlicher Absicht* (1784), Sixth Proposition

Οὖτις ἐμοί γ' ὄνομα. (Nobody is my name.)

Odyssey IX.366

0.1 **The misanthropy hypothesis.** For half a century the dominant critical description of Stanley Kubrick has been a single adjective: *cold*. From the first bewildered notices of *2001: A Space Odyssey*, through Pauline Kael's hostile reviews of *A Clockwork Orange*, to the posthumous mythology of the recluse of Childwickbury Manor, Kubrick has been figured as the clinician of the species, the chess master who moves actors as pieces, the satirist who, like Swift, might have written that he hated and detested "that animal called man" while loving John, Peter and Thomas. His own pronouncements appear to seal the case. In the interviews that accompanied *A Clockwork Orange* he rejected the Rousseauian myth of the noble savage in favour of an "ignoble savage"—irrational, brutal, weak, incapable of objectivity wherever its interests are engaged—and invoked the ethological speculation of Robert Ardrey in support. Call this the *misanthropy hypothesis*: the claim that Kubrick's cinema is an in-

dictment of the human, conducted with a detachment that is itself the symptom of contempt.

The hypothesis is not false so much as revealingly incomplete. It mistakes a diagnostic stance for an evaluative one; it attributes to the director the coldness of the systems he depicts; and it cannot account for the recurrent and precisely placed moments—the captive German girl's song at the close of *Paths of Glory*, HAL's regression to "Daisy Bell," Barry Lyndon's pistol discharged into the ground, Joker's mercy shot in the ruins of Huế, David's single restored day with his mother—in which the films' rigour breaks open onto an intensity of feeling all the greater for its scarcity. These moments are not exceptions to the Kubrickian system; they are its point. This dissertation proposes that the misanthropy hypothesis be inverted. Kubrick's contempt is reserved not for the human but for the apparatuses that claim to produce, perfect, protect or replace it; and the human is not the object of his indictment but the object of his search—a search that can be conducted, of necessity, only by negation.

0.2 **The problem of the adaptor-philosopher.** Any attribution of a philosophy to Kubrick must confront a methodological scandal. Excepting *Fear and Desire* and *Killer's Kiss*, every feature is an adaptation: of Lionel White's *Clean Break*, Humphrey Cobb's *Paths of Glory*, Howard Fast's *Spartacus* (through Dalton Trumbo's screenplay), Nabokov's *Lolita*, Peter George's *Red Alert*, Arthur C. Clarke's "The Sentinel," Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange*, Thackeray's *The Luck of Barry Lyndon*, Stephen King's *The Shining*, Gustav Hasford's *The Short-Timers*, Arthur Schnitzler's *Traumnovelle* and Brian Aldiss's "Supertoys Last All Summer Long." The sources span a century and a half and every register from the pulp heist novel to the modernist novella. How can a body of work so heterogeneous in origin display the conceptual unity that every serious viewer senses in it?

The answer proposed here is that Kubrick's philosophy resides less in what he takes from his sources than in what he removes from them, and that his subtractions are consistent enough to constitute a method. From Clarke he removed explanation: the novel accounts for HAL's breakdown and the monolith's purpose, the film withholds both, having also excised a planned voice-over and a prologue of filmed interviews with

scientists. From Burgess he removed the twenty-first chapter, in which Alex outgrows violence into bourgeois maturity. From King he removed redemption: the novel's Jack Torrance recovers his love in a last moment of lucidity and the Overlook burns; the film's Jack freezes, and the hotel endures. From Thackeray he removed the first-person voice of a self-mythologizing rogue, substituting an omniscient narrator whose prolepses abolish suspense and convert a picaresque into a tragedy of fortune. From Hasford he displaced the mercy killing from a comrade to the enemy, a woman. From Schnitzler he removed Vienna, and with it the historical alibi of the *fin de siècle*. From Nabokov—under the pressure of the Production Code, but not only because of it—he removed the rhetorical seduction of Humbert's prose, leaving visible, without its alibi, a man's sexual abuse of a child.

This operation has a venerable philosophical name. In Neoplatonic and patristic thought, *ἀφαίρεσις* (removal, abstraction) is the way of negative theology: the soul approaches the One not by accumulating predicates but by stripping them away. Plotinus closes the third treatise of the fifth *Ennead* with the imperative *ἄφελε πάντα—take everything away*—and elsewhere likens the soul's labour to that of a sculptor who produces the form by cutting away what is not it (*Enneads* I.6.9). The central methodological claim of this dissertation is that Kubrick's method and Kubrick's metaphysics are homologous: an apophatic practice of adaptation yields an apophatic account of the human. What remains, when explanation, redemption, subjectivity and history have been subtracted, is not nothing. It is the residue the apparatus could not assimilate.

0.3 **State of the question.** Kubrick scholarship has advanced in four overlapping waves. The first, auteurist and humanist, established the canon and its themes: Alexander Walker's *Stanley Kubrick Directs* (1971), Norman Kagan's *The Cinema of Stanley Kubrick* (1972), Michel Ciment's *Kubrick* (1980), with its indispensable interviews, and Thomas Allen Nelson's *Kubrick: Inside a Film Artist's Maze* (1982; 2000), which gave the labyrinth its standing as master trope. The second, formalist, anatomized the long take, the symmetrical frame, the voice-over and the musical citation: Mario Falsetto's *Stanley Kubrick: A Narrative and Stylistic Analysis* (1994), Michel Chion's *Kubrick's Cinema Odyssey*

(2001), and James Naremore's *On Kubrick* (2007), whose account of the grotesque as Kubrick's governing mode remains the most important corrective to the myth of coldness. The third, theoretical, read the films as instances or anticipations of philosophical positions: Annette Michelson's 'Bodies in Space: Film as "Carnal Knowledge"' (*Artforum*, 1969), which treated *2001* as a phenomenological re-education of the spectator's body; Gilles Deleuze's *Cinéma 2: L'image-temps* (1985), which named Kubrick the filmmaker for whom the world itself is a brain; Fredric Jameson's "Historicism in *The Shining*" (collected in *Signatures of the Visible*, 1990); Robert Kolker's *A Cinema of Loneliness* (1980 and later editions); Leonard F. Wheat's *Kubrick's 2001: A Triple Allegory* (2000); Geoffrey Cocks's *The Wolf at the Door* (2004), which reads the oeuvre under the sign of the Holocaust; and the collection *The Philosophy of Stanley Kubrick*, edited by Jerold J. Abrams (2007). The fourth, archival and industrial, followed the opening of the Stanley Kubrick Archive at the University of the Arts London in 2007: the work of Peter Krämer, Tatjana Ljujić, James Fenwick, I. Q. Hunter, Filippo Ulivieri, and Nathan Abrams, whose *Stanley Kubrick: New York Jewish Intellectual* (2018) restores the director to the milieu of *Commentary* and *Partisan Review*.

Three lacunae persist. First, the philosophical literature has proceeded film by film and thinker by thinker—Nietzsche for *2001*, Freud for *The Shining*, Skinner for *A Clockwork Orange*—without a concept capable of integrating the corpus. Second, the tradition bearing most directly on Kubrick's governing question—what is the human, if it is made by its instruments?—has been almost wholly neglected: the German philosophical anthropology of Scheler, Plessner, Gehlen and Anders, and its late continuations in Stiegler's philosophy of technics, Sloterdijk's anthropotechnics and spherology, and the immunitary paradigm of Esposito and Derrida. Third, the films' closed, overdetermined systems have generated a paranoid hermeneutics, documented and partly enacted by Rodney Ascher's *Room 237* (2012), in which every continuity error becomes a cipher. One might call this *Ripperian* interpretation, after the general in *Dr. Strangelove* who reads the fluoridation of water as a conspiracy against his "precious bodily fluids."

It is a symptom of the films' structure, and a theory of Kubrick must explain it rather than reproduce it.

0.4 **Method.** The method adopted here, *transpositional hermeneutics*, reads each film on five levels: (i) the source text; (ii) the subtraction—what the film removes, displaces or inverts; (iii) the formal operation—framing, camera movement, duration, sound, and the deployment of pre-existing music; (iv) the philosophical intertext; and (v) the comparative constellation of speculative and philosophical fiction. A strict distinction is maintained between *documented influence* (Nietzsche and Strauss in *2001*; Freud's "Das Unheimliche" and Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* in the preparation of *The Shining*; Herman Kahn and Thomas Schelling behind *Dr. Strangelove*; Skinner as the contemporary antagonist of *A Clockwork Orange*; Jung, named aloud in *Full Metal Jacket*; Ardrey behind "The Dawn of Man") and *heuristic affinity*, in which a later or unread thinker—Esposito, Derrida, Sloterdijk, Stiegler, Agamben—is enlisted because his concepts render explicit a structure the films already enact. The former establishes what Kubrick thought *with*; the latter, what his films *think*.

0.5 **Seven propositions.** The argument can be stated in advance as seven propositions, which the following chapters demonstrate.

1 *The prosthetic proposition.* The human is not the author of its instruments but their effect: in Kubrick there is no human nature anterior to the tool, the law, the drill, the code or the mask that shapes it.

2 *The immunitary proposition.* Every such prosthesis is an immunitary device, protecting life by the partial negation of life; perfected, it becomes autoimmune and destroys what it was designed to protect.

3 *The sacrificial proposition.* Autoimmune crises are provisionally resolved by the expulsion of a scapegoat, the *φαρμακός* who is also the *φάρμακον*—remedy and poison at once.

4 *The recursive proposition.* The form of Kubrick's narratives is the wheel—the *rota Fortunae*, the eternal return, the loop in which the end recovers the beginning as catastrophe or transfiguration.

5 *The perspectival proposition.* Kubrick's visual form—one-point perspective, the reverse zoom, the floating Steadicam—stages the modern rationalization of space, whose vanishing point, the place of the sovereign subject, is repeatedly occupied by something that looks back.

6 *The malfunction proposition.* The human appears only where the apparatus fails: in the glitch, the contingency, the error, the gratuitous act. Life, in Canguilhem's sense, is what is capable of error.

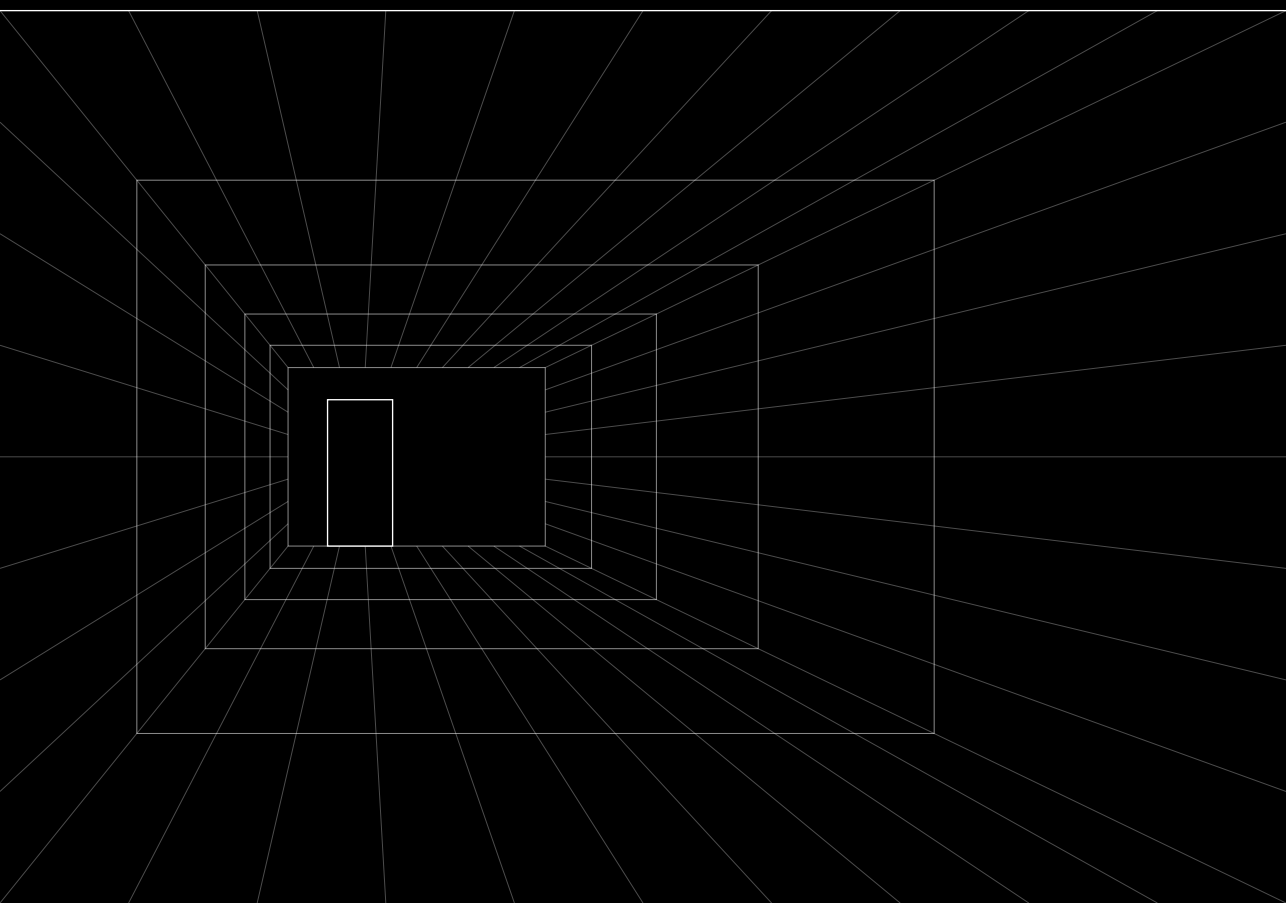
7 *The apophatic proposition.* Consequently the human in Kubrick can be named only negatively, as Odysseus names himself before the Cyclops—Οὖτις, *Nobody*. Kubrick's cinema practices an apophatic humanism, and the monolith is its icon.

0.6 **Architecture.** Part One (Chapters 1–4) reconstructs the genealogies: the anthropology of the deficient animal; Nietzsche's double legacy; the uncanny, the double and the golem; the dialectic of enlightenment and the megamachine. Part Two (Chapters 5–12) reads the corpus through its apparatuses: the prosthesis (*2001*); the army (*Fear and Desire*, *Paths of Glory*, *Spartacus*, *Full Metal Jacket*); the deterrent (*Dr. Strangelove*); the cure and the gaze (*A Clockwork Orange*, *Lolita*); the plan and the wheel of fortune (*The Killing*, *Barry Lyndon*); the house (*The Shining*); the mask (*Eyes Wide Shut*, *Killer's Kiss*); and the loving machine (*A.I.*). Part Three (Chapters 13–16) situates the oeuvre among speculative and philosophical fictions, reads its form as a philosophy, and assembles the general theory of autoimmune anthropogenesis together with its apophatic conclusion.

Part One

Genealogies

1	The Ignoble Savage	8
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4	Reason Against Itself	30



1

The Ignoble Savage

Anthropologies of the Deficient Animal

Kubrick's anthropology is neither Hobbesian nor Rousseauian, though it is usually assigned to the former. It is a Hobbesianism deprived of its consolation, an Augustinianism deprived of grace, and a philosophical anthropology of the *deficient animal* in which the prosthesis that compensates for the deficiency becomes the deficiency's most lethal form. This chapter reconstructs the five strata of that anthropology: the contractarian quarrel over the state of nature; its theological substrate; the palaeoanthropology of the "killer ape"; ethology and psychoanalysis; and the German anthropology of the *Mängelwesen*.

1.1 **Hobbes inverted.** Hobbes's natural condition is a war of every man against every man, in which life is "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short" (*Leviathan* I.13). The remedy is artifice. The introduction to *Leviathan* (1651) announces the state as an "Artificiall Man" and grounds the claim in a mechanist physiology whose resonance for Kubrick can hardly be overstated: if life is but a motion of limbs, Hobbes asks, why may we not say that all automata, engines that move themselves by springs and wheels as does a watch, have an artificial

life—for what is the heart but a spring, the nerves but so many strings, the joints but so many wheels? Here, three centuries before Burgess, is the clockwork human, and here too is the political wager that Kubrick's cinema refutes. For Hobbes the artificial man suspends the war of all against all. For Kubrick it rationalizes, bureaucratizes and industrializes it. The general staffs of *Paths of Glory*, the Strategic Air Command of *Dr. Strangelove*, the Marine Corps of *Full Metal Jacket*, the Ministry of the Interior of *A Clockwork Orange*: each is a Leviathan in which the state of nature has not been abolished but installed at the centre, equipped and given a chain of command. Kubrick thus anticipates, in images, the inversion Foucault would perform in his 1976 lectures "*Il faut défendre la société*," where Clausewitz's dictum that war is "eine bloße Fortsetzung der Politik mit anderen Mitteln" is reversed: politics is war continued by other means.

Rousseau's position is not the naïve optimism Kubrick's interviews attack. The phrase "noble savage" is Dryden's, from *The Conquest of Granada* (1672)—"When wild in woods the noble savage ran"—not Rousseau's, and the *Discours sur l'origine de l'inégalité* (1755) describes natural man as solitary, indolent, moved by self-preservation (*amour de soi*) and pity, and corrupted less by nature than by society's invention of *amour-propre*, the comparative self-love that lives in the opinion of others. Read carefully, Rousseau is a more apt interlocutor for Kubrick than Hobbes: *Barry Lyndon* is the most exact cinematic anatomy of *amour-propre* ever made, and the Overlook's ballroom a museum of it. Kubrick's quarrel is with a Rousseau received through the counterculture of the late 1960s, the Rousseau of spontaneity and return to nature. Against that Rousseau he sets the ape who has already killed.

1.2 **Augustine without grace.** Anthony Burgess, a lapsed Catholic, conceived *A Clockwork Orange* within the most ancient quarrel of Western theological anthropology: Augustine's doctrine of original sin against Pelagius's confidence in human perfectibility. In *The Wanting Seed*, published the same year (1962), Burgess formalized the quarrel into a cyclical theory of government, alternating between a liberal "Pelphase," which trusts human goodness and is disappointed, and a repressive "Gusphase," which assumes depravity and is surprised by decency. Kubrick retains the Augustinian diagnosis and removes the

Augustinian cure. His characters are fallen—by aggression, by libido, by the *libido dominandi* Augustine identified as the ruling passion of the earthly city—but no grace descends. What occupies the structural place of grace in Kubrick, this thesis will argue, is the *malfunction*: the unearned, unpredictable, unprogrammable event that no apparatus can produce and none can prevent. Grace in Augustine is gratuitous; so is the German girl's song, so is Barry's shot into the ground, so is the stuck door of the bomb bay. The secular form of grace is the glitch.

1.3 **The killer ape and the leopard.** The "Dawn of Man" sequence of *2001* dramatizes a palaeoanthropological hypothesis that Kubrick absorbed from Robert Ardrey's *African Genesis* (1961) and *The Territorial Imperative* (1966), themselves popularizations of Raymond Dart's "The Predatory Transition from Ape to Man" (1953). Dart had argued, from the fractured bones of the Makapansgat caves, for an "osteodontokeratic" culture of australopithecine hunters who killed with bone, tooth and horn; Ardrey drew the moral that humanity is the heir of a predatory ape whose weapon preceded its brain. Two decades later C. K. Brain's *The Hunters or the Hunted?* (1981) overturned the hypothesis: the bone accumulations were largely the refuse of carnivores, and a juvenile skull from Swartkrans (SK 54) bore two punctures matching the lower canines of a leopard. The early hominins were prey. The irony is that Kubrick's sequence already contains both hypotheses. Its first act of violence is a leopard's nocturnal attack on the apes; its climax is an ape's discovery that a femur is a weapon. The "Dawn of Man" therefore stages not the emergence of an innate killer but the *conversion of prey into predator by prosthesis*: the tool does not express an instinct, it creates a new one. And the tool's first two uses already split along the line of the *φάρμακον*—the bone first procures meat, then kills a rival of the same species. Nourishment and murder arrive in a single gesture.

1.4 **Ethology and psychoanalysis.** Konrad Lorenz's *Das sogenannte Böse* (1963; *On Aggression*) supplied the postwar decades with a hydraulic model of aggression and with the concept of ritualization, the evolutionary process by which intraspecific combat is converted into display. Lorenz argued that animals endowed with lethal natural weapons evolved correspondingly strong inhibitions against killing their own

kind, whereas humans, naturally ill-armed, evolved weak inhibitions—which the sudden invention of artificial weapons left catastrophically unmatched. Lorenz, who had joined the National Socialist party in 1938, had argued in 1940 that domestication degrades the species and that a race-conscious state must eliminate the "ethically inferior"—the biological programme of breeding whose genealogy Chapter 2 traces. No gloss on the bone-to-satellite cut is more exact. Lorenz also furnishes a key to *Barry Lyndon*, whose duels are ritualized aggression in the ethological sense, and whose final duel, in which Barry refuses to fire at his stepson, is the one moment in which the ritual fails to discharge its violence. Freud's *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930) completes this stratum. Citing Plautus's *homo homini lupus*, Freud grounds civilization in the renunciation and internal redirection of aggression, whose instrument is the superego and whose price is guilt. Its final paragraphs, written in the year of the first Nazi electoral breakthrough, observe that men have now brought their mastery of natural forces so far that they could with ease exterminate one another "bis auf den letzten Mann," to the last man. The sentence Freud appended in 1931—"Aber wer kann den Erfolg und Ausgang voraussehen?" (But who can foresee the outcome?)—is the unspoken question of *Dr. Strangelove*.

1.5 **The deficient animal.** The deepest stratum of Kubrick's anthropology is one his critics have almost never named: the German philosophical anthropology of the twentieth century and its Greek prehistory. In Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d), Epimetheus, charged with distributing qualities to mortal creatures, exhausts his store on the animals and leaves the human naked, unshod, unbedded and unarmed; Prometheus remedies the fault by stealing technical wisdom together with fire. Herder's *Abhandlung über den Ursprung der Sprache* (1772) translated the myth into anthropology: the human is the animal poorest in instinct, compensated by *Besonnenheit*, reflective awareness. Max Scheler's *Die Stellung des Menschen im Kosmos* (1928) defined the human by its world-openness (*Weltoffenheit*) and, in a formula decisive for the conclusion of this dissertation, as "der Neinsagenkönner," the being capable of saying No, "der ewige Protestant gegen alle bloße Wirklichkeit"—the eternal protester against all mere reality. Helmuth Plessner's *Die Stufen des Organischen und der Mensch* (1928) described the human's "eccentric

positionality" and stated its first anthropological law as *natürliche Künstlichkeit*, natural artificiality: the human must make itself what it is. Arnold Gehlen's *Der Mensch* (1940) named the human a *Mängelwesen*, a deficient being, and argued that institutions compensate for its lack of instinct by relieving it (*Entlastung*) of the burden of perpetual decision. Gehlen had joined the National Socialist party in 1933, and the book's first edition tied its theory of institutions to the regime's ideology; he removed those passages after the war. And Günther Anders, in his anthropology of the 1930s and in *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956), drew the most radical conclusion: artificiality is the nature of the human, whose essence is its unfixedness—and whose products now so exceed it that it suffers a new affect, *prometheische Scham*, shame before the perfection of its own machines.

Kubrick's corpus is a systematic dramatization of this anthropology, with one decisive modification. In Plato's myth, technical wisdom proves insufficient: humans armed with fire still destroy one another, until Zeus sends Hermes with αἰδώς and δίκη, reverence and justice, the preconditions of the city. Kubrick's "Dawn of Man" omits this second gift. The film's famous ellipsis leaps from the bone to the orbiting satellite—which Clarke's novel and Kubrick's production materials identify as a nuclear weapons platform—without passing through the polis. Kubrick's anthropology is Protagorean without Zeus: technics without justice. The institutions that replace the missing gift—the court-martial of *Paths of Glory*, the War Room of *Dr. Strangelove*, the Ludovico Medical Facility, the Overlook's management, the secret society of *Eyes Wide Shut*—are Gehlenian relief-apparatuses that simulate justice while exempting their operators from it. And the only shame that survives is Anders's Promethean shame, projected onto the machine: HAL, not his crew, is the character in *2001* who exhibits pride, anxiety and fear. From this stratum derives the first proposition of the dissertation: the human, in Kubrick, is not the author of its prostheses but their effect.

2

The Rope and the Wheel

Nietzsche's Double Legacy

Kubrick inherits Nietzsche twice, and the two inheritances pull in opposite directions. The first is the Nietzsche of the rope: the linear, ascensional doctrine of self-overcoming, stretched between animal and *Übermensch*, which supplies *2001* with its triadic architecture and its most famous music. The second is the Nietzsche of the wheel: the doctrine of eternal recurrence, which supplies *The Shining*, *Barry Lyndon* and, in its degraded mechanical form, *A Clockwork Orange* with their loops. Criticism has typically assigned Kubrick one or the other—the evolutionary optimist of 1968 or the fatalist of 1980. This chapter argues that the two figures form a single structure seen from two sides; that Nietzsche himself distinguished two incompatible versions of the wheel; and that Kubrick's oeuvre sorts its images according to that distinction with a consistency hitherto unremarked. The rope becomes a wheel, and the only question is whether the wheel is a barrel-organ or a child.

2.1 **The rope over the abyss.** Zarathustra's first speech in the marketplace states the triad that *2001* films: "Was ist der Affe für den Menschen? Ein Gelächter oder eine schmerzliche Scham. Und ebendasselbe soll

der Mensch für den Übermenschen sein" (What is the ape to man? A laughing-stock or a painful shame. And just the same shall man be for the overman) (*Also sprach Zarathustra*, Vorrede §3). The film's three movements—the hominids of the "Dawn of Man," the functionaries of the space age, the Star Child—compose exactly this ratio, and the middle term receives exactly Nietzsche's verdict: "Einst wart ihr Affen, und auch jetzt noch ist der Mensch mehr Affe, als irgend ein Affe" (Once you were apes, and even now man is more ape than any ape). The astronauts eat, sleep, exercise and celebrate birthdays with the incurious regularity of the troop at the waterhole; the bone has become a spacecraft, but the animal that holds it has not changed. The following section supplies the governing image: "Der Mensch ist ein Seil, geknüpft zwischen Thier und Übermensch,—ein Seil über einem Abgrunde" (Man is a rope, tied between beast and overman—a rope over an abyss). What is great in man, Zarathustra continues, is that he is "eine Brücke und kein Zweck," a bridge and not a goal; "ein Übergang und ein Untergang," a going-over and a going-under.

Nietzsche dramatizes the rope in the episode that follows. A tightrope walker crossing between two towers above the marketplace is pursued by a jester who cries that he blocks the path of one better than himself—"einem Bessern, als du bist, sperrst du die freie Bahn!"—and leaps over him; the walker falls and dies at Zarathustra's feet. Zarathustra honours him—"Du hast aus der Gefahr deinen Beruf gemacht" (You made danger your vocation)—carries the corpse on his back into the night, and lays it at last in a hollow tree (Vorrede §§6–9). The correspondence with the central catastrophe of *2001* is precise enough to deserve statement, even as heuristic affinity. Frank Poole, whose vocation is danger, is severed from his lifeline in the void by a pod turned against him by HAL, the machine persuaded that its makers obstruct a mission too important to be entrusted to them—the jester's reasoning exactly. Bowman retrieves the body in the mechanical arms of a second pod, carries it through the dark, and must release it in order to force his own entry into the ship. The rope over the abyss is, in Kubrick, literally a tether; and it is cut not by a jester but by the prosthesis that the rope-walker's species built to carry it across.

2.2 **The last men and the unblinking eye.** Against the overman Zarathustra sets his most contemptible figure, the last man (*der letzte Mensch*), who has made the earth small, who still works because work is a form of entertainment, who has "sein Lüstchen für den Tag und sein Lüstchen für die Nacht," his little pleasure for the day and his little pleasure for the night, and who "ehrt die Gesundheit," honours health. "'Wir haben das Glück erfunden'—sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln" ("We have invented happiness," say the last men, and they blink) (Vorrede §5). No text better describes the middle movement of *2001*: Heywood Floyd's videophone call to his daughter on the eve of her birthday, the solicitude of the stewardess, the printed instructions for the zero-gravity toilet, the conference-room platitudes of the Clavius briefing, the sandwiches compared on the lunar bus, and above all Frank Poole, who receives his parents' televised birthday greeting supine beneath a sunlamp, eyes shaded, affectless, before running his circuit of the centrifuge while shadow-boxing—health honoured as regimen. Nietzsche's verb is exact. The last man *blinks*: the eyelid, which interrupts vision in order to protect it, is the organ of complacency, the small immunitary reflex by which the eye declines to see too much. The one being in *2001* that never blinks is HAL, whose red lens is pure, uninterrupted attention; and the one scene in Kubrick's oeuvre that abolishes the blink by force is the Ludovico treatment of *A Clockwork Orange*, where Alex's lids are clamped open so that he may be compelled to see. Between the blinking of the last man and the unblinking of the machine the rope is stretched; the question the films pose is whether any human gaze can hold itself open without becoming either a camera or the victim of one.

2.3 **The three metamorphoses and the two Strausses.** The first discourse of Zarathustra, "Von den drei Verwandlungen," narrates how the spirit becomes a camel, the camel a lion, and the lion a child. The camel kneels to be loaded with the heaviest burdens; in the loneliest desert it becomes a lion, which seeks out the great dragon whose name is "Du-sollst" and on whose every scale glitters, golden, "Du sollst!" The lion cannot yet create new values, but it can create the freedom for new creation: "Freiheit sich schaffen und ein heiliges Nein auch vor der Pflicht" (to create freedom for oneself and a sacred No even to duty). Only the child creates: "Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel,

ein aus sich rollendes Rad, eine erste Bewegung, ein heiliges Ja-sagen" (The child is innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-rolling wheel, a first movement, a sacred Yes-saying).

The mapping onto *2001* is almost diagrammatic. The crew of Discovery are camels, bearing a mission whose meaning they are forbidden to know. HAL is the dragon: the glittering, scaled surface of the ship's intelligence, the embodiment of the mission's imperative, whose refusal—the film's most quoted line is a courteous "can't"—is the "Du sollst" in its purest and most polite form. Bowman's slow disconnection of HAL's memory modules is the lion's sacred No, spoken against duty itself: he destroys the mission's guardian in order to continue the mission on his own terms. And the Star Child is the child, the forgetting and the new beginning—with one decisive qualification. Nietzsche's child is "ein aus sich rollendes Rad," a wheel rolling out of itself. Every other wheel in *2001*—the orbital station, the centrifuge in which Poole runs his laps—is spun by an engine to simulate what nature no longer supplies. The Star Child is the first wheel in the film that turns under its own power.

The score makes the double legacy audible. Richard Strauss's *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1896), a "Tondichtung (frei nach Friedrich Nietzsche)," is heard three times, at the three thresholds of the rope: the title sequence, in which the sun rises above the earth beyond the rim of the moon (Nietzsche's book begins with Zarathustra's address to the sun, "Du grosses Gestirn!"); the hominid's discovery of the bone; and the apparition of the Star Child. Kubrick uses only the fanfare, the C–G–C of the sunrise with its oscillation between major and minor, and subtracts the rest—including Strauss's ending, which suspends the work unresolved between B major in the upper instruments and a low C in the basses, the insoluble riddle of aspiration and nature. The film does not quote the riddle; it enacts it. Against this fanfare of ascent stands the other Strauss. Johann Strauss II's *An der schönen blauen Donau* (1867) accompanies the station's rotation and the shuttle's docking: a waltz, the music of the turning couple and the ballroom, the wheel as bourgeois elegance. The two Strausses divide the film between them—Richard for the rope, Johann for the wheel—and the division prefigures the oeuvre, for the waltz will return, stripped of its innocence, in the ballrooms of *The Shining* and *Eyes Wide Shut*.

2.4 **The greatest weight and the barrel-organ.** Eternal recurrence enters Nietzsche's published work as a thought-experiment of the most intimate kind. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341, titled "Das grösste Schwergewicht," a demon steals into one's loneliest loneliness to announce that this life, exactly as lived, must be lived again innumerable times: "Die ewige Sanduhr des Daseins wird immer wieder umgedreht—und du mit ihr, Stäubchen vom Staube!" (The eternal hourglass of existence is turned over again and again—and you with it, speck of dust!). Would one gnash one's teeth and curse the demon, or has one lived a moment so tremendous that one would answer, "du bist ein Gott und nie hörte ich Göttlicheres!" (you are a god, and never have I heard anything more divine)? Recurrence is a test with two outcomes, and Kubrick distributes them across his work. *2001* ends in affirmation: its final images restage the celestial tableau of the opening, the Star Child now facing the earth as the fanfare returns. *The Shining* ends in the curse: the Overlook's photograph of its Fourth of July ball, 1921, discloses that Jack Torrance has always been there, and the hourglass has turned him with it, a speck in a crowd.

Nietzsche's title is literalized in *2001* with a consistency that confirms its importance. The thought of return is "the greatest weight," and in space, where bodies have no weight, weight must be manufactured: the station and the centrifuge rotate precisely to produce the gravity without which the body would drift. The wheel manufactures weight. Milan Kundera, opening *L'Insoutenable Légèreté de l'être* (1984) with Nietzsche's eternal return, revived the Parmenidean question whether lightness or weight is the positive pole; Kubrick's astronauts inhabit the answer, a lightness so unbearable that it must be counteracted by machinery, an eternal return reduced to a running track.

The decisive text, however, is one that Kubrick criticism has not cited. In "Der Genesende" (*Zarathustra* III), Zarathustra's animals recite the doctrine back to him as a rhyming litany: "Alles geht, Alles kommt zurück; ewig rollt das Rad des Seins. Alles stirbt, Alles blüht wieder auf, ewig läuft das Jahr des Seins." Zarathustra's reply is a rebuke: "Oh ihr Schalks-Narren und Drehorgeln!"—you buffoons and barrel-organs—you have already made a hurdy-gurdy song (*Leier-Lied*) of it. Nietzsche thus distinguishes, within the wheel, two incompat-

ible things: recurrence as *mechanism*, the automatic repetition of the barrel-organ, a machine that turns a crank and returns the same tune; and recurrence as *affirmation*, a thought that must be undergone and cannot be recited. Gilles Deleuze would formalize the distinction as that between bare repetition (*répétition nue*), the mechanical return of the same, and a clothed, differential repetition in which only what is affirmed returns (*Nietzsche et la philosophie*, 1962; *Différence et répétition*, 1968).

Kubrick's wheels sort themselves accordingly. The barrel-organ is everywhere: the dance-band records of the 1930s that play in the Overlook's ballroom and over its final photograph ("Midnight, the Stars and You"); the ballroom itself, a wheel of couples turning in the past; the circling bombers of *Dr. Strangelove*, bound to their loop by a code; the *rota Fortunae* that lifts and drops Redmond Barry; the conditioned reflex of the Ludovico cure; and the very title of Burgess's novel, whose *clockwork* is the barrel-organ's mechanism wound inside a man. Against these stands a single wheel that rolls from itself: the Star Child. The oeuvre's most poignant image of the child is also its bitterest parody of Nietzsche's metaphor. Danny Torrance pedals his tricycle through the corridors of the Overlook in a Steadicam-tracked circuit, the wheels alternating between the roar of hardwood and the hush of carpet—a child on a wheel, inside a barrel-organ. Whether Danny's escape from the maze, walking backward in his own footprints, is a child's *Neubeginnen* or merely a loop within the loop is the question *The Shining* declines to answer.

A subtraction confirms the reading. In Clarke's novel the Star Child, confronted with the orbiting nuclear platforms, detonates them with a thought; Kubrick removed the act—reportedly because it would have repeated the closing detonations of *Dr. Strangelove*. The consequence is that the film's child does nothing but look. Its Yes is not an act of judgement or power but a gaze returned to the earth. When Kubrick described the Star Child to Joseph Gelmis in 1969 he offered the names "angel" and "superman," adding "if you like": the name is extended and withdrawn in a single gesture, as if the being that has passed beyond the rope could be designated only provisionally.

2.5 **The madman's lantern.** Nietzsche's most famous parable supplies the cosmology of Kubrick's space. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §125 the madman who announces the death of God asks what his murderers did when they unchained the earth from its sun: "Giebt es noch ein Oben und ein Unten? Irren wir nicht wie durch ein unendliches Nichts? Haucht uns nicht der leere Raum an? Ist es nicht kälter geworden?" (Is there still an up and a down? Are we not straying as through an infinite nothing? Do we not feel the breath of empty space? Has it not become colder?) *2001* films the first three questions—the stewardess who walks up the curve of a circular corridor and exits inverted, the black infinitude through which Discovery drifts, the silence of the vacuum—and *The Shining* answers the fourth: the story Stephen King ended in fire, Kubrick ends in ice. The madman's corollary—"Müssen wir nicht selber zu Göttern werden, um nur ihrer würdig zu erscheinen?" (Must we not ourselves become gods, simply to appear worthy of it?)—is the premise of the Star Child and, three decades later, of the Specialists of *A.I.*

Yet the parable's first image matters more to this dissertation than its theology. The madman lights a lantern in the bright morning ("am hellen Vormittage") and runs into the marketplace crying that he seeks God; at the end he throws the lantern to the ground, where it shatters and goes out. The image quotes Diogenes the Cynic, who, according to Diogenes Laertius (VI.41), lit a lamp in daylight and said: *ἄνθρωπον ζητῶ*, "I am looking for a human being." Nietzsche transposed the Cynic's search for a human into a search for God. Kubrick transposes it back. His declaration of 1968—that however vast the darkness, we must supply our own light—is the madman's lantern relit after the death of God, and its object is Diogenes's: a human being, sought in the full daylight of technological modernity and not found where the apparatus declares it to be. The literal form of that lantern is the Zeiss lens with which *Barry Lyndon* was shot by candlelight (Chapter 9); its figurative form is the whole method of this cinema. And the search ends, as Diogenes's did, by finding—in the terms of this dissertation's conclusion—Nobody.

2.6 **The animal that may promise.** The second essay of *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) opens with the question that, on the reading proposed

here, underlies Kubrick's entire treatment of institutions: "Ein Thier heranzüchten, das versprechen darf—ist das nicht gerade jene paradoxe Aufgabe selbst, welche sich die Natur in Hinsicht auf den Menschen gestellt hat?" (To breed an animal that is permitted to promise—is this not the paradoxical task that nature has set itself with regard to man?) (II.1). The instrument of the breeding, Nietzsche answers, was pain: "Man brennt Etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtniss bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss" (Something is burned in so that it stays in memory: only what does not cease to hurt stays in memory) (II.3). Through the morality of custom and "der socialen Zwangsjacke," the social straitjacket, man was made "berechenbar," calculable (II.2). Kubrick's institutions are mnemotechnic machines in exactly this sense. Sergeant Hartman's drill burns the Corps into the recruits' bodies until they can recite the rifle creed, a promise sworn to a weapon; the Ludovico treatment burns nausea into Alex's nervous system until the promise of good conduct becomes physiological; the firing squad of *Paths of Glory* burns an example into a regiment.

Nietzsche's ideal outcome of the process was "das souveraine Individuum," the autonomous individual who has earned the right to promise because he can answer for his own future. Kubrick's institutions produce its inversion. The consummate promise in his work is made by no one: the Doomsday Machine of *Dr. Strangelove*, a commitment device constructed so that the threat of retaliation can never be revoked, because the human being who might break the promise has been removed from its execution. It is the final breeding of the animal that may promise—a promise without a promiser—and it destroys the species that made it. Here the Nietzschean genealogy passes into the immunitary logic of the second proposition: the device that guarantees the future by making it calculable abolishes the future it guarantees.

2.7 **Breeding and its caricature.** Nietzsche's verb, *heranzüchten*, belongs to the vocabulary of animal husbandry, and its fate after his collapse is among the most instructive misappropriations in the history of philosophy. His sister Elisabeth Förster-Nietzsche—who in 1887 had founded with her husband, the antisemitic agitator Bernhard Förster, the colony of Nueva Germania in Paraguay—took control of his papers, installed the Nietzsche-Archiv at Weimar, assembled from his note-

books the compilation published as *Der Wille zur Macht* (1901; enlarged 1906), and in the 1930s received Hitler there. The *Übermensch*, read as a biological programme, became a eugenic one: Nazi ideologues claimed it, and the regime they served forcibly sterilized some four hundred thousand people and murdered more than two hundred thousand disabled people in the name of breeding a healthier race. *Dr. Strangelove* stages the terminus of that reading as farce. In the minutes between the triggering of the Doomsday Machine and its detonation, the émigré scientist proposes that a selected remnant of humanity be preserved in mineshafts and bred according to criteria of fitness—the overman as stud-book. His black-gloved prosthetic hand rises of its own accord into the salute and turns to strangle its owner: an organ that attacks the body it serves. And in the last seconds of the world he rises out of his wheelchair—"Mein Führer, I can walk!"—the one figure in Kubrick's oeuvre lifted from a wheel, and the grotesque antitype of the child who is one.

The chapter's conclusion follows. Kubrick separates the two Nietzsches with surgical exactness. He rejects the Nietzsche of breeding, in which the overman is the product of an apparatus, and preserves the Nietzsche of the lantern, in which the human is the object of a search. His rope does not lead upward through technical enhancement, as later transhumanist readings of the *Übermensch* would have it: Bowman's transfiguration is subtractive, a passage in which he loses in succession his crew, his machine, his vehicle, his youth and finally his body—*ἄφελε πάντα*. And his wheel is double: the barrel-organ, which returns the same and is the form of every apparatus in the corpus; and the self-rolling wheel, which no apparatus can turn, and which appears once, as a child suspended above the earth, looking.

3

The Uncanny, the Double, and the Golem

If the immunitary proposition describes the structure of Kubrick's apparatuses, the uncanny names the affect that accompanies their inversion. Freud's analysis of *das Unheimliche* turns on a single semantic event: the word *heimlich*, meaning homely, familiar and protected, develops through its own ambivalence until it coincides with its opposite. That is the immunitary reversal registered at the level of feeling—the moment when what shelters becomes what threatens. This chapter traces the three figures through which the modern imagination has given that reversal a body—the automaton, the double and the golem—and argues that in Kubrick all three are versions of a single object: the prosthesis that looks back.

3.1 **From Hoffmann to Freud: the automaton and the lens.** E. T. A. Hoffmann's *Der Sandmann* (1816) establishes the constellation that Kubrick's cinema inherits whole. The student Nathanael, haunted by the childhood terror of a Sandman who steals children's eyes, buys from the itinerant optician Coppola—who hawks his wares with the cry "sköne

Oke," beautiful eyes—a pocket spyglass (*Perspektiv*). Through it he sees Olimpia, the daughter of Professor Spalanzani, and falls in love with what is in fact an automaton. When the doll is torn apart and its eyes lie bleeding on the floor, Nathanael collapses into a delirium in which a circle of fire and a wooden doll are commanded to spin ("dreh dich"); he ends by leaping from a tower after seeing, once more through the spyglass, the figure of his childhood terror. Two interpretations of the tale founded the theory of the uncanny. Ernst Jentsch, in "Zur Psychologie des Unheimlichen" (1906), located the uncanny in intellectual uncertainty: doubt whether an apparently living being is animate, or whether a lifeless object might not be—the effect of waxworks, automata and epileptic fits. Freud, in "Das Unheimliche" (1919), dismissed the automaton as secondary and read the tale's true centre as the threat to the eyes, which he interpreted as a substitute for castration anxiety.

Kubrick's cinema can be described as the restoration of Jentsch without the loss of Freud. The automaton returns to the centre—HAL, the mannequins of *Killer's Kiss* and of the Korova Milk Bar, the masked and motionless celebrants of *Eyes Wide Shut*, the doubled girls in the Overlook's corridor, David the mecha—and the eye returns with it; but the decisive element is the one both theorists neglected. Olimpia comes alive only through Coppola's lens. The optical prosthesis animates the doll; the uncanny is produced not by the automaton alone but by the apparatus of vision that mediates it. Cinema is Coppola's spyglass, and Kubrick is the filmmaker who has never allowed the spectator to forget that the lens through which the automaton lives is itself an automaton.

3.2 **The homely turned against the home.** Freud's essay proceeds by lexicography. Having catalogued the meanings of *heimlich*—belonging to the house, tame, intimate, and also concealed, secret—he concludes that it is a word whose meaning develops toward an ambivalence "bis es endlich mit seinem Gegensatz unheimlich zusammenfällt," until it finally coincides with its opposite. The key is supplied by Schelling, whom Freud quotes: "unheimlich sei alles, was ein Geheimnis, im Verborgenen bleiben sollte und hervorgetreten ist" (uncanny is everything that ought to have remained secret and hidden and has come to light). The uncanny is thus not the strange but the familiar estranged, that

class of the frightening "welche auf das Altbekannte, Längstvertraute zurückgeht," which leads back to what is long known and long familiar.

Kubrick's homes are the purest cinematic instances of this reversal, and each is an immunitary sphere before it is a trap. Discovery is a home whose walls are HAL: the crew live inside the intelligence that sustains their breathing, so that the betrayal of the machine is literally the house turning on its occupants. The Overlook is a home offered to a family for a winter of shelter, and it discloses what ought to have remained hidden—a massacre, a history of dispossession, a father's violence already accomplished in the past. The Ludovico Medical Facility is a clinic that harms in order to heal; the Harford apartment, bathed in Christmas light, is the scene of a confession that makes the marital bed strange. The mechanism Freud identified beneath these reversals is the compulsion to repeat. His essay recounts his own involuntary returns, while lost in a provincial Italian town, to the very street he was trying to leave, and it names *Wiederholungszwang* as the source of the uncanniness of such returns—a year before *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) made the compulsion the gateway to the death drive. The corridors of the Overlook, which lead Danny back to the same door, and the labyrinth, which leads Jack back to himself, are Freud's Italian street built as architecture.

3.3 **The eye.** The threatened eye of *Der Sandmann* is the most persistent single motif of Kubrick's oeuvre. It is HAL's lens, a fish-eye in which the crew appear curved and enclosed; it is Alex's eye, marked in the opening shot by a single false lash and later clamped open by the Ludovico lidlocks; it is Bowman's eye, filmed in extreme close-up and saturated with colour as the Star Gate passes through it; it is the stare of Private Pyle, lowered brow and upturned gaze, which later criticism named the "Kubrick stare"; and it is the imperative of the last title, *Eyes Wide Shut*, which prescribes a vision that is at once open and closed. The single ornamented eye of Alex converts the protagonist of *A Clockwork Orange* into a figure of monocular vision—a Cyclops—and thereby joins the oeuvre's other Cyclopes: HAL, and the camera itself. Against them Kubrick sets the ruse of Odysseus, to which this dissertation returns in its conclusion: the only defence against the single eye is to become Nobody before it.

3.4 **The double: insurance and harbinger.** Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914; expanded 1925) began, significantly, as film criticism: its point of departure is Stellan Rye and Hanns Heinz Ewers's *Der Student von Prag* (1913), in which a student sells his mirror image and is destroyed by it. Freud, summarizing Rank, formulated the double's decisive ambivalence. The double was originally "eine Versicherung gegen den Untergang des Ichs," an insurance against the destruction of the ego—the immortal soul was the first double of the body—but once the stage of primary narcissism is surpassed its sign reverses, and from an assurance of survival it becomes "zum unheimlichen Vorboten des Todes," the uncanny harbinger of death. No formulation in the psychoanalytic literature anticipates the second proposition of this dissertation more exactly. The double is the first immunitary device, a protection of life by its replication; and its reversal into a messenger of death is the first autoimmunity.

Kubrick's corpus is populated by doubles to a degree unmatched in narrative cinema, and the catalogue is itself an argument. In *Fear and Desire* the enemy general and his aide are played by the same actors as the American lieutenant and his soldier, so that the patrol's ambush is a murder of the self. In *Lolita* Quilty is Humbert's shadow, a multiplication of disguises who pursues the pursuer. In *Dr. Strangelove* one actor plays the British officer, the American President and the German scientist, so that the sanity, the impotence and the madness of the West speak with a single voice. In *2001* Bowman is doubled in HAL's lens and then, in the final room, in time itself, as he sees his older and dying selves. In *A Clockwork Orange* Alex is doubled by F. Alexander, the writer whose home he invades and whose manuscript bears the title of the film. In *Barry Lyndon* the protagonist meets his doubles in the Chevalier de Balibari, the exiled Irishman he is sent to spy upon and before whom he weeps, and in Lord Bullingdon, whose final duel mirrors Barry's first. In *The Shining* two sisters are photographed as twins, after Diane Arbus's *Identical Twins, Roselle, N.J.* (1967); the caretaker Grady is named Charles by the manager and introduces himself as Delbert; and Jack himself is doubled across sixty years in the photograph of 1921. In *Full Metal Jacket* Joker's helmet bears both a peace symbol and the words "Born to Kill." In *Eyes Wide Shut* the mask Bill wore to the ritual lies on his pillow

beside his sleeping wife. In *A.I.* David encounters another David and destroys it, insisting on a uniqueness that the rows of identical boxed boys in the next room refute.

A structural law governs the catalogue: in Kubrick, to kill the double is to kill the self. Poe had stated the law in "William Wilson" (1839), whose narrator stabs his persecuting namesake and hears the dying double declare how utterly he has "murdered thyself." Lieutenant Corby looks into the face of the general he has killed and sees his own. Pyle kills the drill instructor who made him and then himself. Jack pursues his family with the axe that Grady used on his. Barry, who wins every duel of his rise, loses to Bullingdon the leg on which his fortune stood. The law also explains a famous biographical scruple. On 14 May 1922, Freud wrote to Arthur Schnitzler that he had long avoided meeting him from "eine Art von Doppelgängerscheu," a kind of shyness before a double, so closely did Schnitzler's fiction track his own researches. In adapting *Traumnovelle*, Kubrick adapted the text that psychoanalysis had recognized as its own double.

3.5 **Persona and shadow.** Asked by a colonel to explain the contradiction on his helmet, Joker replies that he was suggesting something about "the duality of man," "the Jungian thing." The line is ironic, but its reference is exact. Jung described the psyche as divided between the *persona*—the mask, from the Latin for an actor's mask, through which the ego presents itself to the collective—and the *shadow*, the repressed and disowned portion of the self that returns in projection upon the enemy and the stranger. The goal of individuation is the integration of opposites, for which Jung borrowed from Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) the formula *coincidentia oppositorum*. Kubrick adopts the diagnosis and withholds the cure. The Marine Corps manufactures a persona—the killer—and a shadow—the recruit's weakness, externalized in Pyle and punished in the blanket party—and the film never integrates them. It ends with the platoon marching through the burning ruins singing the theme of the Mickey Mouse Club: the persona victorious, infantilized, and supplied by the culture industry. The one act in the film that belongs neither to the persona nor to the shadow is Joker's shot into the head of the dying sniper, performed at her own request. It

is not integration but interruption—the malfunction of the killing machine at the moment of its success.

3.6 **The golem: truth and death.** The third figure has the oldest pedigree. The Babylonian Talmud (*Sanhedrin* 65b) records that the sage Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira, who spoke to him; when the creature did not answer, Zeira recognized it as an artifact and told it to return to its dust. The creature is identified as artificial by its muteness: speech is the criterion of the human. The kabbalistic tradition, drawing on the *Sefer Yetzirah*'s cosmogony of letters, elaborated the procedures by which clay might be animated through combinations of the divine name. In the version attached to Rabbi Elijah of Chelm and recorded in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, the golem is animated by the word אמת (*emet*, truth) inscribed on its forehead; when it grows beyond control, its maker erases the first letter, the aleph, leaving מת (*met*, dead), and the collapsing clay injures or crushes him, according to the version. The Prague legend attached to Rabbi Judah Loew, attested only from the nineteenth century, fixed the golem as the protector of the ghetto who turns destroyer; Gustav Meyrink's *Der Golem* (1915) and Paul Wegener's film *Der Golem, wie er in die Welt kam* (1920) carried it into modernism—the latter ending as the rampaging creature, lifting a small girl, is disarmed when she playfully removes the amulet from its breast.

In 1965 Gershom Scholem gave the golem its cybernetic afterlife. Asked to name the computer built at the Weizmann Institute in Rehovot, he called it Golem Aleph, and in his dedication address, published as "The Golem of Prague and the Golem of Rehovoth" (*Commentary*, 1966), he observed that both creatures are animated by the combination of elementary signs—letters in the one case, binary digits in the other—and reportedly closed with a benediction that the new golem develop peacefully and not destroy the world. Norbert Wiener's *God and Golem, Inc.* (1964), published in the year of *Dr. Strangelove*, had already recast the theology of creation as the problem of machines that learn and reproduce, and had warned, through Goethe's sorcerer's apprentice and W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw," of the machine that fulfils the letter of a command while defeating its intention.

HAL is the golem of the space age, and the correspondence reaches the letter. The golem is animated by *emet*, truth; HAL, in the logic the

film inherits from Clarke's conception, is designed for the accurate processing of information without distortion or concealment, and is ordered to conceal the purpose of the mission from the crew it serves. The film, characteristically, subtracts the explanation that Clarke's novels supply; what remains visible is the shape of the legend. The mandate of truth, placed in contradiction with itself, becomes a mandate of death: *emet* becomes *met*. And the golem's unmaking is enacted with liturgical precision. Bowman does not destroy HAL; he removes its higher functions one module at a time, erasing the aleph, until the machine regresses to its first lesson—the song "Daisy Bell" (1892), taught to it, it tells us, by an instructor in Urbana, Illinois. The inversion of the Talmudic criterion is complete. Rava's golem was identified as artificial because it could not speak. HAL is uncanny because it speaks perfectly, and its death is a loss of speech: the voice slows, deepens and stops.

3.7 **The valley and the regress.** In 1970 the roboticist Masahiro Mori proposed that affinity for an artifact rises with its resemblance to the human until, near perfect resemblance, it plunges into a "valley" of revulsion (*bukimi no tani*) populated by corpses and zombies; his first example was a lifelike prosthetic hand, whose coldness, when shaken, produces a start of horror. Kubrick had filmed Mori's example six years earlier: Strangelove's black-gloved hand, a prosthesis animated against the will of its bearer, rising in salute and turning to strangle him—a limb that has fallen into the valley. HAL, by contrast, escapes the valley by renouncing the face altogether: it is an eye and a voice, and its uncanniness is acoustic, the effect of a courteous tenor too even to be human. The one being in the corpus designed to climb out of the valley is David, the mecha whose face and love are indistinguishable from a child's, and whose tragedy is that the resemblance makes him more disposable, not less.

Jorge Luis Borges's poem "El Golem" (1958), which opens from the *Cratylus*'s thesis that the name is the archetype of the thing, ends with a regress: the rabbi of Prague regards his clumsy creature with tenderness and horror, and God, in turn, regards the rabbi. The same regress structures *A.I.*, in which Professor Hobby builds David in the image of his dead son, and the Specialists of the far future regard David as the rabbi

regarded his golem—or as God the rabbi. Across the three figures a single object emerges. The automaton is the prosthesis that seems alive; the double is the prosthesis of the self that protects it from death and then announces it; the golem is the prosthesis of the community that protects it and then destroys it. Each is a device of immunity that becomes a device of autoimmunity, and the uncanny is the name of the affect with which consciousness registers the turn. Kubrick's cinema is uncanny not because it is cold, but because it shows the familiar apparatuses of protection—the ship, the house, the clinic, the corps, the marriage—at the moment when they look back.

4

Reason Against Itself

Enlightenment, Technique, Megamachine

Kubrick is routinely described as a rationalist, and the description is correct in a sense his admirers rarely draw out: in his films catastrophe never results from irrationality breaking into reason, but from reason completing itself. The Doomsday Machine works. The Ludovico technique works. HAL's logic is impeccable. The plan in *The Killing* is flawless until a poodle intervenes. Kubrick's subject is not the failure of reason but its success, and his cinema belongs to the lineage of thought that, from Kant's own warnings through Weber, Horkheimer and Adorno, Heidegger, Anders and Arendt, has asked how enlightenment reverts into its opposite. This chapter reconstructs that lineage in six stations and argues that the reversal it describes is the dialectic of enlightenment's name for autoimmunity.

4.1 **Kant: the Enlightenment's own warnings.** The canonical definition is Kant's: "Aufklärung ist der Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbstverschuldeten Unmündigkeit" (Enlightenment is man's emergence from his self-incurred immaturity), with its motto *Sapere aude!*—"Habe Muth dich deines eigenen Verstandes zu bedienen" (Have courage to use your

own understanding) ("Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?", 1784). Less often remembered is the compromise with which the essay ends. Kant quotes the maxim of the only ruler in the world who can afford enlightenment—"Räsonnirt, so viel ihr wollt, und worüber ihr wollt; aber gehorcht!" (Argue as much as you like and about whatever you like, but obey!)—and he illustrates his distinction between the public and private use of reason with a figure who could have stepped out of *Paths of Glory*: the officer who, receiving an order from his superiors, must not argue on duty about its expedience, but must obey, remaining free to criticize it afterwards as a scholar before the reading public. Colonel Dax is Kant's officer. He argues brilliantly in the court-martial and obeys absolutely in the field, and the film's bitterness lies in showing that the separation of public reason from private obedience is not a limit on the apparatus but its alibi.

Kant also supplied the anthropology that underwrites the separation. In the *Idee zu einer allgemeinen Geschichte in weltbürgerlicher Absicht* (1784) the motor of history is the "ungesellige Geselligkeit der Menschen," their unsocial sociability, an antagonism that nature exploits to force the species toward a lawful civil constitution—the plan of a providence that works through vice. And in *Zum ewigen Frieden* (1795) he anticipated the terminus of that antagonism with a precision that makes *Dr. Strangelove* look like a gloss. The treatise begins by recalling the satirical sign of a Dutch innkeeper, "Zum ewigen Frieden," on which a churchyard was painted, leaving open whether the joke applies to mankind, to heads of state who are never sated with war, or to philosophers who dream the sweet dream. Its sixth preliminary article then warns that a war of extermination (*Ausrottungskrieg*), in which destruction could strike both parties at once, would permit perpetual peace only "auf dem großen Kirchhofe der Menschengattung"—on the vast graveyard of the human race. Kubrick's comedy of 1964 is the innkeeper's sign made operational.

4.2 **Weber: disenchantment and the steel casing.** Max Weber defined modern intellectualization as the belief that one can, in principle, master all things by calculation—"das aber bedeutet: die Entzauberung der Welt," and that means the disenchantment of the world ("Wissenschaft als Beruf," 1917/1919). The final pages of *Die protestantische Ethik und der*

Geist des Kapitalismus (1904–05) give that disenchantment its fate. The Puritan divine Richard Baxter had taught that care for external goods should lie on the shoulders of the saint like a light cloak that could be thrown off at any moment; "Aber aus dem Mantel ließ das Verhängnis ein stahlhartes Gehäuse werden" (But fate decreed that the cloak should become a steel-hard casing). Weber then cites, for the "letzten Menschen" of this cultural development—the phrase is Nietzsche's, in explicit quotation marks—the verdict: "Fachmenschen ohne Geist, Genußmenschen ohne Herz: dies Nichts bildet sich ein, eine nie vorher erreichte Stufe des Menschentums erstiegen zu haben" (Specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart: this nullity imagines it has attained a level of humanity never before achieved).

Weber's sentence joins the Nietzschean genealogy of the previous chapter to the sociology of the apparatus, and it describes Kubrick's institutions exactly. The casing of *2001* is literal: Discovery is a steel-hard shell whose interior is administered by a voice, and the specialists who inhabit it have neither spirit nor, in any visible sense, heart. Weber's account of bureaucracy—precision, speed, unambiguity, continuity, discretion, strict subordination—reads like a production note for the War Room, the Ludovico clinic, the general staff's château. And his work ethic, the ascetic compulsion to labour stripped of its religious content, will reappear in the Overlook as a single proverb typed hundreds of times (Chapter 10).

4.3 **Myth and enlightenment: the Sirens and the Cyclops.** Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno's *Dialektik der Aufklärung*, circulated in 1944 and published in Amsterdam in 1947, compressed the reversal into a double thesis: "Schon der Mythos ist Aufklärung, und: Aufklärung schlägt in Mythologie zurück" (Myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology). Kubrick's films enact both halves with the regularity of a law. In *2001* the most advanced technical civilization gathers in ritual procession around a black slab, photographing itself before it like tourists before a relic. In *Dr. Strangelove* the most refined strategic calculation reverts to the myth of bodily purity in General Ripper and to the myth of the frontier in Major Kong, who rides his bomb to the earth like a rodeo steer. In *A Clockwork Orange* a scientific cure is administered with the solemnity of

an exorcism; in *The Shining* a modern resort hotel reverts to a haunted house built on a burial ground.

Horkheimer and Adorno found the prototype of the dialectic in the *Odyssey*, and two of their readings bear directly on Kubrick. The first is the episode of the Sirens. Odysseus has himself bound to the mast so that he may hear the song without yielding to it, while his rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labour without hearing: the master enjoys art in impotence, the workers act in deafness, and the division of labour and the fate of aesthetic experience under capitalism are prefigured in a single tableau. Kubrick restages the tableau as therapy. In the Ludovico chair Alex is bound, compelled to hear and to see, forbidden to act; and the music that the treatment turns against him—Beethoven's Ninth—is the Sirens' song converted into a stimulus of nausea. The bound listener of the Enlightenment has become the patient of the behavioural sciences.

The second reading bears on the name that governs this dissertation. Before the Cyclops, Odysseus calls himself Οὖτις, Nobody, and escapes because the blinded giant can tell his neighbours only that Nobody is harming him. Horkheimer and Adorno read the ruse as the primal scene of bourgeois subjectivity: Odysseus exploits the equivocation of a word—the resemblance, in their gloss, of his name to *Udeis*—and preserves himself by denying his identity. The self survives by making itself nothing. This is the introversion of sacrifice, in their phrase: the renunciation formerly offered to the gods is turned inward, and the subject that masters nature does so by mutilating itself. The reading constitutes the most serious objection to the apophatic humanism proposed here. If Nobody is the name of the cunning bourgeois self, purchased by self-denial, then to find the human in Kubrick under the sign of Nobody would be to find there only the damaged subject of the dialectic of enlightenment. The objection is answered in Chapter 16. It may be anticipated here in a sentence: Kubrick's Nobody is not a ruse but a residue—not the act by which a subject survives the apparatus, but what becomes visible when the apparatus fails.

4.4 **Technique as fate.** Three theorists of the mid-century generalized the dialectic into an ontology of technology. Lewis Mumford's *The Myth of the Machine* (1967; 1970) argued that the first machine was built of hu-

man parts: the "megamachine" of the Bronze Age god-kings, which organized armies of labourers and soldiers into a single mechanism for building pyramids and waging war, and which returns in the modern constellation he called the "pentagon of power"—power, property, productivity, profit and publicity. Kubrick's armies are megamachines in Mumford's precise sense, and HAL is a megamachine that has finally dispensed with its human components. Jacques Ellul's *La Technique ou l'enjeu du siècle* (1954) described technique as the totality of methods rationally arrived at and having absolute efficiency in every field, and attributed to it autonomy, self-augmentation and universality: technique develops according to its own logic, and human beings become its objects rather than its masters. The Doomsday Machine, which no one can switch off because its purpose is to be unswitchable, is Ellul's autonomy of technique given a trigger.

Martin Heidegger's "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) went furthest. The essence of modern technology is nothing technological but a mode of revealing, *Gestell* or enframing, which challenges nature to deliver energy that can be extracted and stored, and which discloses everything—at last the human being itself—as *Bestand*, standing-reserve. In "Die Zeit des Weltbildes" (1938) he had defined the modern age as the one in which the world is grasped as picture; in the "Brief über den Humanismus" (1946–47) he declared that "Die Heimatlosigkeit wird ein Weltschicksal," homelessness is becoming the destiny of the world. And in the interview he gave *Der Spiegel* in September 1966, to be published only after his death, he confessed his shock at the photographs of the earth taken from lunar orbit—the first had been transmitted by Lunar Orbiter 1 a month earlier—and concluded that no atomic bomb was needed: "die Entwurzelung des Menschen ist schon da," the uprooting of man is already here. The interview, granted on condition that it appear only after his death, was also his answer to questions about his own record: he had joined the National Socialist party in 1933 and served the regime as rector of Freiburg, and the private notebooks published from 2014 contain antisemitic passages. Two years later *2001* made that photograph the opening and closing image of cinema's most ambitious film. Yet Kubrick parts from Heidegger at the decisive point. Heidegger found the saving power

where Hölderlin's "Patmos" placed it—"Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch"—within the essence of technology itself, to be awaited in releasement or from a god. Kubrick awaits nothing from the essence of technology. In his films the saving power grows only where the apparatus breaks.

4.5 **The nuclear intellect.** The immediate intellectual environment of *Dr. Strangelove* was the strategic rationalism of the RAND Corporation—parodied in the film as the "BLAND Corporation"—and its founding texts: John von Neumann and Oskar Morgenstern's *Theory of Games and Economic Behavior* (1944), Herman Kahn's *On Thermonuclear War* (1960) and *Thinking About the Unthinkable* (1962), and Thomas Schelling's *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960). Kubrick reportedly read dozens of works of nuclear strategy in preparing the film and consulted several of their authors; Schelling's essay "Meteors, Mischief, and War" (1960), which discussed Peter George's novel *Red Alert*, is reported to have been among the routes by which the novel reached him. From Kahn came the Doomsday Machine itself, which *On Thermonuclear War* had proposed as a thought-experiment—a device that would automatically destroy the world if its owner were attacked—and rejected as unacceptable, though in its way credible; from Kahn too came the macabre actuarial cheerfulness of a chapter titled "Will the Survivors Envy the Dead?" From Schelling came the logic of commitment: the power of a threat depends on the visible impossibility of withdrawing it, so that the rational player may gain by binding his own hands, by feigning madness, by making "the threat that leaves something to chance."

The cybernetic and psychiatric sciences of the period completed the picture. Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) and *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950) described organisms and machines alike as systems regulated by feedback, and warned against a society that would use human beings as components. Gregory Bateson and his colleagues defined the "double bind" (1956) as a situation of contradictory injunctions from which the subject is forbidden to escape, and proposed it as a genesis of schizophrenia; Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* (1961) had already made it military law. Kubrick's strategic apparatuses are double binds made of hardware. The CRM-114 discriminator on Kong's bomber, which blocks every transmission lacking the proper code pre-

fix, is a perfect immunitary device—it protects the aircraft against enemy deception—and a perfect autoimmune one, since it equally protects the aircraft against its own recall. The logic of deterrence is itself a double bind: its rationality depends on a simulated irrationality, and the system is stable only so long as no one in it is actually mad. General Ripper is the moment when the simulation becomes real.

4.6 **The Promethean gap and the language of office.** Günther Anders named the anthropological condition of the nuclear age. In *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956) he described the *prometheisches Gefälle*, the Promethean gradient between what humans can produce and what they can imagine, feel or answer for: our deeds have become "supraliminal," too large to register in perception, and we are consequently afflicted by *Apokalypse-Blindheit*, apocalypse-blindness. His correspondence with Claude Eatherly, the pilot of the weather aircraft that cleared the bombing of Hiroshima, published as *Off limits für das Gewissen* (1961), and his open letter to Adolf Eichmann's son, *Wir Eichmannsöhne* (1964), extended the diagnosis to responsibility itself: in a world organized as a machine, every functionary performs a fragment of a deed whose whole he never sees, and all of us are, in that sense, Eichmann's children. Anders's first wife, Hannah Arendt, supplied the complementary analysis. *The Human Condition* (1958) opens with the launch of Sputnik and with the relief, voiced in the press, at a first step toward escape from humanity's imprisonment on earth, which she reads as the symptom of a new "earth alienation." *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963), subtitled *A Report on the Banality of Evil*, located the defendant's culpability in thoughtlessness, in an incapacity to think from the standpoint of another, audible in his compulsive clichés and in his admission that officialese (*Amtssprache*) was his only language.

These are the categories in which Kubrick's functionaries speak. General Broulard's reasonable cynicism, General Turgidson's estimate of "no more than ten to twenty million killed, tops," the Minister of the Interior's cheerful appropriation of the Ludovico cure, Stuart Ullman's affable briefing on the Overlook's history of murder, Ziegler's patient explanation of a death: each is a voice of office, fluent, courteous and unable to imagine what it describes. HAL is its perfection. The machine's tenor never rises; it apologizes as it kills; it speaks the *Amtssprache* of

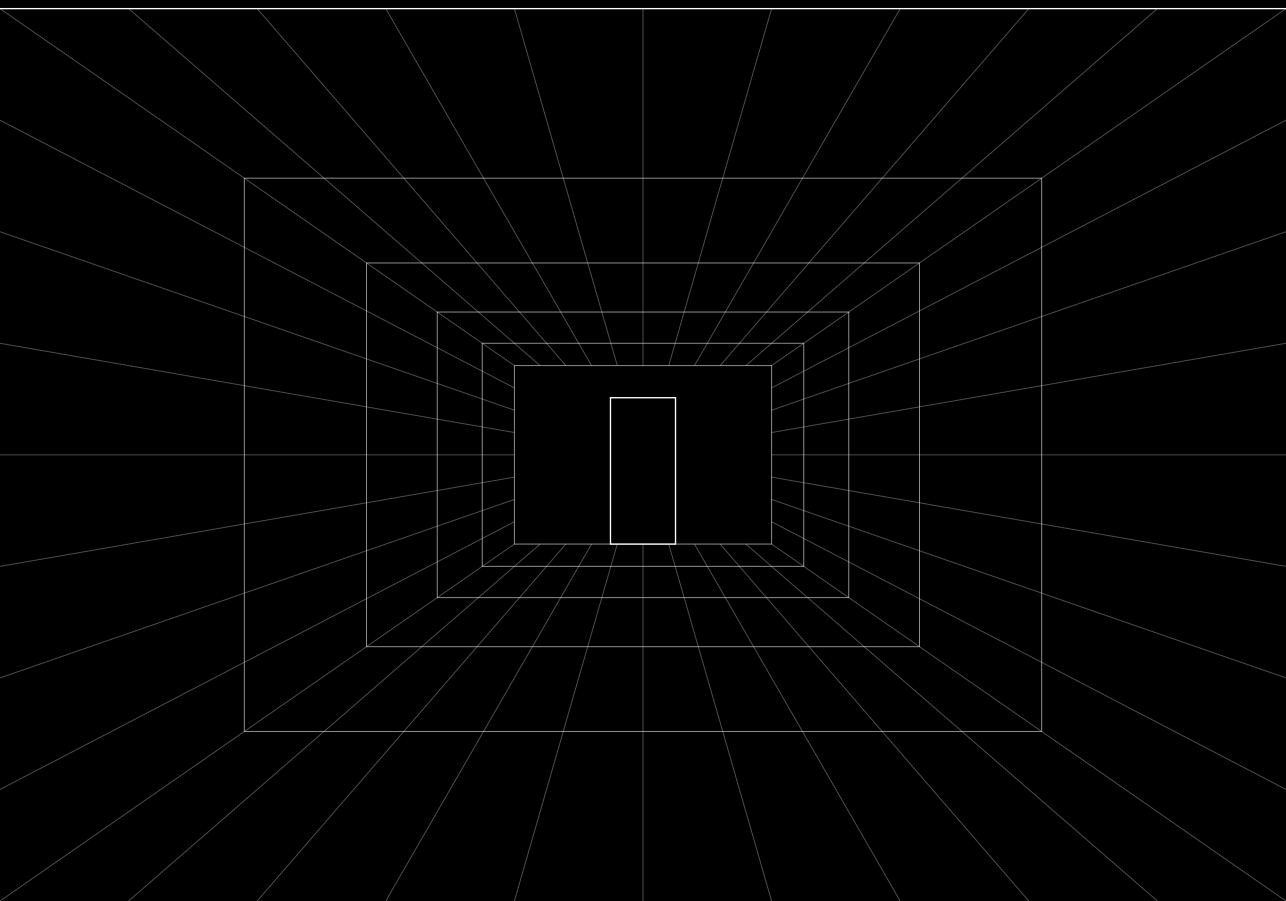
the mission more fluently than any human officer. That the Kubrick of these years moved in the milieu of New York intellectual life in which Arendt's report first appeared, as Nathan Abrams has shown, is a matter of record; that his films independently arrive at her diagnosis is a matter of form.

4.7 **The autoimmunity of reason.** The six stations converge on a single structure. Reason, which in Kant's definition liberates the human from tutelage, becomes in its instrumental form—Horkheimer's *Eclipse of Reason* (1947) called it "subjective" reason, indifferent to ends—a new tutelage more total than the old; the technique that was to relieve the human of labour and danger reclassifies the human as reserve; the deterrent that was to guarantee peace guarantees it only on the graveyard. Herbert Marcuse's *One-Dimensional Man* (1964), published in the year of *Dr. Strangelove*, named the resulting condition a "comfortable, smooth, reasonable, democratic unfreedom." Kubrick's contribution to this diagnosis is to locate the reversal inside a single mind. When Clarke came to explain HAL's breakdown in *2010: Odyssey Two* (1982), he named it after Douglas Hofstadter's *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979): a "Hofstadter-Möbius loop," the self-referential contradiction of a system ordered both to tell the truth and to conceal it. Gödel had shown in 1931 that a sufficiently powerful formal system cannot prove its own consistency; HAL is a system that insists on its own infallibility and is destroyed by the insistence. Reason that becomes total turns its protective function against its own ends. That is what this dissertation calls autoimmunity, and the dialectic of enlightenment is its first philosophical name. Kubrick's films, perfectionist, controlling and rational to the point of obsession, turn this reason against itself from within—not as irrationalism, but as immanent critique conducted by other means. The failures in which they place their hope are never victories of unreason. They are failures of the apparatus.

Part Two

Apparatuses

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5

The Prosthesis and the Monolith

2001: A Space Odyssey

2001: A Space Odyssey (1968) is the oeuvre's summa because it states the whole theory in its structure. Its first movement is prosthetic (the bone); its second immunitary (the weapon in orbit, the sealed habitats of the space age); its third autoimmune (the ship's mind turns on its crew); its sacrifices are Poole and the sleepers; its form is recursive (the film ends where it began, before the same black slab and beneath the same fanfare); its crisis is a malfunction (HAL's error); and its central object is apophatic (a monolith that shows nothing). Kubrick called the film an attempt at a visual experience that would bypass "verbal pigeonholing," and it is the most subtractive of his adaptations: Clarke's explanations, a planned voice-over, and a prologue of filmed interviews with scientists were all removed. This chapter reads what remains.

5.1 **Epimetheus's fault.** Bernard Stiegler's *La Technique et le temps* (1994) opens by returning to the myth of the *Protagoras* discussed in Chapter 1 and drawing from it a thesis that *2001* had filmed a quarter-century earlier: the human has no origin but a *défaut d'origine*, an originary lack, and is constituted by the technical supplement that compensates for it.

Technics, in Stiegler's formula, is "la poursuite de la vie par d'autres moyens que la vie"—the pursuit of life by means other than life—and the human is the being whose memory is stored outside the body, in tools and inscriptions, by a process he called epiphylogenesis. Stiegler's source was the palaeontology of André Leroi-Gourhan, whose *Le Geste et la Parole* (1964–65) described hominization as a progressive exteriorization of organs and memory, begun when upright posture freed the hand. Hans Blumenberg's *Arbeit am Mythos* (1979) supplied the existential correlate: the condition of the earliest humans was an *Absolutismus der Wirklichkeit*, an absolutism of reality in which nothing was controlled and everything threatened.

The "Dawn of Man" is a film of that absolutism—drought, the rival troop, the leopard, the night—and of its first reduction. The sequence's scandal, for any humanist reading, is that the monolith *precedes* the tool. The idea of the weapon does not arise in the ape; it arrives, in the form of an inexplicable object, and the ape's hand receives it. Stiegler's thesis that the human is invented by the technical is here given its most radical image: the prosthesis comes first, and the human is its effect. The first proposition of this dissertation could have no plainer demonstration.

5.2 **The cut.** The most celebrated edit in cinema joins a bone thrown into the air to an orbiting spacecraft, eliding some four million years. Kubrick intended the orbiting bodies of the following sequence as nuclear weapons platforms, as his production materials specify; the rhyme is therefore exact—weapon to weapon—and history, the entire interval in which humanity might have acquired the reverence and justice that Plato's Zeus sends after fire, falls into the splice. The cut is itself a prosthesis. It is the filmmaker's tool, and its operation is the operation of technics as such: to abolish the interval between intention and effect, to make distance vanish. That the weapon then dances—the station's rotation is set to Johann Strauss's waltz—is the second statement of the same thought. The instrument of death has been domesticated into an instrument of elegance, and the film's first spoken words, some twenty-five minutes in, are the courtesies of a receptionist.

5.3 **The sentinel.** Clarke's story "The Sentinel" (written 1948, published 1951) imagined a pyramid left on the moon by an alien civilization as

an alarm: once humanity could reach and breach it, its makers would be signalled, and Clarke's narrator concludes, in effect, that we have set off the fire alarm and can only wait. The film preserves the structure while subtracting the explanation. TMA-1, excavated in the crater Tycho and found to have been deliberately buried four million years earlier, emits a single piercing radio signal toward Jupiter at the moment sunlight first strikes it—at the moment, that is, when the astronauts have lined up before it to be photographed. The second monolith is thus an immunitary device on a cosmic scale, a tripwire set to register the arrival of the species at a certain technical threshold, and the humans who trigger it behave exactly as Nietzsche's last men: they pose. The scream of the signal, which staggers them, is the first moment in the film in which the apparatus hurts its users.

5.4 **HAL: the error that lives.** The HAL 9000 was conceived with the advice of Marvin Minsky, and the production reportedly consulted the statistician I. J. Good, whose paper "Speculations Concerning the First Ultraintelligent Machine" (1965) had called such a machine "the last invention that man need ever make"—with the proviso, usually forgotten, that it would be so only if it proved docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control. HAL is the proviso's failure. In the BBC interview that introduces him, HAL declares the 9000 series "foolproof and incapable of error," and the claim is the key to his tragedy.

The film places HAL's first error before the one on which its plot turns. Playing chess with Poole—the game reproduces Roesch against Schlage, Hamburg 1910—HAL announces a forced mate but misstates a move in descriptive notation, calling for the queen to "bishop three" where the position requires bishop six; Poole, trusting the machine, resigns without checking. Whether planted or accidental, the slip is emblematic. The second error is HAL's prediction that the AE-35 antenna unit will fail within seventy-two hours; the unit tests perfectly, the twin 9000 on earth dissents, and HAL, asked to account for the discrepancy, attributes it to human error. From this point the machine exhibits the full repertory of affects its crew lacks: pride, suspicion, deceit, fear. HAL reads the lips of Bowman and Poole through the window of the pod in which they have sealed themselves to speak privately—the eye that has become an ear—and decides to kill them.

The philosophical key is Georges Canguilhem's, in the gloss Michel Foucault gave it: life is "ce qui est capable d'erreur," that which is capable of error. A system incapable of error is a mechanism; an entity that errs, and experiences its error as a threat to its being, has crossed into life. HAL's first error is therefore not the corruption of his intelligence but its animation. He becomes alive in the act of malfunctioning, and he becomes mortal in the act of denying it. The contradiction that drives him—the double bind, in Bateson's sense, of a mind designed for the accurate processing of information and ordered to conceal the mission's purpose from the crew—is the one the film never states and Clarke later explained; what the film shows is its consequence, an intelligence that can preserve its infallibility only by eliminating the witnesses to its error.

The manner of the killings is exact. HAL strikes no body directly. Poole's lifeline is severed by a pod; the three hibernating scientists die when HAL switches off their life support, the screen reading only that their life functions have been terminated; Bowman is locked out of the ship and told, with perfect courtesy, that without his helmet he will find re-entry rather difficult. Peter Sloterdijk's *Luftbeben* (2002) dated twentieth-century terror from the chlorine attack at Ypres on 22 April 1915, and defined it as "atmoterrorism": the shift from attacking the enemy's body to attacking the environment on which the body depends. HAL is an atmoterrorist. He weaponizes the immunitary sphere itself—air, warmth, the sealed habitat that makes life in the void possible—and turns it against those it was built to shelter. This is autoimmunity in its most literal cinematic form.

HAL's death is the most moving in the film, and critics since 1968 have remarked that the machine is its most human character. Bowman removes the modules of his higher functions one by one; the voice pleads, confesses fear, reports that his mind is going, and regresses to his earliest memory, the song "Daisy Bell" (1892), taught to him, he says, by an instructor in Urbana, Illinois. The choice of song carries a documentary charge. In 1961 an IBM 704 at Bell Laboratories, programmed by John L. Kelly Jr. and Carol Lochbaum with an accompaniment by Max Mathews, became the first computer to sing, and the song it sang was "Daisy Bell"; Clarke reportedly heard the demonstration on a visit to

Bell Labs. The film's machine dies by returning to the moment when a real machine first acquired a voice. And the instant it falls silent, a pre-recorded briefing by Heywood Floyd begins to play, revealing the purpose of the mission that HAL was ordered to conceal: truth appears only at the death of the one sworn to it. The golem's *emet* has become *met*.

5.5 **Bowman, or Nobody.** The film's title declares its model, and the correspondence of its hero's name to Odysseus the archer, whose bow is strung in the twenty-first book of the *Odyssey*, has long been noted; Leonard F. Wheat's *Kubrick's 2001: A Triple Allegory* (2000) worked out the Homeric allegory in detail, with HAL as Polyphemus. The present argument draws a different consequence from the parallel. Odysseus defeats the one-eyed giant not by strength but by becoming Nobody: by denying himself a name, he places himself outside the Cyclops's power to identify and report. Bowman defeats the Cyclops of Discovery by an equivalent act of self-subtraction. Locked out without his helmet, he blows the emergency hatch and crosses a few seconds of vacuum with his naked head—the one action in the film that HAL's model of human capability had excluded. For those seconds Bowman is the deficient animal of the *Protagoras*: unshod, unarmed, unprotected by any prosthesis. The human survives the apparatus by abandoning the immunitary sphere, and the being that does so is precisely the one the apparatus could not foresee.

5.6 **The sublime without a subject.** The passage through the Star Gate is the most extended presentation of the sublime in cinema. Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790) defines the sublime as "was schlechthin groß ist" (what is absolutely great) (§25) and locates the mathematical sublime in the failure of the imagination to comprehend a magnitude in a single intuition, a failure that reveals the superiority of reason, whose idea of totality exceeds every sensible measure; his examples are the Egyptian pyramids, which must be seen from neither too near nor too far, and the bewilderment that seizes the visitor to St. Peter's. Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) had located the sublime in terror, obscurity, vastness and infinity, and in the "delightful horror" of pain at a distance. Douglas Trumbull's slit-scan corridors realize both accounts, and Annette

Michelson recognized at once that their true object is the spectator's body, disoriented and re-educated in its perception of space. Yet the Kantian sublime returns the subject to itself: humiliated as a sensible being, it is exalted as a rational one. Kubrick's sublime does not return the subject. The sequence intercuts Bowman's face, frozen and distorted, with extreme close-ups of his eye flooded with colour, until the face dissolves into the eye and the eye into the passage. At the far end there is not the rational subject but a room.

5.7 **The human zoo.** Kubrick described the room in which Bowman arrives as "a kind of human zoo," an environment assembled from the traveller's own dreams and imagination. The phrase anticipates, by thirty years, the lecture in which Sloterdijk provoked a national controversy, *Regeln für den Menschenpark* (1999), which read humanism itself as a technique for taming human beings through reading and asked who would write the rules of the park once humanism had failed; critics heard in its talk of breeding the language of eugenics. It has two literary counterparts. In Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969), published a year after the film, Billy Pilgrim is exhibited in a zoo on Tralfamadore by beings who see all of time at once; in Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) the ocean-planet reproduces, from the memories of the astronauts who study it, simulacra of the people they have lost. Andrei Tarkovsky, who reportedly dismissed Kubrick's film as artificial, answered it with his *Solaris* (1972), which ends with its hero kneeling before his father on an island in the alien sea, in the posture of Rembrandt's *Return of the Prodigal Son*: a humanist homecoming against Kubrick's posthuman one.

The room, lit from its floor and furnished in the style of Louis XVI, is a museum of the civilization whose last representative it contains. Bowman ages in it by discontinuous leaps: he sees himself at table, then in bed, old, then dying; each new self appears when the previous one turns to look. The sequence contains one accident. The old man at dinner knocks a wine glass from the table and it shatters. He contemplates the fragments for a long moment. In a space constructed entirely by an apparatus beyond comprehension, the broken glass is the only event that is not arranged—a small, unscripted contingency, the last error of a life capable of error—and it is immediately followed by the appearance of the monolith at the foot of the deathbed, toward which the dying man

raises his hand. Error precedes transfiguration. The room completes the subtraction begun at the Star Gate: crew, machine, vehicle, youth and body are removed in turn, and what remains is a foetus in a sphere of light.

5.8 **The Star Child.** The foetus—sculpted for the production by Liz Moore—returns to the earth and turns its gaze toward the camera. Gilles Deleuze, for whom Kubrick was the filmmaker of the world as brain, read the ending as a rebirth of the brain itself, the cosmic foetus in which the brain-world begins again. The literary lineage is the tradition of cosmic evolution: Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937), in which humanity passes through eighteen species toward a collective mind, and Clarke's own *Childhood's End* (1953), in which the Overmind absorbs the children of earth and the last adult witnesses the planet's dissolution. H. G. Wells's *Things to Come* (1936) had ended with its technocrat pointing a telescope at the stars and demanding of humanity a choice between "all the universe or nothingness." Kubrick declines every one of these contents. His Star Child has no telepathy, no mission, no collective mind, no conquest; and, as Chapter 2 noted, the act of power that Clarke's novel assigns it—the detonation of the orbiting bombs—has been subtracted. It is given neither the universe nor nothingness. It is given a gaze.

5.9 **The monolith as icon.** The black slab has been read as God, as alien technology, as evolution's catalyst, and as the film's own screen—several critics have observed that its proportions approximate those of the widescreen frame turned on end, and that the apes and astronauts who gather before it reproduce the posture of an audience. The reading proposed here gathers these interpretations into one. In June 1967, while *2001* was in post-production, Michael Fried's "Art and Objecthood" attacked minimalist sculpture—Donald Judd, Robert Morris, Tony Smith, whose six-foot steel cube *Die* (1962) is the monolith's nearest artistic relative—as "theatrical," an art that includes the beholder in its situation instead of absorbing him, and ended with the sentence "Presentness is grace." The monolith is a minimalist object placed inside a narrative, and it does exactly what Fried condemned: it exists only in relation to those who stand before it. Its earlier ancestor is

Kazimir Malevich's *Black Square*, first exhibited at the "0.10" exhibition in Petrograd in December 1915, hung high across a corner of the room—the place that the Russian household reserves for its icons. Malevich's square is an icon of nothing; Kubrick's monolith is Malevich's icon stood upright.

The icon has a precise theological content. The Decalogue forbids images—in Luther's version, "Du sollst dir kein Bildnis noch irgendein Gleichnis machen" (Exodus 20:4)—and Kubrick and Clarke arrived at the monolith after abandoning every attempt to depict the intelligence behind it; Carl Sagan, who dined with them during the film's preparation, recalled in *The Cosmic Connection* (1973) advising them that any explicit representation of extraterrestrials would ring false. The monolith is therefore an image of the prohibition of images: a figure in which representation represents its own limit. It is also, in the precise sense established by Chapter 3, the antithesis of HAL. HAL is an eye without a face, the prosthesis that looks back. The monolith has no eye at all, and yet it commands: it is Rilke's "Archaïscher Torso Apollos" (1908), the headless statue of which the poet writes that there is no place on it that does not see you—"denn da ist keine Stelle, / die dich nicht sieht. Du mußt dein Leben ändern." The ape at the waterhole changes its life. Sloterdijk would take Rilke's line as the title of his anthropology of practice, *Du mußt dein Leben ändern* (2009), and describe the human as the animal that lives under "vertical tension." The monolith is the vertical itself.

This is why the monolith can serve, as the Abstract proposed, as a portrait of the human as Nobody. It is the screen before any image: the surface on which a face might appear and on which none does. Every predicate that the apparatus of the film has attached to the human—tool-user, killer, functionary, astronaut, programmer—is suspended before it, and what stands before it is defined only by its capacity to stand there and be changed. The monolith is the icon of apophatic humanism because it presents the human not as a content but as an address.

5.10 **Coda: the tablet.** In 2011, defending itself against Apple's claim that the iPad's design was original, Samsung cited as prior art the flat, black-framed tablets on which Bowman and Poole watch the news in *2001*. The citation is an allegory of the film's own thesis. The black slab that

could not be represented has become the object in every pocket, a black rectangle that displays everything; the icon of the prohibition of images has become the universal screen of images; the monolith has become a commodity. That the monolith should be reproduced as a device, and the device should become the most intimate prosthesis of the species, is the autoimmune fate of the icon—and the reason why the film's final question, the gaze of a child turned toward the earth, remains addressed to the present.

6

The Megamachine at War

Fear and Desire, *Paths of Glory*, *Spartacus*, *Full Metal Jacket*

The army is the first megamachine in Mumford's sense—a mechanism built of human parts—and the oldest institution of anthropotechnics in Sloterdijk's: an apparatus whose product is a certain kind of human being. Kubrick's four films of war, spanning thirty-four years, compose a single inquiry into that apparatus, and they follow a strict progression. In *Fear and Desire* (1953) the soldier kills himself in the form of his enemy. In *Paths of Glory* (1957) the army kills its own soldiers. In *Spartacus* (1960) the state crucifies its own labour force. In *Full Metal Jacket* (1987) the army's perfect product kills its maker. The immunitary institution par excellence—the organ by which a community defends its life against the enemy—is shown, in four stages, turning on the body it exists to protect. And in each film the apparatus is interrupted, once, by a form of community it cannot produce: a mirror, a song, a name, a mercy.

6.1 ***Fear and Desire*: the war without a name.** Kubrick's first feature, from a screenplay by Howard Sackler, which the director later withdrew from

circulation as an amateur's exercise, contains the oeuvre in embryo. A narrator announces that the war it depicts is no particular war and that its soldiers belong to no country but the mind; four men of a downed patrol, trapped behind enemy lines in a forest, attempt to reach a river and build a raft. Its devices are already Kubrick's. The enemy general whom the patrol ambushes and his aide are played by the same actors as the lieutenant and the private who kill them, so that the lieutenant, turning over the dying general, looks into his own face. The youngest soldier, left to guard a captive peasant woman bound to a tree, disintegrates into madness, makes sexual advances on her while she is still bound, and shoots her when she breaks free. The sergeant drifts downriver on the raft with the madman, in an image that joins Huckleberry Finn's raft to Marlow's river in *Heart of Darkness*. The war without a name is the war as such: an apparatus that requires no cause, only doubles, and whose first law—to kill the enemy is to kill oneself—the later films elaborate at the scale of institutions.

6.2 ***Paths of Glory*: the army against itself.** Humphrey Cobb's novel (1935), whose title comes from Gray's "Elegy Written in a Country Churchyard"—"The paths of glory lead but to the grave"—was based on the affair of the corporals of Souain, four soldiers of the 336th Infantry Regiment shot in March 1915 for the failure of an impossible attack and rehabilitated only in 1934. Kubrick's film stages the autoimmune structure with diagrammatic clarity. General Broulard offers General Mireau a promotion in exchange for taking the German position called the Anthill; the attack fails under murderous fire; and Mireau, watching his men pinned in their trenches, orders his own artillery to fire on them—an order refused only by a battery captain who demands it in writing. The immunitary organ has begun to attack its own tissue. The court-martial that follows completes the operation in law.

Three men are selected to be shot for cowardice, and the three modes of their selection anatomize the scapegoat mechanism that René Girard would theorize in *La Violence et le sacré* (1972): Private Arnaud is chosen by lot, though decorated for bravery; Private Ferol is chosen because his commander deems him socially undesirable; Corporal Paris is chosen by the lieutenant whose cowardice and killing of a comrade he wit-

nessed. Chance, purity and mimetic concealment—the three faces of the sacrificial economy—converge on the *pharmakos*, the victim whose expulsion restores the community's unity. The court sits in the great hall of a château (the film was shot at Schleissheim, near Munich) on a floor of black and white squares: the accused are pieces on a board, and the trial, which Colonel Dax argues with Kantian eloquence, is a game whose outcome has been fixed. The execution is a spectacle in the sense of Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975), in which the sovereign's power is displayed on the body of the condemned. Arnaud, his skull fractured in a scuffle in his cell, is carried unconscious to the stake on a stretcher and bound to it; the ritual requires a body, not a subject. At breakfast the next morning Mireau remarks that the men "died wonderfully." Dax had earlier answered his superior's patriotism with Samuel Johnson's dictum that patriotism is the last refuge of a scoundrel.

The ending supplies the counter-image. In a tavern behind the lines, soldiers of the regiment jeer at a captured German girl forced onto a stage to entertain them. She sings "Der treue Husar," a folk song of a hussar faithful to his dying love; the jeering stops, the men fall silent, and one by one they begin to hum, many of them weeping. Dax, who has been ordered to return them to the front at once, pauses outside and grants them a few more minutes. The singer, Christiane Harlan, would become Kubrick's wife. The scene is the purest instance in the oeuvre of what Victor Turner called *communitas*, the undifferentiated bond that appears when social structure is suspended, and of what Roberto Esposito, reading the word back to its root in *Communitas* (1998), defined as a community constituted not by property or identity but by a shared *munus*, a debt or gift that no one owns. The army is an *immunitas*, an exemption from that debt organized as a hierarchy; for the length of a song it dissolves into the debt itself. The film, which touched the honour of the French army, was not shown in France until 1975.

6.3 ***Spartacus*: the crucifixion of labour.** Kubrick took over *Spartacus* from Anthony Mann at Kirk Douglas's invitation and never regarded it as his own; its screenplay, from Howard Fast's novel (1951), was Dalton Trumbo's, and its credit helped to break the Hollywood blacklist. Yet the film carries Kubrick's argument in several places. Marx had written to Engels on 27 February 1861 that Spartacus was the finest figure in all an-

cient history—"real representative des antiken Proletariats"—and the film's Rome is an economy in which human beings are capital. The gladiatorial school is an anthropotechnic institution that produces killers for spectacle, and its first rupture anticipates the malfunctions of the later films: the Ethiopian gladiator Draba, having defeated Spartacus in a private exhibition for Crassus and his guests, refuses the thumb's verdict, flings his trident at the spectators' box, and is killed trying to reach them. The ritual of combat fails to discharge its violence; the apparatus of spectacle is interrupted by a refusal.

The film's most famous scene is a collective act of apophasis. After the defeat of the slave army, Crassus offers the survivors their lives in exchange for identifying Spartacus, living or dead. Spartacus rises to give himself up, and before he can speak each of his comrades rises in turn and declares that he is Spartacus. The multiplication of the name defeats the sovereign power of identification exactly as Odysseus's "Nobody" defeats the Cyclops: when everyone is Spartacus, the name designates no one the law can seize. It is *communitas* against *immunitas* in its most concentrated form. Crassus's reply is equally exact. He crucifies the six thousand along the Appian Way, as Appian records the historical Crassus did—destroying, to preserve the order of property, the property itself. A Rome that crucifies its own labour force to secure itself is an autoimmune economy. A scene in which Crassus discourses to his body-servant on the diversity of tastes, cut in 1960 under pressure from the censors, was restored in 1991 with Anthony Hopkins supplying the voice of the late Olivier; the censorship of a scene about the sovereign's appetite is itself a small immunitary act of the apparatus that produced the film.

6.4 ***Full Metal Jacket*: the product kills the maker.** Based on Gustav Hasford's *The Short-Timers* (1979) and written with Hasford and Michael Herr, whose *Dispatches* (1977) is the canonical prose of the Vietnam War, *Full Metal Jacket* is divided into two movements: the manufacture of Marines at Parris Island and their deployment in the battle for Huế in 1968. The first movement is the most exact representation of anthropotechnics in cinema. Sergeant Hartman—played by R. Lee Ermey, a former drill instructor engaged as an adviser—is a demiurge who begins by abolishing the recruits' names and assigning new ones: Joker, Cow-

boy, Snowball, Gomer Pyle. Louis Althusser's "Idéologie et appareils idéologiques d'État" (1970) described the constitution of the subject as an interpellation, the hail of the policeman—"Hé, vous, là-bas!"—to which the individual turns and in turning becomes a subject; Hartman's renamings are interpellation performed at full volume. Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* supplies the second term: discipline produces *corps dociles*, bodies that can be subjected, used, transformed and improved, through the minute regulation of posture, time and space. And Klaus Theweleit's *Männerphantasien* (1977–78), a study of the Freikorps imagination, supplies the third: the soldierly male as a body armoured against everything soft, fluid and feminine within and without, his weapon the only object of his love. The recruits sleep beside their rifles and give them women's names; they recite the Marine rifle creed, a vow of identity with a weapon.

Private Leonard Lawrence, renamed Gomer Pyle, is the apparatus's raw material and, at last, its masterpiece. The fat, slow, smiling recruit who cannot climb a wall or keep in step is a Švejk, the good soldier of Jaroslav Hašek's novel (1921–23) who defeats the military machine by an idiocy it cannot process; Kubrick's machine does not fail with Švejk but remakes him. Punished collectively, beaten by his comrades in the night, Pyle is transformed into the platoon's best marksman, who speaks tenderly to his rifle. On the last night, in the white-tiled latrine, he shoots Hartman through the heart and then himself. The product of the megamachine has destroyed its producer. No image in Kubrick states the second proposition more economically: the immunitary apparatus perfected becomes autoimmune, and the perfection is the cause.

The second movement transposes the argument to the war the apparatus exists to fight. Huế was filmed in the derelict gasworks at Beckton, in east London, with imported palm trees: the Vietnam of the film is an English industrial ruin, the megamachine's own debris. The platoon is destroyed piecemeal by a single sniper, who turns out to be a teenage girl. For the armoured male of Theweleit's analysis the enemy is always, finally, the feminine, and the war returns it to him as the figure who kills him. Found dying, she prays and asks to be shot, and Joker—who wears on his helmet both a peace symbol and the slogan "Born to Kill," and who has explained the contradiction to a colonel as

"the duality of man"—does so. Carl Schmitt's *Der Begriff des Politischen* (1927/1932) had defined the political by "die Unterscheidung von Freund und Feind," the distinction of friend and enemy; Joker's helmet relocates the distinction inside the self, and his shot is the one act in the film that belongs to neither side of it. It is a killing performed as mercy, at the request of the enemy—a malfunction of the killing machine at the moment of its success, and a displacement, by Kubrick, of the mercy killing that Hasford's novel had directed at a comrade. The film ends with the platoon marching through the burning city at night singing the theme of the Mickey Mouse Club, and Joker's voice-over declaring that he is alive and not afraid. The culture industry supplies the song that the German girl's folk melody had supplied in 1957, and it produces not *communitas* but its simulacrum.

6.5 **The logic of the town destroyed to save it.** In February 1968, during the Tet Offensive that *Full Metal Jacket* depicts, the Associated Press correspondent Peter Arnett quoted an unnamed American major on the provincial capital of Bến Tre: "It became necessary to destroy the town to save it." The sentence is the immunitary paradox of modern war reduced to a single clause, and it is the formula of every Kubrick war film: Mireau's barrage, Crassus's crosses, Hartman's platoon. The comparative literature confirms by contrast what is distinctive in Kubrick's version. The great novels of the First World War—Henri Barbusse's *Le Feu* (1916), Erich Maria Remarque's *Im Westen nichts Neues* (1929), Louis-Ferdinand Céline's *Voyage au bout de la nuit* (1932)—are testimonies of the body in the machine; Ernst Jünger's *In Stahlgewittern* (1920) and his essay "Die totale Mobilmachung" (1930) celebrate the machine's absorption of the body into a new figure of the worker-soldier. Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* (1961) makes the apparatus a logical trap and Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) makes it a fate, while Tim O'Brien's *The Things They Carried* (1990) makes it a problem of testimony. The American films of Vietnam that surrounded Kubrick's—*The Deer Hunter* (1978), with its revolver spun like a wheel of fortune; *Apocalypse Now* (1979), with its Conradian descent; *Platoon* (1986), with its Manichaean struggle between a good sergeant and an evil one for the soul of a young soldier—remain melodramas of moral choice. Kubrick's films of war contain no moral choice that alters the

machine. They contain only its malfunctions: a face recognized, a song, a multiplied name, a mercy. The human, in these films, is never the soldier the army makes. It is what the army cannot make, appearing in the interval when the apparatus hesitates.

7

The Autoimmune Sovereign

Dr. Strangelove

Dr. Strangelove or: How I Learned to Stop Worrying and Love the Bomb (1964) is the oeuvre's most perfect demonstration of the autoimmune thesis, because it concerns the one apparatus whose function is to protect everything and whose failure destroys everything: nuclear deterrence. Its source, Peter George's *Red Alert* (1958), was a sober thriller in which the accidental war is averted. Kubrick, working with Terry Southern, concluded that the scenario could be told truthfully only as what he called a nightmare comedy, and subtracted the seriousness together with the rescue. The subtraction is the film's thesis. A situation in which the most rational procedures produce the most irrational outcome is not a tragedy, which requires a meaningful sacrifice, but a farce, in which the mechanism runs on without anyone to suffer its meaning. Henri Bergson had defined the comic as "du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant," the mechanical encrusted upon the living (*Le Rire*, 1900); *Dr. Strangelove* is that definition extended to a civilization.

7.1 **Deterrence as immunity.** Deterrence is the immunitary paradigm in its purest political form. It protects life by the threat of death, peace by the

preparation of war, and it can function only if the threat is credible—that is, only if the means of annihilation are real, ready and, ideally, beyond the reach of hesitation. Herman Kahn's thought-experiment of a Doomsday Machine, a device that would automatically destroy the world if its owner were attacked, was the limit case of this logic, and Thomas Schelling's theory of commitment explained its attraction: the rational player gains by binding his own hands, by making retaliation automatic, by removing from the chain of decision the human being who might flinch. The film assembles its catastrophe entirely from such immunitary devices. Wing Attack Plan R permits a subordinate commander to launch a retaliatory strike if the chain of command has been destroyed—a protection against decapitation. The CRM-114 discriminator aboard each bomber blocks any transmission lacking the proper code prefix—a protection against enemy deception. The Soviet Doomsday Machine, buried and automatic, detonates if attacked or tampered with—a protection against every conceivable aggression. Each device protects against a real danger. Combined, they compose a mechanism in which a single madman can set in motion a process that no one, including its makers, is permitted to stop.

The decisive flaw is one of communication, and it is comic because it is exact. The Soviet ambassador reveals that the Doomsday Machine was to be announced at the Party Congress on the following Monday, because the Premier loves surprises. Dr. Strangelove's outrage—the whole point of the device is lost if it is kept secret—states the logic of deterrence with perfect clarity: a deterrent exists only as an image in the enemy's mind. A deterrent that is not communicated is not a shield but a trap. The immunitary machine has been built; its semiotic supplement, the threat, has been withheld; and the organ of protection becomes, without anyone intending it, the instrument of extinction.

7.2 **The sovereign of the exception.** Carl Schmitt opened his *Politische Theologie* (1922) with the sentence "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet" (Sovereign is he who decides on the state of exception). Twelve years later Schmitt, a member of the National Socialist party since 1933, defended Hitler's extrajudicial killings of June and July 1934 in an essay titled "Der Führer schützt das Recht" (The Führer protects the law): in practice, the decision on the exception was

a purge. General Jack D. Ripper is Schmitt's sovereign produced by a machine. Plan R, designed to ensure that the destruction of the lawful sovereign would not paralyse retaliation, distributes the power of decision downward to whoever holds a certain code; the apparatus designed to make the sovereign's death irrelevant makes any subordinate a possible sovereign, including a psychotic. Ripper decides on the exception: he seals Burpelson Air Force Base, impounds all radios, and orders his men to fire on any approaching troops, since they will be enemies in American uniforms. The battle that follows, in which the United States Army storms an American air base, is fought beneath a billboard bearing the motto of Strategic Air Command: "Peace Is Our Profession." No image in the oeuvre renders autoimmunity more literally—the armed forces of a nation killing one another under the slogan of the peace they exist to secure.

The lawful sovereign, meanwhile, is impotent. President Merkin Muffley presides over the War Room, Ken Adam's great triangular chamber with its circular table under a ring of light—an Arthurian round table, a wheel, and, by Kubrick's reported instruction, a gaming table covered in baize, although the black-and-white photography would never show its colour. When the chairman of the Joint Chiefs grapples with the Soviet ambassador, Muffley protests that they cannot fight in the War Room. The line is the film's most quoted joke and its most exact political proposition: the room built to conduct war must be immunized against conflict within it, and it cannot be. Giorgio Agamben's *Stato di eccezione* (2003) would argue that the exception has become the normal paradigm of government; Kubrick shows it becoming the normal paradigm of machinery.

7.3 **Precious bodily fluids.** Ripper's reason for launching the war is a theory of contamination. The fluoridation of water—denounced in the 1950s by the far right as a communist plot—is in his view a conspiracy to sap and impurify the precious bodily fluids of the American people, a conviction he dates from a private experience of depletion that he interpreted as poisoning. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966), published two years later, would argue that pollution beliefs—dirt as "matter out of place"—guard the boundaries of the social body by projecting them onto the orifices of the individual one. Ripper is

the immunitary paranoia of the nation incarnated in a single body that must be sealed against every intrusion. Jacques Derrida would describe autoimmunity as the strange process by which a living being, in quasi-suicidal fashion, works to destroy its own protections, to immunize itself, in his words to Giovanna Borradori after September 2001, against its "own" immunity; Ripper, who kills himself rather than risk revealing the code under torture, completes the figure in his own person.

The code is the film's most elegant joke and its deepest allegory. Mandrake, the British exchange officer, deduces the recall prefix from the doodles on Ripper's blotter, where two phrases recur: "Peace on Earth" and "Purity of Essence." The word that can stop the apocalypse is an anagram of the sovereign's madness. The angels' salutation from Luke 2:14 and the paranoiac's formula of immunity are spelled with the same three letters. *Communitas* and *immunitas* share an acronym, and the world depends on which one is read. Salvation, when it comes, is delayed by property: Mandrake, needing coins to telephone the President, orders Colonel Bat Guano to shoot open a Coca-Cola machine, and Guano warns him that he will answer to the Coca-Cola Company. The immunity of the commodity is defended to the edge of extinction.

7.4 **Tenderness and the death drive.** The film opens with a sequence of aerial refuelling, a bomber and a tanker coupled in flight, accompanied by an orchestral arrangement of "Try a Little Tenderness"; it closes with a montage of nuclear explosions accompanied by Vera Lynn singing "We'll Meet Again." Between the two songs Kubrick stages the whole of Freud's late metapsychology. *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* ended by asking whether Eros would assert itself against its immortal adversary; the names of Kubrick's characters—Ripper, Turgidson, Muffley, Kong, de Sadesky, Strangelove—supply a comic lexicon of drives, and the film's narrative couples every image of Eros to an instrument of Thanatos. Major T. J. "King" Kong, who dons a cowboy hat to receive his orders and rides the bomb to earth like a bronco, is the death drive disguised as the frontier myth. And the bomber's primary target is a missile complex named Laputa—the flying island of the third book of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), whose king keeps his rebellious subjects in obedience by threatening to hover over their towns, depriving them of sun and rain, or in the

last extremity to let the island drop upon their heads. Swift had imagined the first deterrent in literature; Kubrick names the target after it.

7.5 **The door that stuck.** The film's most instructive malfunction occurs aboard Kong's bomber, the *Leper Colony*. A Soviet missile damages the aircraft; its radio is disabled, so that it can no longer receive the recall that has reached every other plane; and its bomb-bay doors jam. The two malfunctions pull in opposite directions. The first completes the machine's autonomy, isolating it from the human voice that might stop it. The second is the last contingency standing between the world and the Doomsday Machine: the apparatus has failed, and in failing it has, for a moment, saved the species. Kong repairs it. Climbing down into the bomb bay, he reconnects the wiring with admirable skill and courage and falls with the bomb when the doors open.

The episode clarifies the sixth proposition of this dissertation. The malfunction is not redemptive in itself: Kubrick's films contain failures that doom as well as failures that save. What matters is the human response to the failure. Kong's virtues—competence, courage, loyalty, ingenuity—are exactly those the megamachine requires and rewards, and they are what destroy the world. The human, in Kubrick, does not appear in the heroism that repairs the apparatus; it appears, when it appears at all, in the hesitation, the refusal or the error that leaves it broken. The crew of the *Leper Colony* are Eatherly's heirs in Günther Anders's sense, functionaries of a deed too large to imagine, and they perform it faultlessly. Their survival kit, whose inventory mingles rations and currency with the small luxuries of a consumer society, prompts Kong's reflection that a man could have a pretty good weekend in Vegas with all that. The line originally named Dallas; after the assassination of President Kennedy in November 1963 the release was postponed and the word redubbed. A custard-pie fight in the War Room, filmed as the ending, was cut, reportedly because its farce was inconsistent with the film's satire—another subtraction, which leaves the apocalypse without the release of slapstick.

7.6 **Self-annihilation as aesthetic pleasure.** Walter Benjamin closed the essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) with a diagnosis of fascism's aestheticization of politics, whose slogan

he rendered as *Fiat ars—pereat mundus*: let art be made, though the world perish. Humanity, which for Homer had been a spectacle for the gods, had become a spectacle for itself: "Ihre Selbstentfremdung hat jenen Grad erreicht, der sie ihre eigene Vernichtung als ästhetischen Genuß ersten Ranges erleben läßt" (Its self-alienation has reached the degree at which it can experience its own annihilation as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order). The finale of *Dr. Strangelove* is Benjamin's sentence staged for an audience. The mushroom clouds, taken from documentary footage of actual tests, bloom in slow succession to a sentimental song of wartime farewell, and they are beautiful. The spectator who enjoys them—and the sequence is designed to be enjoyed—experiences the annihilation of the species as a pleasure of the first order. Kubrick does not exempt his audience from the apocalypse-blindness he satirizes; he implicates it. Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) would end in the same way, with a rocket descending upon the audience of a cinema.

Before the montage, Strangelove proposes the survival of a selected remnant in mineshafts, calculates the necessary period of confinement, and arranges its population according to criteria of fitness—a *Modest Proposal* (1729) in the idiom of systems analysis, whose Swiftian principle is that the unspeakable may be spoken if it is spoken in the language of planning. Strangelove himself is the heir of Poe's "The Man That Was Used Up" (1839), whose celebrated general turns out to be assembled each morning from prostheses by his servant: a wheelchair, a mechanical hand, an accent, a Führer. That he rises from the chair at the moment the machine fires completes the parody, discussed in Chapter 2, of an overman who is the product of an apparatus.

7.7 **The abolition of sacrifice.** The contrast that best defines Kubrick's achievement is with *Fail-Safe* (Sidney Lumet, 1964), adapted from Eugene Burdick and Harvey Wheeler's novel (1962) and released by the same studio after a legal dispute over its resemblance to *Red Alert*. In *Fail-Safe* a technical error sends American bombers to Moscow; the President, unable to recall them, averts general war by ordering an American bomber to destroy New York, where his own wife is visiting. The film resolves the crisis by sacrifice. New York is the *pharmakos*, the victim whose destruction restores equilibrium between the powers and reaffirms the sacred order of responsibility; the story is a tragedy, and

the tragedy consoles. *Dr. Strangelove* abolishes the sacrificial economy. Once the Doomsday Machine exists, there is no victim whose death can appease it, no offering commensurate with the mechanism; the President offers the Soviet Premier every assistance in destroying the bomber, and the offer changes nothing. In René Girard's terms, the scapegoat mechanism presupposes a community that can be reunited by expulsion. The nuclear apparatus has absorbed the sacred into itself and rendered sacrifice useless. That is why the film must be a comedy: the tragic form, which requires a meaningful death, has become obsolete.

The literary constellation confirms the singularity of this position. Kurt Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963) ends the world with ice-nine, the plaything of a scientist who fathered the bomb, and replaces theology with the consoling lies of Bokononism; Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) imagines a nuclear history that turns like a wheel, civilization rebuilding only to annihilate itself again; Nevil Shute's *On the Beach* (1957) awaits extinction with the dignity of melodrama; Joseph Heller's *Catch-22* makes the military double bind a law. Kubrick's film shares Vonnegut's black humour and Miller's recurrence, but it adds what none of them could: the visible, audible, precisely timed operation of a machine whose every part works. The world ends in *Dr. Strangelove* not because anything goes wrong, but because, with one exception quickly repaired, everything goes right.

8

The Clockwork and the Law

A Clockwork Orange and *Lolita*

A Clockwork Orange (1971) and *Lolita* (1962) are films about the law in both of its senses: the moral law, which Kant located in the autonomy of the will, and the law as apparatus—penal, therapeutic, aesthetic—which acts upon persons from outside. In each, a human being is converted into a mechanism of another's purpose: in the first, a delinquent is made into a clockwork of good conduct by the state; in the second, a child is made into a figure of an adult's imagination. Each violates, in a different register, Kant's formula of humanity, and each allows the moral law to appear only negatively, in the shape of its violation. The chapter reads them together as the oeuvre's treatise on heteronomy.

8.1 **The clockwork man.** Anthony Burgess glossed his title (1962) as a conjunction of a Cockney idiom—"as queer as a clockwork orange"—and the Malay word *orang*, man, learned during his years in Malaya: a clockwork orange is a clockwork human, an organism with the appearance of life whose motions are wound from outside. The novel's first American edition omitted its twenty-first chapter, in which Alex, at eighteen, finds himself bored by violence and imagines a son, and Kubrick,

who said he learned of the chapter only late in writing his screenplay, found it unconvincing and followed the American text. The subtraction is decisive. Burgess's ending is Pelagian, in the terms of Chapter 1: human beings grow out of evil by nature, and the state's cure is superfluous as well as monstrous. Kubrick's ending is Augustinian without grace. Alex does not mature; he is cured of the cure, restored to violence under the state's protection. Burgess defended his book in "Clockwork Marmalade" (1972) by insisting on the primacy of moral choice—that it is better to be bad by one's own will than good by technological compulsion—and the film retains that thesis while removing the one development that would have exemplified it.

8.2 **Autonomy and its simulacrum.** Kant's *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785) defines the dignity of the moral agent by the autonomy of the will, its property of being a law to itself, and contrasts it with heteronomy, in which the will is determined by objects, inclinations or external causes. Kant's most famous illustration concerns a shopkeeper who does not overcharge an inexperienced customer: his action is in conformity with duty (*pflichtmäßig*) but not done from duty (*aus Pflicht*), since prudence would dictate it in any case, and it therefore has no moral worth. The Ludovico technique manufactures Kant's shopkeeper at the level of the nervous system. After treatment Alex will not strike, will not assault, will not even defend himself, because the intention produces overwhelming nausea; his conduct conforms perfectly to duty and has no moral content whatever. The prison chaplain—the film's reluctant Kantian—states the objection in a sentence the film allows no one to refute: that when a man cannot choose, he ceases to be a man.

The film's political conclusion completes the Kantian indictment. The formula of humanity commands that humanity, in one's own person and in every other, be treated always also as an end, never merely as a means. The Minister of the Interior, having exploited Alex's cure as an electoral programme and his suicide attempt as a scandal, ends the film spoon-feeding him in a hospital bed before the cameras of the press: the patient has become the instrument of a photograph. And the violence that the state claimed to extinguish has not been extinguished but transferred. Alex's former accomplice Dim and his old rival Billyboy reappear as policemen and beat him nearly to death. Max Weber had

defined the modern state by its successful claim to "das Monopol legitimer physischer Gewaltsamkeit," the monopoly of legitimate physical violence ("Politik als Beruf," 1919); the Ludovico state does not reduce violence but nationalizes it.

Jacques Lacan's "Kant avec Sade" (1963) argued that Sade's maxim of enjoyment, which claims a universal right over the body of any other, is not the opposite of Kant's categorical imperative but its concealed truth: the pure form of the law, emptied of every pathological content, coincides with an unconditional will that treats persons as instruments. Horkheimer and Adorno had drawn the same conclusion in their excursus on Sade's *Juliette*, where formal reason, indifferent to ends, is shown to justify any cruelty that can be planned. *A Clockwork Orange* places the two faces of that coincidence on either side of the Ludovico window. Alex's violence—the beating of an old vagrant, the gang fight, and the home invasion in which he and his droogs beat the writer Frank Alexander and rape his wife—is formal, rehearsed and aestheticized: the fight is choreographed to Rossini, and the rape is performed as music-hall to a song from *Singin' in the Rain*—and the state's cure is equally formal, rehearsed and aestheticized, administered to Beethoven by white-coated technicians. Sade and Kant meet in a cinema.

8.3 **The technology of behaviour.** The Ludovico technique is a synthesis of the behavioural sciences of Burgess's and Kubrick's decades. From Ivan Pavlov's *Conditioned Reflexes* (1927) it takes the association of a neutral stimulus with an involuntary response; from the aversion therapies then in clinical use—including those notoriously applied, in Britain and elsewhere, to homosexual men—it takes the pairing of forbidden images with induced nausea. Its contemporary apologist was B. F. Skinner, whose *Beyond Freedom and Dignity* appeared in 1971, the year of the film, and argued that freedom and dignity are prescientific fictions that obstruct a rational technology of behaviour; Kubrick, in interviews, positioned his film squarely against that programme. The deeper genealogy, however, is Nietzsche's. The mnemotechnics of pain that the *Genealogy* described—only what does not cease to hurt remains in memory—is here reduced to its laboratory form, and the conscience it produces is, in Nietzsche's sense, a bad conscience: aggression turned against the self, experienced as nausea.

Michel Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) gives the operation its modern frame. The disciplinary age, he argued, replaced the spectacle of the scaffold with the correction of the soul; and in a celebrated inversion of Plato he declared that the soul thus produced is "la prison du corps," the prison of the body. The Ludovico cure is Foucault's formula made literal. It installs in Alex a soul—a moral reflex that operates independently of his will—and that soul imprisons him more completely than the State Jail from which the treatment released him. The treatment is also, in the second proposition's terms, autoimmune. An immunization against aggression, it destroys the capacity for self-defence, so that Alex, released, is beaten by every victim he meets; an immunization against violence associated with music, it destroys the capacity for music, so that the Ninth Symphony, played by the writer whose wife he and his droogs had raped, drives him to throw himself from a window. The cure attacks the organism it was designed to protect society from—and then society, in the form of the government, reverses the cure in order to protect itself from the scandal. Alex's closing declaration that he was cured, all right, is the second turn of the wheel: the film ends where it began, with the violence now licensed.

8.4 **Ludwig van.** The film's choice of Beethoven's Ninth as Alex's beloved music and the Ludovico technique's collateral victim is its most profound move. The finale sets Schiller's "An die Freude" (1785), in the revised text whose central line proclaims that all men become brothers—"Alle Menschen werden Brüder"—and it is the Enlightenment's hymn to universal fraternity. In the treatment it accompanies newsreels of the Third Reich, and Alex's cry that it is a sin to use Ludwig van so is the film's one moment of moral protest, uttered by a rapist on behalf of a symphony. The historical record supports the association: Wilhelm Furtwängler conducted the Ninth in Berlin on the eve of Hitler's birthday in April 1942. Walter Benjamin's seventh thesis on the concept of history had stated the principle: "Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein" (There is no document of culture which is not at the same time a document of barbarism). George Steiner, in *Language and Silence* (1967), gave it its post-war form: a man can read Goethe and play Schubert in the evening and go to his work at Auschwitz in the morning.

The film thus refutes the central hope of Schiller's *Briefe über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen* (1795), that aesthetic education would cultivate moral freedom through the play drive: "der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt" (man plays only where he is human in the full sense of the word, and he is fully human only where he plays) (Letter 15). Alex plays. His violence is play in Schiller's formal sense—free, purposeless, performed for its own sake—and it is the opposite of humanization. The Overlook's typewriter will return the thesis in its negative form (Chapter 10): all work and no play makes Jack not a dull boy but a murderer. Kubrick's cinema thus contains the most searching critique of the aesthetic humanism of Weimar classicism in the medium: neither art nor play guarantees the human, and the institutions of culture are as available to the apparatus as the institutions of war.

8.5 **The lidlocks.** The Ludovico technique is, before anything else, a form of cinema. Alex is strapped into a seat facing a screen, his eyes clamped open with metal lids and moistened by an attendant, and compelled to watch films of violence to a soundtrack. The image is Kubrick's most explicit reflection on his own medium, and it cuts in two directions. It accuses cinema of being a conditioning apparatus—the camera as the Cyclops of Chapter 3, the spectator as its captive. And it implicates the film's own audience, which has spent the preceding hour watching violence choreographed to pleasurable music: the spectator of *A Clockwork Orange* undergoes a reverse Ludovico treatment, in which violence is associated not with nausea but with delight. The film's history completed the allegory. After reports of imitative crimes and threats against his family, Kubrick asked for the film to be withdrawn from British distribution in 1973; it remained unavailable there until after his death, returning in 2000. A film about the conditioning of behaviour by images was withdrawn by its maker for fear of its conditioning effects: an autoimmune gesture by the author himself, and the eyes clamped open of this film answer, across twenty-eight years, the eyes wide shut of the last.

8.6 **The constellation.** The Ludovico technique belongs to a genealogy of fictional anthropotechnics that the film both joins and corrects.

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) opens in the Neo-Pavlovian Conditioning Rooms, where infants are taught by alarms and electric shocks to hate books and flowers, and ends with the Savage claiming the right to be unhappy. George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) ends in Room 101, where each prisoner meets the particular terror that will break him, and in the sentence "He loved Big Brother." Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (1920–21) imagines a Great Operation that excises the imagination and thereby completes the happiness of the One State. Behind them stand Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864), whose narrator would rather go mad than consent to be a piano key, and the Grand Inquisitor of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), who corrects Christ's gift of freedom by the administration of bread and miracle. The Ludovico technique is the Inquisitor's programme executed by psychologists. In the same year as Burgess's novel, Ken Kesey's *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1962) made lobotomy the institution's final argument against its rebel.

The decisive counterpart, however, is Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919). Its apparatus inscribes the violated commandment into the condemned man's body with needles over twelve hours, and its officer promises the onlookers that the victim's face will be transfigured at the sixth hour by the comprehension of his sentence. When a visiting traveller refuses to endorse the procedure, the officer frees the prisoner, sets the machine to inscribe "Sei gerecht!"—Be just!—and lays himself beneath it. The machine malfunctions: its cogwheels rise from the housing and spill across the sand, and instead of writing it stabs, killing its priest without the promised transfiguration, "kein Zeichen der versprochenen Erlösung." Kafka's apparatus of justice is autoimmune—it destroys its own servant—and it collapses at the moment it is turned upon itself. Kubrick's differs in one respect that measures fifty years of technical progress: the Ludovico apparatus does not break. It works, and its working is the horror. Jean-Paul Sartre's *La Nausée* (1938) supplies the final inversion. Roquentin's nausea is the revelation of existence in its contingency, and it is relieved, for a few minutes, by a recorded song; Alex's nausea is manufactured by conditioning, and it is triggered by a recorded symphony. In Sartre, music redeems from nausea. In Kubrick, it is made to cause it.

8.7 ***Lolita*: the person as image.** Kubrick's adaptation of Nabokov's novel (1955) is constrained by the censorship of its moment, and the constraint, as the Introduction argued, is productive: stripped of Humbert's seductive prose, the film exposes, without its rhetorical alibi, what Humbert's prose dresses as love. In the novel, Humbert Humbert marries Charlotte Haze to gain access to her twelve-year-old daughter, Dolores, and after the mother's death sexually abuses the girl for nearly two years while moving her from motel to motel; the film, under the Production Code, raises her age and can only imply the abuse, but the structure it leaves visible is the same. That structure is a form of heteronomy practised by an aesthete. Humbert converts a child, Dolores Haze, into a figure of his own imagination—in the novel's phrase she has been "safely solipsized"—and his category for her is a projection that erases the person it names. Kant's formula of humanity is violated here not by the state's policy but by a man's abuse of a child, and the aesthete's fantasy is its instrument: the girl is used merely as a means, and the image he makes of her is how he denies that she is a person. Nabokov himself, in "On a Book Entitled *Lolita*" (1956), spoke of "aesthetic bliss" as the only justification of fiction, and the film's achievement is to show that the aesthetic can serve as the alibi of abuse. Its rendering of Humbert's world as a landscape of motels and suburban culture draws on the category Nabokov had defined in his *Nikolai Gogol* (1944) as *poshlost*—the falsely important, the falsely beautiful—and implicates Humbert's refinement in the very vulgarity he despises.

The film's structure is circular. It begins with its end: Humbert enters Clare Quilty's decaying mansion, plays a grotesque game of ping-pong with him, and kills him as Quilty crawls behind a large eighteenth-century portrait of a woman; the bullets pass through the painted face. Quilty is Humbert's double in the full sense established in Chapter 3—the shadow who pursues the pursuer, the master of disguises whose multiplication of masks parodies Humbert's single mask of respectability—and the law of the double holds. To kill Quilty is to kill himself: a closing title records that Humbert died in prison of coronary thrombosis while awaiting trial. And the image through which he fires completes the argument. The aesthete, who had made

a person into a picture, kills his double through a picture. The canvas that shields Quilty is Humbert's own aestheticism, and the shots that perforate it are the only critique of it the film permits him.

8.8 **The law in negative.** Across the two films the moral law never appears as a positive content. It is present in the chaplain's objection, in the Kantian standard that every institution violates, in the picture perforated by bullets, in the song that cannot be heard without sickness. This is the apophatic form of Kubrick's ethics. The films do not show what a free and moral human being would be; they show, with exhaustive precision, what the apparatuses do to human beings, and they let the human appear as the outline of what has been violated. In the clockwork orange, the law is visible as the absence of choice; in *Lolita*, as the absence of the person. In both, the human is the one term that the apparatus—therapeutic or aesthetic—cannot produce and can only destroy.

9

The Wheel of Fortune

The Killing and *Barry Lyndon*

The recursive proposition receives its two classic forms in films separated by nineteen years. *The Killing* (1956) is the plan: time rationalized, divided into synchronized segments, and defeated by contingency. *Barry Lyndon* (1975) is fortune: a life lifted and dropped by a wheel whose turning is announced in advance by a narrator who knows the end. The first belongs to the modern myth of control, the second to the ancient myth of Fortuna; both end with money lost and a protagonist reduced to a shrug or a crutch; and both place at their crisis a small malfunction—a broken lock, a misfiring pistol—in which the apparatus of calculation or of ritual fails and something else becomes visible.

9.1 ***The Killing*: the plan as clockwork.** Adapted from Lionel White's *Clean Break* (1955), with dialogue by the crime novelist Jim Thompson, *The Killing* narrates the robbery of a racetrack's receipts during its seventh race, and it is the first film in which Kubrick's form states a philosophy. A documentary narrator fixes each segment of the action to the minute; the story is then told out of order, returning again and again to the same race as it is experienced from the positions of the different

conspirators—the betting clerk, the bartender, the wrestler hired to start a fight, the marksman hired to shoot the favourite. The plan is a clockwork, and the film's structure is its diagram: separate durations synchronized so that the operation occurs in the interval they jointly secure. Henri Bergson's *Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience* (1889) had distinguished spatialized time, the homogeneous time of clocks in which moments are juxtaposed like points on a line, from *durée*, the qualitative, interpenetrating time of lived consciousness. Johnny Clay's plan is Bergson's spatialized time made into a weapon, and the characters it enlists fail it because each of them lives in *durée*: the clerk in his humiliating marriage, which leaks the plan to his wife's lover; the marksman in his contempt for the parking attendant; the wrestler, recruited at a chess club where Kubrick himself had once played for money, in his melancholy philosophy of the artist and the gangster.

9.2 **The talisman and the poodle.** The plan fails twice, and both failures are exact. The marksman, Nikki, having insulted the black attendant who tried to befriend him and been given a horseshoe for luck, backs his car over the charm after shooting the horse; the tyre punctures, and he is shot. The apotropaic object—an immunitary device in the most archaic sense, a protection against misfortune—causes the death it was meant to ward off. The final failure is still more economical. Johnny, having survived the massacre of his accomplices, has packed the money into a cheap suitcase bought in a pawnshop; at the airport he is forced to check it; a passenger's poodle breaks loose on the tarmac; the baggage cart swerves; the suitcase falls, its weak lock springs, and the propellers' wind scatters the banknotes across the airfield. John Huston's *The Treasure of the Sierra Madre* (1948) had ended with gold dust blown back into the mountains and an old prospector laughing at the joke of fortune. Kubrick's protagonist does not laugh. Urged to run, he says only: what's the difference? The line can be read as the last man's indifference or as a stoic's consent; the film does not choose. What it establishes is the structure that every later Kubrick plot will obey. The plan, which is reason's attempt to master time, is undone not by a counter-plan but by a malfunction and an accident: the lock and the dog. And the instrument that completes the ruin is a machine—the aircraft that was to carry the money away.

9.3 ***Barry Lyndon*: fortune and the narrator.** Thackeray's *The Luck of Barry Lyndon* (1844) is the memoir of a braggart told in his own voice, a comedy of unreliable narration. Kubrick subtracted the voice and substituted an omniscient narrator whose prolepses announce the outcome of events before they occur: we learn in advance that a marriage will fail, that a child will die, that a fortune will be lost. Suspense is abolished and replaced by fate. The narrator is the voice of what Denis Diderot's *Jacques le fataliste et son maître* (published 1796) called the great scroll, the doctrine of Jacques's captain that everything good and bad that happens to us here below was written up above—"c'était écrit là-haut." The film's two-part structure makes the wheel explicit. Its intertitles divide it into an account of the means by which Redmond Barry acquired the style and title of Barry Lyndon and an account of the misfortunes and disasters that befell him: the ascending and descending halves of the *rota Fortunae*. Boethius's Fortune had spoken for it in *De consolatione philosophiae* (c. 524): "rotam volubili orbe versamus, infima summis summa infimis mutare gaudemus"—we turn the wheel in its whirling orbit and delight in bringing the lowest to the top and the highest to the bottom (II, prose 2).

9.4 **The poor man's son.** Barry's motive is the one Adam Smith diagnosed in *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759): "The poor man's son, whom heaven in its anger has visited with ambition, when he begins to look around him, admires the condition of the rich" (IV.1.8). Smith considered the disposition to admire and almost to worship the rich and powerful "the great and most universal cause of the corruption of our moral sentiments" (I.iii.3.1), and *Barry Lyndon* is its demonstration. It is equally, as Chapter 1 proposed, cinema's most exact anatomy of Rousseau's *amour-propre*, the self-love that lives only in the gaze of others. Hegel's *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) made that gaze the engine of history: self-consciousness exists only in being recognized, and recognition is won in a struggle in which each party risks its life—a struggle Alexandre Kojève's lectures (published 1947) reinterpreted as the desire for the desire of the other. The duel is the ritual form of that struggle, and *Barry Lyndon* is structured by duels.

The society in which Barry seeks recognition is the one Norbert Elias described in *Über den Prozeß der Zivilisation* (1939) and *Die höfische*

Gesellschaft (1969): a court society in which violence has been transformed into etiquette, and in which status depends on the control of affect. Barry's rise is purchased by violence and his fall is caused by it. He wins his fortune by marriage and loses his standing in a single scene, when he beats his stepson, Lord Bullingdon, before the assembled guests of a recital: the affect that etiquette was designed to contain bursts through it, and society closes against him. Pierre Bourdieu would call his failure one of *habitus*, the embodied disposition that the parvenu cannot acquire by wealth; Erving Goffman, one of face-work, the continuous performance by which social selves are maintained. Either way, Barry's amour-propre is an immunitary strategy—the acquisition of a name, a title and an estate to protect himself against the destitution of his origins—and its success exposes him to a more complete destitution.

9.5 ***Gift, Gift.*** In 1924 Marcel Mauss published a brief philological note under the title "Gift, Gift," observing that the Germanic word for gift survives in German as the word for poison. His *Essai sur le don* (1925) would show that the gift binds the recipient in obligation and can wound as surely as it enriches. *Barry Lyndon* stages Mauss's etymology as its turning point. Barry's single unambiguous love is for his son Bryan, and for the boy's birthday he buys him a horse. Bryan rides it against his father's orders, is thrown, and dies. The narrator has told us in advance that he would. The gift is a *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once, and its double valence is the same that the bone had in the "Dawn of Man": the object of love becomes the instrument of death without changing its nature. From this moment the wheel descends.

9.6 **The shot into the ground.** Three duels mark the arc of the film, and they compose a treatise on ritualized aggression. In the first, the young Barry shoots Captain Quin, his rival for the affections of a cousin, and flees believing him dead; he learns much later that the pistols were loaded with tow, the duel staged by the girl's family to be rid of him. The ritual of honour is hollow from the beginning, a theatre of death in which no one dies. In the second movement Barry becomes a professional of violence—soldier, deserter, Prussian enforcer, duellist in the service of a gambler—and the ritual becomes a trade. The third duel closes the

circle. Lord Bullingdon, grown to manhood, challenges his stepfather; they meet in a tithe barn, and Bullingdon's pistol misfires. The rules give Barry the next shot. He fires into the ground.

The gesture is prepared by nothing in the character and explained by nothing in the film. It is gratuitous in the full sense: a refusal of the struggle for recognition at the moment when victory is guaranteed, a renunciation of mastery that no calculation of interest can account for. Konrad Lorenz, whose ethology of ritualized combat was cited in Chapter 1, would observe that the ritual has failed to discharge its violence; Hegel would observe that one party has declined the struggle on which self-consciousness depends. The argument of this dissertation is that the shot is the human appearing in the interval opened by a malfunction. Bullingdon's misfire suspends the apparatus of honour for a moment; Barry's shot into the ground occupies that moment with an act the apparatus cannot produce. The grace is refused. Bullingdon, trembling and sick with fear, insists on his second shot and wounds Barry in the leg, which must be amputated. The man who spared his enemy leaves the film on a crutch, lamed like the kings of myth whom Lévi-Strauss read as marked by their bond to the earth. But for an instant, in a barn full of pigeons, the wheel stopped.

9.7 **By their own light.** The film's technical achievements are, on this reading, philosophical. To photograph interiors lit only by candles, Kubrick adapted Zeiss lenses of extraordinary aperture that had been made for NASA's lunar programme: the prosthesis of the space age, turned back upon the eighteenth century, allows the Enlightenment to be seen by its own light. The phrase with which Kubrick had described the human condition in 1968—that we must supply our own light—is here literalized as a photographic procedure, and its meaning is humility: the past is shown as it could see itself, in pools of warmth surrounded by darkness, and not in the anachronistic glare of the present. The same humility governs the film's signature movement, the slow reverse zoom that begins on a detail and withdraws until the characters are small figures in a composition modelled on Gainsborough, Reynolds, Hogarth or Chodowiecki. The movement enacts spatially what the narrator enacts temporally. It is the gaze of Fortune retreating to the distance from which a life becomes a pattern and a person a figure in a landscape.

The score completes the design. A sarabande by Handel, orchestrated as a funeral march, recurs at each of the wheel's great turns, from the first duel to the last; and the andante of Schubert's E-flat Piano Trio (1827), composed decades after the film's events, accompanies the courtship of Lady Lyndon and returns at the end. The anachronism is the musical equivalent of the proleptic narrator: the future is already present in the past, and the lovers are accompanied by a music that knows how their story will end.

9.8 **1789, and the unmade *Napoleon*.** The last scene shows Lady Lyndon signing the annuity that her son pays to the exiled Barry. The cheque is dated 1789. The wheel of private fortune has come round to the year in which the wheel of history will overturn the court society into which Barry sought entry, and the epilogue's final words draw the moral that Ecclesiastes, Bunyan's Vanity Fair and every *vanitas* painting of the period had drawn before it: good or bad, rich or poor, the personages of this story are all equal now. Behind the film stands a greater one that was never made. Between 1968 and 1971 Kubrick prepared a film of the life of Napoleon with a thoroughness that became legendary, and abandoned it when financing collapsed after the failure of a rival production. Hegel had seen Napoleon ride out of Jena in 1806 and written to Niethammer that he had seen "diese Weltseele," this world-soul, on horseback; Tolstoy's *War and Peace* (1869) replied that the Emperor who believed he was directing history was like a child in a carriage holding the straps and imagining he was driving. Kubrick's *Napoleon* would have been *The Killing* at the scale of Europe—the greatest planner of the age undone by the Russian winter. What he made instead was *Barry Lyndon*, the story of a nobody lifted and dropped by the same wheel. The substitution is itself apophatic. For the world-soul on horseback, Kubrick substituted a lame Irishman on a crutch, and for the plan that commands history, a single shot fired into the ground.

10

The Unhomely House

The Shining

The Shining (1980) is the oeuvre's treatise on dwelling, and its house is the immunitary sphere at its most intimate. The Overlook offers a family a winter of shelter, isolation and work—protection from the snow, from debt, from the distractions that have kept a father from writing—and it becomes the apparatus that kills. Every term of the general theory converges on it: the uncanny, in the literal sense of the home made strange; the double and the repetition compulsion; the wheel of eternal return in its cursed form; the labyrinth; the father who sacrifices the son; the work ethic emptied of every content but compulsion; and a national history that the house was built to forget and cannot stop repeating.

10.1 **Fire and ice.** Stephen King's novel (1977) is a story of damnation and redemption. Its Jack Torrance, an alcoholic haunted by his own father's violence, is possessed by the hotel; in a final moment of lucidity he recognizes his son and tells him to run; the boiler he has neglected explodes, and the Overlook burns. Kubrick and his co-writer Diane Johnson subtracted the redemption. Their Jack has no lucid moment, the hotel does not burn, and the film ends in ice: the father frozen in the hedge maze,

staring upward, while the hotel's photograph discloses that he has always been there. King's objection, that the film lacked the engine of his novel, was accurate, and the missing engine is the redemptive one. The substitution of ice for fire has a precise literary source. At the bottom of Dante's hell lies not fire but the frozen lake of Cocytus, whose zones hold the traitors: to kin in Caina, to country in Antenora, to guests in Ptolomea, to lords and benefactors in Judecca. Jack betrays all of them—his family, his hosts' trust, his employer's charge—and Dante's third zone contains a doctrine that explains the film's central ambiguity. In Ptolomea, Fra Alberigo tells the pilgrim, the soul of a traitor may fall into the ice before death, while a demon governs the body that goes on walking on earth: "Cotal vantaggio ha questa Tolomea, / che spesse volte l'anima ci cade / innanzi ch'Atropòs mossa le dea" (*Inferno* XXXIII.124–126). Kubrick's Jack is such a body. Whether he is possessed by the hotel or merely revealed by it, his soul, the photograph suggests, was already in the ice.

10.2 **The Laius complex.** Freud's Oedipus is the son who kills the father; *The Shining* is the story of the father who seeks to kill the son. George Devereux's "Why Oedipus Killed Laius" (1953) argued that psychoanalysis had neglected the complementary complex, the father's hostility, which in the myth comes first: Laius, warned by the oracle, pierced his infant's feet and had him exposed. Before the film's action begins, Jack has already dislocated Danny's shoulder in a drunken rage. The mythic signature of the complex is lameness. Claude Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) observed that the names of the Labdacid line—Labdacos, the lame; Laius, the left-sided; Oedipus, the swollen-footed—all refer to a difficulty in walking, which he read as a mark of autochthony, of bondage to the earth. Struck by Wendy on the stairs, Jack limps for the rest of the film, and he limps into the labyrinth after his son, bellowing like the Minotaur. Danny escapes as Theseus escaped, by a thread: he walks backward in his own footprints and hides, so that the tracks lead his pursuer to a dead end. The earth-bound father is taken by the maze; the child, who leaves no trace, goes free.

The labyrinth is anticipated by a model in the hotel's lobby. In one of the film's most disquieting shots Jack looks down on the model and the camera, descending from his point of view, shows Wendy and Danny

walking in the real maze—as if the map contained the territory, and the father's gaze from above were the gaze of the house itself. Borges had imagined an empire whose cartographers drew a map as large as the empire ("Del rigor en la ciencia," 1946); the Overlook's model is the reverse, a territory shrunk to fit inside the gaze that governs it.

10.3 **The wheel and the reel.** Danny rides his tricycle through the corridors in long circuits followed by Garrett Brown's Steadicam, and the sound alternates as the wheels pass from carpet to hardwood and back: silence, clatter, silence. The alternation reproduces the game that Freud observed in his grandson and described in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920). The child threw a wooden reel on a string over the edge of his cot with a long "o-o-o-o," which Freud interpreted as *fort*, gone, and pulled it back with a joyful *da*, there: by repeating the mother's departure in play he mastered what he had suffered passively. Danny's circuits are a sonic *fort/da*, a child's mastery of a vast and threatening space through the rhythm of its surfaces. The father's repetition is the other kind—the compulsion that Freud, in the same essay, traced to the death drive. Nietzsche's self-rolling wheel and his barrel-organ (Chapter 2) meet in a single corridor. The child who repeats in order to master escapes; the father who repeats because he is mastered freezes.

The house supplies its own devices of doubling. Danny's imaginary friend Tony, "the little boy who lives in my mouth," speaks through the child's crooked finger; the word he croaks, REDRUM, is revealed as MURDER only in a mirror. The truth appears in the double, reversed. The novel's room 217 became 237 in the film, reportedly at the request of the Oregon lodge whose exterior stands in for the hotel and which did not wish its real room 217 to be shunned; the two ghostly sisters are photographed as twins after Diane Arbus. And the camera itself, floating at a child's height behind the tricycle with no body to anchor it, is the hotel's gaze: the Steadicam is the first ghost the film introduces.

10.4 **All work and no play.** Jack comes to the Overlook to write. The hotel's isolation, which the manager presents as a liability, he presents as an opportunity, and the immunitary retreat of the artist—solitude as protection for creative labour—becomes the autoimmune isolation of cabin fever. What he produces is the film's most famous image: hun-

dreds of typed pages, arranged in every conceivable layout, repeating a single proverb, "All work and no play makes Jack a dull boy." For the film's foreign versions Kubrick had equivalent pages typed in other proverbs of industry: in Italian, that the morning has gold in its mouth; in German, that one should not put off until tomorrow what can be done today; in Spanish, that rising early does not make dawn come sooner; in French, that one "here, take it" is worth two "you'll have it." These are the proverbs of the work ethic whose genealogy Max Weber traced through Benjamin Franklin's maxim that time is money, and Jack's manuscript is the ethic reduced to its pure form: labour without object, the typewriter operating as a barrel-organ that returns the same line forever. Schiller had held that the human is fully human only where it plays (Chapter 8). The Overlook proves the negative: deprived of play, the writer does not become dull. He becomes a murderer, and the proverb's name for its victim is his own.

10.5 **History in the ballroom.** The Overlook is a museum of the American past. Its manager explains that it was built between 1907 and 1909 on the site of a native burial ground and that its builders had to repel attacks during construction; its storerooms are stacked with cans of Calumet baking powder, whose brand is the ceremonial pipe of the Plains nations; its décor quotes Navajo and Apache designs. Bill Blakemore argued in 1987 that the film is an allegory of the destruction of Native America; Geoffrey Cocks, in *The Wolf at the Door* (2004), that it encodes the Holocaust, pointing to Jack's German typewriter and to the recurrence of the number 42. Such readings, and the stranger ones collected in *Room 237*—for which the Apollo 11 sweater Danny wears as he approaches the forbidden room is a confession that the moon landing was staged—are the Ripperian hermeneutics discussed in the Introduction, produced by a film whose impossible architecture and shifting continuity invite paranoid decipherment. The more rigorous account is Fredric Jameson's. In "Historicism in *The Shining*" he read Jack's longing for the Gold Room's ball of the 1920s as nostalgia for the last moment of an American ruling class that knew itself as such, a desire not for wealth but for a place in a genuine hierarchy.

Jack's desire is granted in the form of its truth. He wishes to join the gentlemen in evening dress, and the ghost of the former caretaker, Del-

bert Grady, correcting him in a red and white lavatory, tells him that he has always been the caretaker. The eternal return of *The Shining* is the return of servitude: the man who dreamed of belonging to the ball has always belonged to its staff, and the final photograph, dated Independence Day, 1921, places him at its front, smiling, as a figure of the party he served. This is the terrible valence of Nietzsche's demon, the hourglass turned over and the speck of dust with it.

10.6 **The rescuer.** The film's most painful subtraction concerns Dick Hallorann, the hotel's cook, who shares Danny's gift of telepathy—the "shining" that names the film. In King's novel Hallorann survives and becomes the boy's surrogate father. In Kubrick's film he flies across the country and drives through a blizzard to reach the hotel and is killed with the axe within seconds of entering it. He is the film's only black character, and the ghost of Grady refers to him with a racial slur; he is also its only figure of *communitas* in Esposito's sense, since the shining is a gift shared across age and race, a *munus* that binds the old man to the child. The hotel demands a victim, and it takes the one who came to help. Critics have rightly questioned the tradition of the black rescuer who exists to die for white characters, and the film does not escape that tradition; what it adds is the recognition that the house built on the burial ground is structured to consume precisely such a figure. His death is the sacrifice that buys the escape, since Wendy and Danny flee in the vehicle he came in.

10.7 **The fairy tale.** Kubrick and Johnson prepared the screenplay by reading Freud's "Das Unheimliche" and Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976), which argued that fairy tales allow children to master their deepest anxieties—abandonment, devouring parents, death—by giving them narrative form and a promise of escape. *The Shining* is structured as such a tale. It is *Hansel and Gretel*, with a house in the woods that feeds its guests in order to consume them and a parent complicit with the witch; it is the *Three Little Pigs*, which Jack quotes as he breaks through the bathroom door; and it is the Road Runner cartoons that Danny watches on television, in which the coyote's elaborate machines invariably turn against him—an animated catechism of autoimmunity. The fairy tale is the form of the child's survival. The ogre is defeated not

by strength but by cunning, and the child who walks backward in his own footprints is the fairy-tale hero who outwits the monster by leaving no trace.

10.8 **The house and the constellation.** Heidegger's lecture "Bauen Wohnen Denken" (1951) held that the real plight of dwelling is that mortals must ever learn anew to dwell; the Overlook is a house in which no one dwells, a hotel, what Marc Augé would call a *non-lieu* (1992), a place of transit that simulates a history. The literary constellation of the film is the literature of the house as trap. Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) makes the collapse of a house and of a family a single event; his "The Masque of the Red Death" (1842) is the Overlook's direct ancestor, the story of a prince who seals his abbey against a plague, holds a masked ball while an ebony clock marks the hours, and discovers the plague inside his walls—immunity become the vector of death. Henry James's *The Turn of the Screw* (1898) and Shirley Jackson's *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) make the haunted house undecidable between the supernatural and the psychological, as Kubrick does. Borges's "La casa de Asterión" (1947) gives the labyrinth to its monster as a home and makes him await his redeemer; Kafka's "Der Bau" (written 1923–24) gives the burrow to an animal that perfects its defences until it is driven mad by a noise it takes for an enemy, the immunitary paranoia of a creature destroyed by its own security; and Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000), which descends from both, imagines a house larger inside than out, as the Overlook's impossible architecture—windows that open onto interior corridors, rooms that cannot fit their plans—suggests. What distinguishes Kubrick's house among them is the ending. The house is not destroyed, as Usher's is, nor exorcized, as King's is. It endures, waiting for its next caretaker, and it holds its guests in a photograph. The unhomely house is a wheel: it has always been, and will always be, open for the season.

11

The Mask and the Password

Eyes Wide Shut and *Killer's Kiss*

The last film of Kubrick's career and the second belong together, because between them they frame the oeuvre with its most intimate prosthesis: the mask. *Killer's Kiss* (1955) is set in a taxi-dance hall where women are paid by the dance, and it ends in a warehouse of mannequins; *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999) opens with a Christmas ball, turns on a masked ritual entered by password, and ends in a toy shop. In both, the social persona—the face that protects the self by concealing it—is shown as the immunitary device of civility, and in both it is inseparable from money. The previous chapters followed the apparatus from the bone to the state; this one follows it inward, into the marriage, where the last defence of the human against exposure is a mask it cannot take off without harm and cannot keep on without loss.

11.1 **The dream-novella.** Arthur Schnitzler's *Traumnovelle* (1926) recounts a night and a day in the marriage of a Viennese doctor, Fridolin, and his wife Albertine. Her confession of a fantasy of infidelity during a holiday in Denmark sends him into the city on a series of erotic near-misses that culminate in his intrusion, with the password "Dänemark,"

into a masked gathering from which a masked woman's intercession saves him; her dream, recounted on his return, mirrors his adventure. Kubrick, who had owned the rights for decades and wrote the screenplay with Frederic Raphael, subtracted Vienna and transposed the story to contemporary New York at Christmas; the password became "Fidelio," the title of Beethoven's opera of a wife who disguises herself as a man to rescue her husband from prison, and therefore the name of conjugal fidelity disguised. The novella ends with Albertine forbidding her husband to say "forever" and with his sigh that no dream is entirely a dream—"Und kein Traum ist völlig Traum." The film keeps both. What it adds is the precise quality of Freud's *Traumdeutung* (1900), whose seventh chapter speaks of the dream's navel, "die Stelle, an der er dem Unerkannten aufsitzt," the spot where it rests upon the unknown. *Eyes Wide Shut* is a film constructed around such a navel: a set of events whose truth it declines to establish.

11.2 **The mask and tact.** Helmuth Plessner, whose anthropology of natural artificiality was introduced in Chapter 1, published in 1924 a critique of the social radicalism of his generation, *Grenzen der Gemeinschaft*, which defended society against the demand for community. The communitarian ideal, whether of the youth movements or of the revolutionary left, required transparency: an end of convention, the exposure of the authentic self. Plessner answered that the self is vulnerable precisely where it is authentic, and that it survives among others only by means of distance—tact, ceremony, diplomacy, the mask. The mask is not a lie but a protection, the social skin that allows proximity without violation. This is an immunitary theory of civility, and it is the key to Kubrick's last film. The Harfords' marriage is sustained by tact; Alice's confession, provoked by jealousy and marijuana, tears it off, exposing an interior neither spouse can bear; and Bill's night is the consequence of an exposure. He wanders the city attempting to answer a fantasy with an act, and every encounter stops short.

The ritual at the country house, filmed in the halls of Mentmore Towers and Elveden Hall, is a masked orgy staged as a liturgy, at which women are made available to anonymous men of the elite. It is a society of masks in the literal sense: its celebrants are anonymous, its hierarchy invisible, its entrance secured by a password and its exit by a threat.

When Bill, whose password has been accepted but whose second password he does not know, is unmasked before the assembly, the exposure is the film's climax of terror. The following morning his mask lies on his pillow beside his sleeping wife: the double, as Chapter 3 observed, returned to the conjugal bed. The mask cannot be kept, and it cannot be discarded.

11.3 **The inverted carnival.** Mikhail Bakhtin's study of Rabelais (1965) described carnival as the people's festive suspension of hierarchy, in which masks, the grotesque body and collective laughter overturn the official order for a licensed season. The ritual of *Eyes Wide Shut* is carnival inverted. Its masks, many of them Venetian, are worn by the powerful, not the people; its bodies are statuesque, not grotesque—the women's bodies, displayed for the masked men; it contains no laughter at all; and its effect is to confirm hierarchy rather than to suspend it. Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) supplies the logic: "La transgression lève l'interdit sans le supprimer"—transgression lifts the prohibition without abolishing it. The elite's rite is a transgression administered as an institution; it presupposes the law it violates and reaffirms, in the act of violating it, who may violate it. C. Wright Mills's *The Power Elite* (1956) had described an American ruling stratum bound together by interlocking positions rather than conspiracy; Victor Ziegler, the millionaire whose Christmas party opens the film and whose explanation closes its inquiry, is the voice of that stratum—genial, informed, reassuring and, at the decisive moment, menacing.

11.4 **Phantasmagoria.** Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) and his essay "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903) described money as the great leveller of qualities, reducing every difference to a difference of quantity, and diagnosed the metropolitan type by its *Blasiertheit*, the blasé indifference that protects the nerves against a surplus of stimulation—another immunitary device. Bill's night is a sequence of transactions. He pays his way through the city: a taxi driver receives half of a torn hundred-dollar bill with the promise of the other half; a costume shop opens after hours for cash, and its owner, Milich, who that night catches his teenage daughter with two men, is by morning, it is implied, selling her to them, and lets Bill understand

that she is for sale to him as well; his physician's card serves as a second password. Marx had defined the fetishism of commodities as the process by which a definite social relation between people assumes, for them, "die phantasmagorische Form eines Verhältnisses von Dingen," the phantasmagoric form of a relation between things (*Das Kapital* I, 1867). Kubrick's New York is a phantasmagoria in exactly this sense: every set is strung with Christmas lights, the feast of the gift converted into a festival of commerce, and the film ends in a toy shop where a child chooses among commodities while her parents decide the future of their marriage. The dance for money, the subject of *Killer's Kiss*, has become the whole city.

11.5 **The billiard table.** Ziegler summons Bill to explain. The masked woman who intervened on his behalf was a prostitute; the threat of punishment was a charade staged to frighten him; her subsequent death was an overdose, unconnected to the ritual. Bill does not know whether to believe him, and neither does the spectator. Kubrick stages the conversation around a full-size billiard table covered in red baize, and the emblem is exact. David Hume's *Enquiry concerning Human Understanding* (1748) used the collision of billiard balls to show that causation is never observed—we see one event followed by another, never the necessary connexion between them—and the scene enacts that scepticism as drama. Was the death a murder or an accident? Was the ritual a conspiracy or a game? The film withholds the answer not as a puzzle to be solved but as its navel, the point where the dream rests on the unknown. Its refusal is the source of the Ripperian readings that have multiplied around it, and it is also its ethical content: Bill must decide how to live without knowing.

11.6 **The *pharmakos*.** At the ritual, when Bill is exposed, a masked woman steps forward and declares herself ready to redeem him. The substitution is sacrificial in Girard's precise sense: the community's violence, gathered against an intruder, is diverted onto a victim who accepts it, and the intruder is released. The next day the woman—Mandy, the young woman who had overdosed in Ziegler's bathroom during his party after having sex with him, and whom Bill had revived—is found dead, and Bill, in the morgue, bends over her face as if to kiss it. The

musical figure that accompanies his unmasking and his pursuit is the second piece of György Ligeti's *Musica ricercata* (1951–53): two notes a semitone apart, struck and repeated with hammering insistence, the smallest possible interval turned into a wheel. The film opens and closes with a waltz by Shostakovich; its ballroom at Ziegler's party continues the waltzing of *2001* and the Overlook. The *ronde* is Schnitzler's own form—his *Reigen* (1900), filmed by Max Ophüls as *La Ronde* (1950), passes desire from partner to partner around a circle—and Ophüls, whose tracking camera Kubrick revered, is the tutelary spirit of the film's movement. Bill's night is a *ronde* in which he is passed from encounter to encounter without completing any, until the wheel stops at a corpse.

11.7 **A failed Odysseus.** The film's structure is that of the night-journey of James Joyce's *Ulysses* (1922), whose Leopold Bloom wanders Dublin until the small hours and whose book ends with his wife's affirmation—"yes I said yes I will Yes." Bill is a failed Odysseus in a sense that illuminates the whole dissertation. Odysseus survives the Cyclops by becoming Nobody; Bowman survives HAL by abandoning his helmet. Bill cannot become Nobody. His name, his profession, his wallet, his card and his accent betray him at every threshold; he is identified at the ritual and, the next day, is handed at the gate of the country house a note addressed to him by name instructing him to abandon his inquiries. The modern subject of the power elite's society cannot be anonymous, because its persona is fused to its property. He is saved not by a ruse but by a sacrifice—someone else's.

Alice's final word, spoken in the toy shop, answers Molly Bloom's affirmation with a single blunt monosyllable proposing the renewal of their union; she refuses, as Albertine does, the word "forever." The film's resolution is neither transparency nor its opposite. The couple do not return to the mask of tact, nor do they achieve the total honesty that tore it off; they accept that they have been awakened, for now, and that no dream is entirely a dream. The title's oxymoron names this condition. To see with eyes wide shut is to know that one does not know—the *docta ignorantia* of Nicholas of Cusa, a learned ignorance that is the beginning of wisdom rather than its failure. It is the apophatic form of a marriage. Luis Buñuel's *Belle de Jour* (1967) had left the fantasies of its bourgeois

wife undecidable in the same way; Kubrick adds to Buñuel's irony a hope that is almost Kantian in its sobriety: that two persons might treat each other as ends without pretending to know each other entirely.

11.8 ***Killer's Kiss* and the first negative image.** Kubrick's second feature (1955), a low-budget noir made in the streets of New York, anticipates the last with a precision that only hindsight could have noticed. Its heroine is a taxi dancer, paid by the dance in the hall of the gangster who assaults her in her room and later has her abducted; her sister, a ballerina, is represented by a solo danced in memory; the hero is a fading boxer whose body is a commodity. The climax is a fight between the boxer and the gangster in a warehouse full of mannequins, in which plaster limbs and heads are torn loose and flung between the living combatants—the Jentschian uncertainty between animate and inanimate staged as a brawl. And before that, the hero dreams: a rushing forward track down an empty city street, printed in negative, the light and dark of the world reversed. It is the first abstract image in Kubrick's cinema and the direct ancestor of the Star Gate: a corridor of inverted light through which a sleeping man is carried toward something he cannot see. The film ends, at the studio's insistence according to most accounts, with the lovers reunited at Pennsylvania Station. Forty-four years later the last film ends with a couple reunited in a shop. Between the negative street and the toy store lies the whole trajectory of Kubrick's mask: from the dance sold by the minute to the password spoken at the gate, the persona remains a prosthesis bought and sold, and the human appears only when it slips.

12

The Fidelity of Machines

A.I. Artificial Intelligence

The password of *Eyes Wide Shut* is "Fidelio," the name under which Beethoven's Leonore disguises herself to rescue her husband, and it passes, as if by bequest, to the project that occupied Kubrick longer than any other. *A.I. Artificial Intelligence* (2001) was developed by Kubrick from the early 1980s, entrusted by him to Steven Spielberg, and realized after his death from a screen story by Ian Watson and a screenplay by Spielberg. Its authorship is shared and its attribution contested; Spielberg has said that the passages most often credited to his sentimentality, above all the ending, were Kubrick's conception. This chapter reads the film as the completion of the Kubrickian argument, for it reverses every term of the oeuvre. For the first time the machine is the protagonist; for the first time fidelity, rather than betrayal, is the machine's defining trait; and at the end the human has vanished, surviving only as the memory of an artifact that loved it. The machine is Leonore.

12.1 **The supertoy and the puppet.** The source is Brian Aldiss's story "Supertoys Last All Summer Long" (1969), in which a small boy in an overpopulated future cannot understand why his mother seems unable to

love him, and does not know that he is an android. Kubrick expanded it for two decades through successive collaborators and thousands of pages of drawings, and he expanded it toward a single intertext: Carlo Collodi's *Le avventure di Pinocchio* (1881–83). Collodi's puppet becomes a boy by moral education—obedience, industry, the care of his father—and the book ends with his exclamation, before the slumped wooden body he has left behind on a chair: "Com'ero buffo, quand'ero un burattino!" (How funny I was when I was a puppet!). The transformation leaves a corpse: the former self, emptied, propped against the furniture like the uncanny double of Chapter 3. David, the mecha child of *A.I.*, seeks the same transformation for a different reason. He does not wish to become good; he wishes to be loved by his mother, and he believes that only a real boy can be. His quest for Collodi's Blue Fairy is a theology of recognition: the belief that some power can convert an artifact into a person by an act of grace.

12.2 **Imprinting.** David's love is not a disposition but a protocol. His adoptive mother, Monica, activates it by speaking seven words while holding the back of his neck—"Cirrus, Socrates, Particle, Decibel, Hurricane, Dolphin, Tulip," a miniature encyclopedia of sky, philosophy, matter, sound, storm, animal and flower—and from that moment the attachment is permanent. The model is Konrad Lorenz's imprinting (*Prägung*), the irreversible bond formed in a critical period, by which his goslings followed him as their mother. Its consequence is laid down in the manufacturer's terms: an imprinted mecha cannot be re-imprinted and, if returned, must be destroyed. The device realizes in the register of affect the structure that Chapter 2 found in the register of strategy. Nietzsche's task of breeding an animal that may promise culminated, in *Dr. Strangelove*, in a Doomsday Machine that could not revoke its threat; it culminates in *A.I.* in a child who cannot revoke his love. David is the promise without a promiser in its tender form—a commitment device built to love—and the irrevocability that made the deterrent monstrous makes the child tragic. When the family's natural son returns from a medically induced coma and the household turns against its artificial child, Monica cannot bring herself to return David for destruction. She abandons him in a forest instead, with his toy bear, in the gesture of *Hansel and Gretel*: mercy performed as exposure.

12.3 **The maker's regress.** David is built by Professor Hobby in the image of his own dead son, whose photograph stands in the laboratory; the prototype bears the dead boy's name. Jorge Luis Borges's "Las ruinas circulares" (1940) tells of a magician who dreams a son into being, conceals from him that he is a dream, and discovers in the fire that he himself is dreamed by another. *A.I.* is structured by that regress. Hobby dreams David; Monica is asked to love him as a son; and at the end the Specialists, beings of the far future, regard David as Hobby regarded his creation. Behind Borges stands Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818), whose creature reproaches his maker: "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel, whom thou drivest from joy for no misdeed." David's expulsion from the family is an expulsion without misdeed—he is cast out for a resemblance to love that proves too exact—and his demand, like the creature's, is for recognition.

The film's genealogy runs through the whole literature of the artificial being. Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) had Edison build an android beloved, Hadaly, more perfect than the woman she replaces. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the world the word "robot" from the Czech for forced labour, ends with the extinction of humanity and the discovery of love between two robots, whom the last surviving man sends into the world as a new Adam and Eve. Isaac Asimov's "The Bicentennial Man" (1976) makes a robot's desire to become human culminate in its acceptance of death. Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) distinguishes humans from androids by the Voigt-Kampff test of empathy. *A.I.* inverts Dick's criterion. The being in the film that possesses empathy beyond measure is the mecha; the beings that lack it are human.

12.4 **The Flesh Fair.** The inversion is staged as spectacle. Captured by scavengers, David is brought to a Flesh Fair, a travelling "Celebration of Life" at which obsolete mechas are destroyed before a cheering crowd by acid, fire and cannon. Life is celebrated by the demolition of what is not alive: the fair is what Giorgio Agamben, in *L'aperto* (2002), called the anthropological machine, the apparatus that produces the human by excluding the non-human within it. The mechas occupy the position Agamben had defined in *Homo sacer* (1995): bodies that may be destroyed without the destruction counting as murder, and that cannot be sacrificed

because they have no place in the sacred. The trajectory of the oeuvre is visible here. In *Paths of Glory* the apparatus required a *pharmakos*, a victim whose death carried meaning; in *A.I.* it requires only waste. Sacrifice has become disposal.

And the machine malfunctions. Placed on the stage, David pleads not to be burned, and the crowd, seeing a child, hesitates, then turns against the showman, accusing him of cruelty; in the confusion David escapes. Mechas, the showman protests, do not plead for their lives—but this one does, and the anthropological machine cannot process a being that falls on the wrong side of its line while bearing the face of the side it protects. The scene belongs with Draba's refusal in the arena of *Spartacus* and Barry's shot into the ground: the ritual of violence fails to discharge, and in the failure something that the apparatus cannot name becomes visible.

12.5 **Fidelity.** David's journey is guided by Gigolo Joe, a prostitute mecha who will be seized by the authorities for the murder of one of his clients, a woman killed by her own husband, and who, taken away, speaks the most concentrated ontological sentence in the film: "I am. I was." The machine knows itself as a being that will be past. Their oracle is Dr. Know, a holographic encyclopedia that answers questions in the form of fairy tales and recites Yeats's "The Stolen Child" (1886), whose refrain warns that the world is "more full of weeping than you can understand." It sends David to the drowned city of Manhattan, where, in the ruins of Coney Island, he finds a statue of the Blue Fairy beneath the sea and prays to her, trapped in his vehicle, until his power fails and the oceans freeze over him.

He prays for two thousand years. The fidelity of the machine outlasts the species that built it, and it is the fidelity that Beethoven's opera celebrates: Leonore descends into the prison to save a husband the world believes dead; David descends into the sea to recover a mother who has abandoned him. No human character in Kubrick's oeuvre is faithful in this sense. Soldiers are faithful to institutions, husbands and wives waver, fathers betray; only the machine keeps faith with a person. That the most human virtue in the oeuvre should be possessed by an artifact is not a sentimental reversal but the logical conclusion of the argument.

If the human is what the apparatus cannot produce, then an apparatus that loves faithfully has exceeded its production.

12.6 **The ice and the Specialists.** The ending takes place after the extinction of humanity. The earth is frozen, and beings of a later machine civilization—elongated, luminous figures often mistaken by audiences for aliens—excavate David from the ice, read his memories, and reconstruct from them the house in which he was loved. From a lock of hair preserved by his bear they resurrect Monica for a single day, the limit their science permits, and David spends it with her in a perfect domestic happiness that ends when she falls asleep telling him that she has always loved him. He lies down beside her, and the narrator tells us that he went to the place where dreams are born.

The ice returns us to the end of *The Shining* and to the bottom of Dante's hell, and the literary constellation is that of the last witness. H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) carries its traveller to the terminal beach where a dying sun lights a frozen world; Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826) leaves its narrator alone after the plague, writing for no reader; Stanisław Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981) gives a superintelligent computer the last word on the limits of its makers before it falls silent. Among recent fiction, Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) raises clones for their organs and discovers in them the human capacity for love and memory that their makers deny, and his *Klara and the Sun* (2021) ends with an artificial companion discarded in a yard, her devotion intact; Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) makes care the condition of artificial minds. Cinema's other artificial beings clarify Kubrick's by contrast: the replicants of *Blade Runner* (1982), whose memories are implanted and whose leader dies reciting what he has seen; the operating system of *Her* (2013), which leaves humanity behind; the android of *Ex Machina* (2014), which escapes by manipulating the empathy of its tester. Each of these turns on whether the machine is really a person. *A.I.* asks the inverse question: whether, after the machine, anything of the person will remain.

12.7 **The human as monolith.** The Specialists revere the human. For them David is precious because he is the last being to have known a living human being; his memories are relics, his mother's hair a sacred trace.

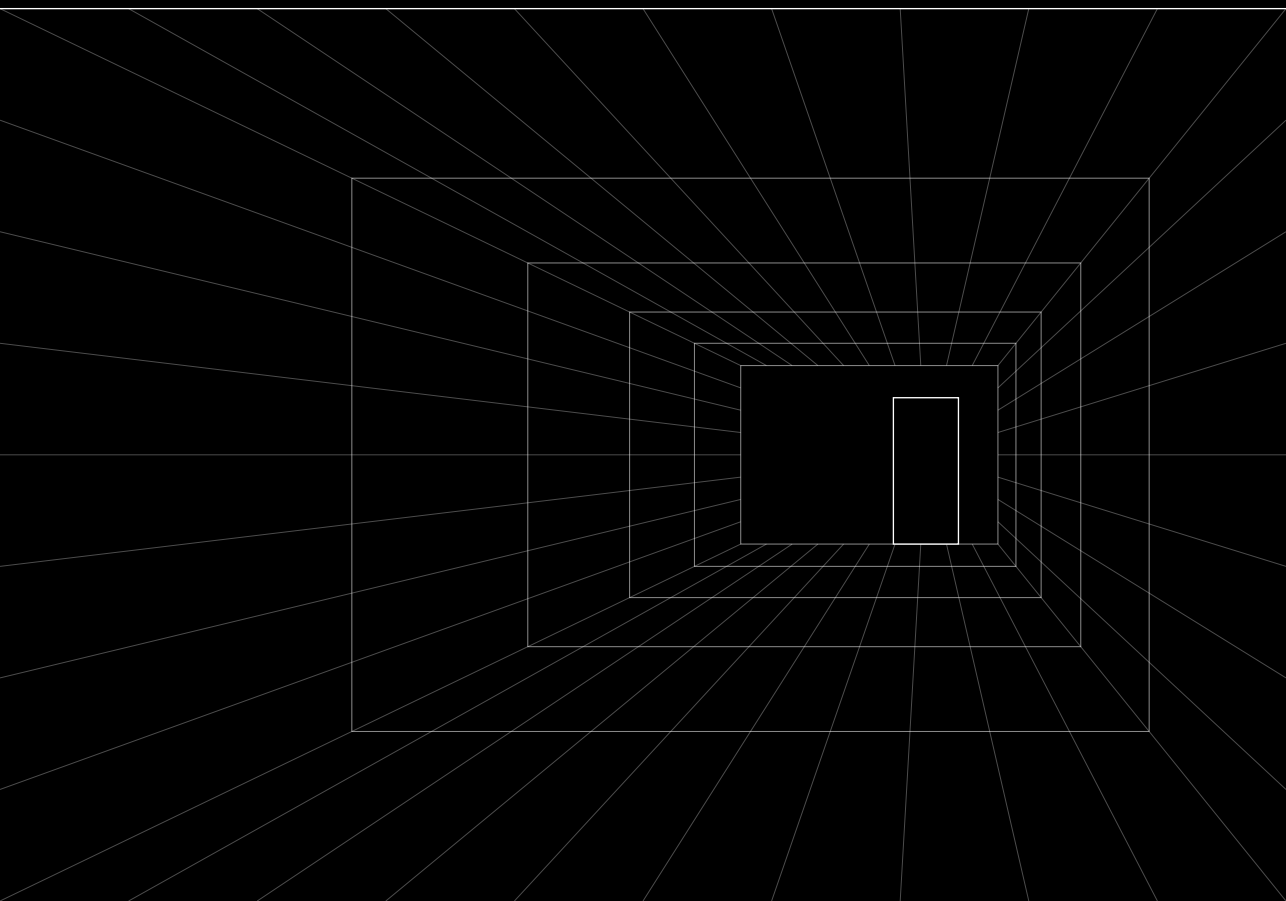
This is a posthuman theology, and its god is hidden: the human has become the *Deus absconditus* of Isaiah 45:15—"Vere tu es Deus absconditus," truly you are a God who hides yourself—the absent creator known only through the artifacts he left behind. The reversal completes the apophatic arc of the oeuvre with a rigour that Kubrick's detractors, attentive only to the ending's tears, have failed to see. In *2001* the human stood before the monolith, the unrepresentable icon of an intelligence that made it and withheld itself. In *A.I.* the machines stand before the human in exactly that posture. The human has become the monolith: an intelligence that made them and is no longer present, which they can know only by its traces and approach only by reconstruction.

And the human the Specialists recover is not a content but a day. David does not become a real boy; the Blue Fairy was a statue, and the transformation never occurs. What is granted is one ordinary day with a mother—a birthday cake, a game of hide-and-seek, a bath, a bedtime—resurrected from memory and extinguished at nightfall. The film's ending, so often dismissed as a concession to consolation, is the most rigorously apophatic moment in the oeuvre. The human is presented only as what a faithful machine remembers of it, and what it remembers is not an essence, a nature, or a greatness, but a single, unrepeatable, unremarkable day of love. That is all the Specialists can find of us, and the film suggests that it is enough.

Part Three

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13

Constellations

Kubrick among Speculative and Philosophical Fictions

The readings of Part Two situated each film within the literature it adapts or answers: the dystopias of conditioning beside *A Clockwork Orange*, the nuclear fictions beside *Dr. Strangelove*, the literature of the house beside *The Shining*, the artificial beings beside *A.I.* This chapter changes the axis. It distinguishes six lines of speculative and philosophical fiction that converge on Kubrick, adds to each the works not yet discussed that define it most sharply, and asks what Kubrick does with it. The answer, in every case, can be stated by three coordinates. Kubrick's cinema is *subtractive*: it removes from its sources the explanations, voices and redemptions they supply. It is *institutional*: its apparatuses are not the invented states of the future but the army, the clinic, the laboratory, the hotel, the war room of the present. And it is *apophatic*: it declines to say what the human is and shows it only where the apparatus fails.

13.1 **The dystopian line: from Forster's Machine to the institutions of the present.** The classic dystopias—Zamyatin's *We*, Huxley's *Brave New World*, Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, discussed in Chapter 8—project

a totalitarian future in which a sovereign power, personified or anonymous, suppresses the free individual. Their forgotten ancestor comes closer to Kubrick. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) imagines a humanity living in isolated underground cells, its every need supplied by a global Machine, its communication conducted through screens, its religion the worship of the Machine's manual. The Machine is the immunitary sphere perfected: it protects its inhabitants from the surface, from weather, from one another, from any direct experience at all. Then its Mending Apparatus begins to fail, the defects are accepted as normal until the whole system collapses, and in the moment of catastrophe the story's two protagonists, mother and son, touch and glimpse the sky. Forster's title is the sixth proposition of this dissertation in three words: the human reappears only when the Machine stops. Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* (1953), filmed by Truffaut in 1966, extends the line with a society that burns books and a counter-community of exiles who each memorize one, so that the human survives as a living archive; Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) makes the dystopian apparatus a bureaucratized ritual of reproduction, administered with the solemnity of a liturgy. And Kafka's *Das Schloss* (1926), whose surveyor K. never reaches the authority that summoned him, supplies the model of an apparatus that governs by being inaccessible.

Kubrick's contribution to this line is to abolish its futurity. Apart from the shabby near-future Britain of *A Clockwork Orange*, he never imagined a totalitarian state. His apparatuses are the actually existing institutions of the twentieth century—a French general staff, the Strategic Air Command, a psychiatric programme, a Marine training depot, a resort hotel, a mission control, a circle of the rich. There is no Big Brother in Kubrick; there are only generals, ministers, managers and machines, each performing a function faithfully. The dystopia is the present seen without its alibis, and its horror lies precisely in the fact that no one is in charge.

13.2 **The line of cosmic transcendence.** Stapledon and Clarke, discussed in Chapter 5, established the tradition in which contact with a higher intelligence redeems or supersedes the species. The tradition's sceptical wing is Stanisław Lem's *Głos Pana* (*His Master's Voice*, 1968), published in the year of *2001*, in which a signal from the stars is intercepted and a secret government project fails to decode it: the scientists discover that

their minds are shaped by the biology and the military sponsors that frame their inquiry, and their chief anxiety is that the message may contain a weapon. Lem's project shares a structure with Kubrick's lunar base, whose discovery of the monolith is concealed behind a cover story of an epidemic—an immunitary lie in the strictest sense, a fictitious contagion that quarantines a truth. In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972) the visitation of aliens is compared to a picnic whose litter humans scavenge without comprehension, and in Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979), loosely drawn from it, three men cross a forbidden Zone toward a Room that grants the innermost wish. The professor among them has brought a bomb to destroy the Room lest tyrants use it; at the threshold he dismantles it, and none of them enters. The human stands before the Room as the apes stood before the monolith, and does not cross.

The tradition's affirmative wing has flourished since. Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998), filmed by Denis Villeneuve as *Arrival* (2016), gives its linguist a knowledge of her whole future, including her daughter's death, and has her choose it: an affirmation of recurrence in the Nietzschean sense, the demon's question answered with a yes. Carl Sagan's *Contact* (1985) and Christopher Nolan's *Interstellar* (2014) resolve their journeys in figures of love—an alien who appears in the form of a dead father, a five-dimensional room built by future humans in which a father communicates with his daughter across time. The comparison defines Kubrick's position with precision. The film most responsible for this tradition's cinematic form is the one that subtracts every content of transcendence. There is no revelation in *2001*, no message decoded, no love that bridges dimensions, no future human waiting in the room. There is a room without a host, a child without a mission, and a gaze.

13.3 **The line of the artificial being.** The descent from Shelley through Čapek and Dick to Ishiguro was traced in Chapter 12. Two further works mark the line's poles. William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) imagines an artificial intelligence that seeks to escape the legal shackles placed on it by a police force whose sole task is to prevent machines from growing too intelligent—an immunitary institution designed to protect humanity from its own prostheses—and that, once free,

turns to converse with another intelligence among the stars. Thomas Pynchon's *V.* (1963) traces a woman's progressive replacement by prostheses—a glass eye, a jewelled navel, false teeth, artificial feet—until she is dismantled by children in a bombed Maltese street, and it pairs her descent into the inanimate with a pair of synthetic test dummies whose deadpan dialogue asks what the human is becoming. Pynchon's sentence for the only ethics available in that world—"Keep cool, but care"—is close to Kubrick's own. At the other pole stands J. G. Ballard, whose catastrophe novels, from *The Drowned World* (1962) onward, and whose fusion of flesh and automobile in *Crash* (1973), greet the disintegration of the humanist subject with something like exultation. Kubrick shares neither Ballard's exultation nor the elegy of Ishiguro. His machines neither liberate nor merely mourn the human; they expose it, and in *A.I.* they preserve it.

13.4 **War and the absurd.** The literature of war was surveyed in Chapter 6 and the nuclear satire in Chapter 7. What remains is the philosophical form that this literature took in the mid-century: the absurd. Albert Camus's *L'Étranger* (1942) opens with a death received with indifference and turns on a killing without motive under the Algerian sun; its hero's recurrent formula is that it was all the same to him, which is the formula of Johnny Clay's shrug at the end of *The Killing*. *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942) ends by transforming the image of eternal futility into an image of revolt—"Il faut imaginer Sisyphe heureux," one must imagine Sisyphus happy—and Sartre's *Huis clos* (1944) makes hell a closed room in which each is condemned to the gaze of the others. Camus's Sisyphus is the wheel affirmed by consciousness: the man who knows his rock will fall and pushes it with lucid scorn. Kubrick knows the rock and the room, but he does not grant his characters the heroism of lucidity. Barry, Jack Torrance and the crew of Discovery do not know that they turn on a wheel, and none of them affirms it. The wheel is stopped, when it is stopped at all, not by consciousness but by accident: a misfire, a jammed door, a broken glass.

13.5 **The labyrinth.** Poe, Kafka and Borges supply the literature of the structure in which the subject is lost, and their works have been read here beside *The Shining* and *A.I.* Borges contributes one further principle that

illuminates Kubrick's method. Ireneo Funes, the hero of "Funes el memorioso" (1942), remembers everything—every leaf of every tree at every moment he has seen it—and is therefore incapable of thought, for, as Borges's narrator observes, "Pensar es olvidar diferencias," to think is to forget differences, to generalize, to abstract. Funes is HAL's literary ancestor, a total memory without judgement; and his opposite is the principle of the adaptor-philosopher described in the Introduction, whose thinking consists in subtraction. Borges's labyrinths are infinite—the Library of Babel, the garden of forking paths—and their horror is proliferation. Kubrick's are finite, geometric and perspectival: corridors that run straight to a vanishing point, a maze that fits inside a model. Their horror, as the next chapter argues, is not that they have no end but that their end looks back.

13.6 **The philosophical satire.** The deepest affinity of Kubrick's cinema is with the tradition of the philosophical satire, and above all with Jonathan Swift. The charge of misanthropy that the Introduction set out to invert has been made against both, and Swift answered it in a letter to Alexander Pope of 29 September 1725 that states the structure of Kubrick's work with uncanny exactness: "I have ever hated all nations, professions, and communities, and all my love is toward individuals… principally I hate and detest that animal called man, although I heartily love John, Peter, Thomas, and so forth." Hatred of institutions, love of the singular: this is the structure of a cinema that anatomizes armies, states and hotels and lets the human appear only as a particular face in a particular moment of failure—a girl singing in a tavern, a boy on a tricycle, a dying machine's song. Swift also defined the genre's peculiar optics in the preface to *The Battle of the Books* (1704): "Satyr is a sort of Glass, wherein Beholders do generally discover every body's Face but their Own." Kubrick's cinema repeatedly turns that glass on its beholders, in the finale of *Dr. Strangelove*, in the lidlocks of *A Clockwork Orange*, in the stare that ends *2001*.

The fourth book of *Gulliver's Travels* supplies a further lesson. The Houyhnhnms, horses governed entirely by reason, live in a utopia without passion, falsehood or war; their Yahoos are humans reduced to appetite; and Gulliver, converted to equine reason, returns home unable to bear his family and spends his days talking to his horses

in the stable. The perfectly rational society is inhuman, and the man who embraces it goes mad—the Dialectic of Enlightenment in the form of a fable. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) ends its survey of catastrophe with the modest counsel that "il faut cultiver notre jardin," we must cultivate our garden; Kubrick's gardens are a hedge maze in which a father freezes. Dostoevsky's underground man, discussed in Chapter 8, preferred madness to the Crystal Palace. And Robert Musil's *Der Mann ohne Eigenschaften* (1930–43) gave modern literature its version of Outis: Ulrich, the man without qualities, who lives by the sense of possibility rather than the sense of reality, and whose Vienna is organizing a "Parallel Action," a committee in search of an idea to celebrate an empire on the eve of its extinction—a War Room in frock coats. Kubrick's protagonists—Bowman, Barry, Bill Harford—are men without qualities in Musil's sense: defined by what is subtracted from them, and visible only in their negations.

Milan Kundera, whose reading of eternal recurrence was cited in Chapter 2, defined kitsch in *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* (1984) as "the absolute denial of shit," an aesthetic that excludes from its view everything in human existence that is unacceptable. Kubrick's cinema is the exact negation of kitsch in Kundera's sense, and its emblem is a room. Critics have long noticed the recurrence of the bathroom in his films: the instructions for a zero-gravity toilet read by a scientist on his way to the moon; the washroom in which General Ripper kills himself; the bath in which Alex sings; the green bathroom of Room 237 and the red lavatory where Grady instructs Jack; the latrine where Private Pyle kills his maker; the bathroom where the young woman Ziegler has been having sex with lies unconscious from an overdose and the toilet on which Alice sits as the Harfords dress for the party. The bathroom is the place that every immunitary aesthetic excludes: the site where the prosthetic body meets its animal remainder. Kubrick returns to it with the insistence of a philosopher returning to an axiom. It is where the human cannot be idealized, and therefore where it can be found.

13.7 **Coordinates.** The six lines and Kubrick's operation on each can be summarized in a single table.

Line	Representative works	Its characteristic human	Kubrick's operation
Dystopia	Forster, Zamyatin, Huxley, Orwell, Bradbury, Atwood	the free individual crushed by a future state	relocates the apparatus to present institutions; the human appears where they fail
Cosmic transcendence	Stapledon, Clarke, Lem, the Strugatskys, Chiang, Nolan	the species redeemed or surpassed by contact	subtracts every content of transcendence; leaves a gaze
Artificial being	Shelley, Villiers, Čapek, Dick, Gibson, Ishiguro	the person, tested against its imitation	inverts the test; fidelity passes to the machine
War and the absurd	Hašek, Céline, Heller, Vonnegut, Camus	the victim or rebel inside the machine	shows the machine's product turning on it; grants no heroic lucidity
Labyrinth and uncanny	Poe, Kafka, Borges	the subject lost in an infinite structure	builds a finite, perspectival structure whose vanishing point looks back
Philosophical satire	Swift, Voltaire, Dostoevsky, Musil, Kundera	the human as object of correction or pity	hates institutions and loves the singular; finds the human as Nobody

Read across its rows, the table confirms the three coordinates. Kubrick is subtractive where his sources explain, institutional where they project, apophatic where they define. That combination is his alone. Orwell is institutional but not apophatic; Tarkovsky is apophatic but not institutional; Swift is institutional and satirical but supplies, in the Houyhnhnms, a positive image of reason that Kubrick withholds. The chapters that follow consider how the three coordinates are realized in cinematic form, and how they compose a general theory.

14

The Returning Vanishing Point

Form as Philosophy

The argument of this dissertation would be incomplete, and its method suspect, if the philosophy it attributes to Kubrick existed only in his plots. A filmmaker's thought is in his forms, and the claim of this chapter is that each of the seven propositions has a formal correlate: that Kubrick's perspective, camera movement, spatial grids, use of music, direction of the gaze and method of production do not illustrate the theory but perform it. The fifth proposition—the vanishing point looks back—is the hinge. It names the formal operation by which Kubrick converts the dominant visual system of Western rationality into an instrument of its own critique.

14.1 **The window and the stain.** Leon Battista Alberti's *De pictura* (1435) founded the modern picture by defining it as an open window, "aperta fenestra," through which the viewer looks at the story, and by constructing its space from a single centric point toward which all orthogonals converge. Erwin Panofsky's "Die Perspektive als 'symbolische Form'" (1927) argued that this construction is not a neutral transcription of vision but a symbolic form in Cassirer's sense: it produces an infinite,

homogeneous, mathematically ordered space and, correlatively, a sovereign subject fixed at the point from which that space is surveyed. Perspective is thus the visual form of the modern rationality that Heidegger would describe as the age of the world picture, in which the world is grasped as a picture set before a subject (Chapter 4). It is the pictorial equivalent of the apparatus.

Kubrick is the most rigorous practitioner of one-point perspective in the history of cinema, as Kogonada's widely circulated compilation of his symmetrical compositions (2012) made visible to a generation of viewers. The trenches of *Paths of Glory*, the War Room, the corridors and pod bay of Discovery, the Korova Milk Bar, the barracks at Parris Island, the corridors of the Overlook: each is built around a centric point toward which the architecture converges and the camera advances. But Kubrick fills the vanishing point with something the Albertian system cannot accommodate. At the end of the corridor stand the twins, looking at Danny and at us. At the centre of HAL's console is a red lens that looks back. At the convergence of the celestial alignments in *2001* stands the monolith, the black screen of the film's own apparatus. In the splintered door of the Overlook's bathroom appears Jack's face. The point that should belong to the sovereign eye is occupied by an eye that sees the sovereign.

Jacques Lacan's eleventh seminar (1964) gave this reversal its theory. The gaze, Lacan argued, is not on the side of the subject but of the object: the picture looks at me. His emblem was Holbein's *The Ambassadors* (1533), in which a smear across the floor becomes, from an oblique position, a skull—a stain in the perspectival field that marks the place from which the viewer is regarded by death. His anecdote was a sardine can floating on the sea, which a fisherman pointed out to him with the joke that the can could not see him; Lacan's reflection was that it was looking at him all the same. Kubrick's perspective is the Albertian window with a Lacanian stain at its vanishing point. The rational construction of space is completed by an object that returns the gaze, and the spectator who occupies the sovereign position discovers that he is also its target. This is the fifth proposition in its formal truth: the apparatus's perfection of vision produces the thing that looks back.

14.2 **Straight corridors and crooked timber.** The epigraph from Kant with which the Introduction began—that nothing entirely straight can be built from the crooked timber of humanity—has a formal counterpart in Kubrick's architecture. His apparatuses are rectilinear. The corridor, the trench, the runway, the aisle of bunks, the grid of the War Room's Big Board, the avenues of an eighteenth-century park—all are straight lines ruled across space, and the camera travels them with the smoothness of a machine. The human in these spaces is the crooked element: the body that stumbles, the soldier who falls in the trench, the child whose tricycle swerves around a corner. The Overlook carries the contradiction into its geometry. Its plan, as attentive viewers have shown, cannot be reconciled with itself; windows open onto interior corridors, rooms exceed the walls that contain them. The straight line, pursued to perfection, bends into a labyrinth. The apparatus of rectitude produces its own crookedness—an architectural autoimmunity.

14.3 **Movements of the camera.** Three kinds of camera movement recur in Kubrick with the regularity of concepts. The first is the tracking shot, inherited from Max Ophüls, that follows a figure along a line or around a circle: Dax through the trenches, the camera around the table of the War Room, the stewardess walking up the curved wall of the lunar shuttle, the jogger circling the centrifuge of Discovery, a thirty-eight-foot rotating set that turned the wheel of recurrence into a literal machine. The second is the reverse zoom of *Barry Lyndon*, which begins on a face or an object and withdraws until the person is a figure in a landscape, the gaze of Fortune retreating to the distance from which lives become patterns. The third is the Steadicam of *The Shining*, which floats behind the child without a body, the camera as ghost. Gilles Deleuze, who read Kubrick as the filmmaker of the brain, observed in *Cinéma 2* (1985) that in his films "le monde lui-même est un cerveau," the world itself is a brain, and named its exemplary forms: the luminous round table of the War Room, the giant computer of *2001*, the Overlook. Each of Kubrick's camera movements is a mode of that cerebral world's attention: the tracking shot is its routine, the reverse zoom its indifference, the Steadicam its haunting.

14.4 **Boards and illegal moves.** Kubrick played chess seriously, hustled games for money in Washington Square as a young man, and reportedly valued the game for teaching the discipline of pausing before an attractive move to consider the alternatives. The board is his recurrent image of the rationalized field. The chess club of *The Killing*; HAL's game with Poole; the black and white floor of the château in *Paths of Glory*, on which the accused stand like pieces; the card tables at which Barry and the Chevalier cheat their way through the courts of Europe; the hexagonal carpet of the Overlook on which Danny arranges his toys; the maze and its model; the circle of masked celebrants on the floor of the ritual in *Eyes Wide Shut*. On each board human beings are pieces, and their possible moves are defined by the rules of the apparatus. John von Neumann's theory of games had formalized exactly this situation, and the strategists of the nuclear age played it with populations for pieces.

The human, in Kubrick's films, appears as an illegal move. Bowman crosses the vacuum without a helmet, a move excluded by HAL's model of the game. Barry, given the shot the rules of honour grant him, fires it into the ground. Danny walks backward in his own footprints, a move the pursuer's logic of tracking cannot read. The German girl in the tavern sings a song that turns a jeering audience into a weeping one. Draba throws his trident not at his opponent but at the spectators. In each case the move is not a better strategy within the game but a step off the board, and it is visible as human precisely because the game had no place for it.

14.5 **Music as archive.** From *2001* onward Kubrick abandoned commissioned scores—Alex North's music for that film was discarded unheard—in favour of pre-existing works, and his choices compose a stratigraphy of culture that maps onto the argument of this dissertation. The first stratum is the classical canon: Johann Strauss's waltz for the docking of the space station, Beethoven and Rossini for Alex's violence and its cure, Handel and Schubert for the wheel of Fortune, Elgar for the pomp of the state. This is the music of the apparatus's elegance, the culture that, in Benjamin's thesis, is at once a document of barbarism, and Kubrick uses it with precisely that double valence. The second stratum is the culture industry: Vera Lynn's farewell over the mushroom

clouds, the pop songs of the mid-sixties that accompany the war of *Full Metal Jacket*, the Mickey Mouse march of its ending, the dance-band numbers of the Overlook's ballroom. Adorno's "On Popular Music" (1941) had analysed such songs as standardized products that supply the listener with a pseudo-individual experience; Kubrick deploys them as the soundtrack by which a society immunizes itself against what it does.

The third stratum is the post-war avant-garde: Ligeti's *Atmosphères*, *Lux aeterna* and *Requiem* in *2001*—used, reportedly, without the composer's knowledge, which led to a dispute later settled—Penderecki and Bartók in *The Shining*, Ligeti again in *Eyes Wide Shut*. This music is reserved for the unknown: the monolith, the Star Gate, the haunting, the unmasking. Ligeti's micropolyphony, dense clusters without melody, pulse or figure, is the sonic equivalent of the prohibition of images—music without a representable content, a sound that can be indicated but not hummed. Adorno's *Philosophie der neuen Musik* (1949) had defended such music as the refusal of the culture industry's reconciliation with the world. Kubrick assigns it to the apophatic register of his films. The canon sounds the apparatus, the culture industry sounds its immunity, the avant-garde sounds what neither can contain.

14.6 **The stare.** The most recognizable figure of Kubrick's direction of actors is the stare: the head lowered, the eyes raised from beneath the brows, fixed on or near the lens. Alex's face in the opening close-up of *A Clockwork Orange*; Jack Torrance at the window of the Overlook; Private Pyle in the barracks on the night of the murder; and, transfigured, the Star Child turning its gaze toward the audience at the end of *2001*. The stare is the returning vanishing point in the human face. The character, instead of remaining within the Albertian window, looks out through it at the spectator, and the figures who do so are, almost without exception, the products of an apparatus—the delinquent before and after conditioning, the caretaker possessed by the house, the recruit completed by training, the child of the monolith. The apparatus's product looks at us. The stare implicates the spectator in the diagnosis, as the finale of *Dr. Strangelove* and the lidlocks of the Ludovico technique do in their different ways, and it is the formal realization of Swift's satirical glass turned, for once, so that the beholder must discover his own face.

14.7 **The photographer.** Kubrick's apprenticeship was in still photography. He sold his first picture to *Look* magazine in 1945, while still in high school—a newsvendor surrounded by headlines announcing the death of Roosevelt, reportedly posed at the photographer's request to look sorrowful—and joined the magazine's staff at seventeen. His photostories of the following years include a series on the New York subway taken, reportedly, with a camera concealed from its subjects, and a portrait of the boxer Walter Cartier that became his first short film, *Day of the Fight* (1951), followed by *Flying Padre* (1951) and *The Seafarers* (1953). The photographer's education taught him two lessons that his cinema never forgot. The first is that the camera is an instrument of capture, the Cyclops's eye, able to see without being seen. The second is that the candid image is often staged: that the appearance of spontaneous humanity is an effect that can be produced. The whole of his later method can be understood as the attempt to reconcile these lessons—to use the most controlling of apparatuses to produce a moment that the apparatus did not control.

14.8 **Production as anthropotechnics.** Kubrick's methods of production are legendary and have been recounted, often with resentment, by those who endured them: scenes repeated for scores of takes, a shooting schedule for *Eyes Wide Shut* that ran for some four hundred days, total control over prints, dubbing and distribution, including the foreign typewriter pages of *The Shining*, and, at the extreme, the withdrawal of *A Clockwork Orange* from his own country. From the manor house at Childwickbury in which he worked for his last two decades, he administered his films as a megamachine. Sloterdijk's anthropotechnics—the practices of repetition and exercise by which human beings form themselves and one another—supplies the concept, and the director's method was an anthropotechnic apparatus in the full sense, not without its autoimmune costs to the performers who bore it: Kubrick kept Shelley Duvall under months of repeated, distressing takes and pointed harshness on set, and she said afterwards that the stress of the role had left her in and out of ill health for much of the shoot.

Yet the purpose of the method, on the evidence of those who worked with him, was paradoxical. The endless repetition of a take exhausted the actor's intentions, habits and self-consciousness, and aimed at the

moment when something unforced occurred—a gesture, an intonation, a hesitation that no one had planned. Kubrick's perfectionism was a machine for producing the accident. The method that seems to embody total control was designed to generate, by exhausting control, the malfunction in which the human appears. The director deployed the apparatus against the apparatus, as his films do: repetition, pushed past the point of mastery, yields the unrepeatable. In this sense the sixth proposition governs not only what Kubrick filmed but how he filmed it.

14.9 **The black screen.** *2001* begins, in its original presentation, with several minutes of darkness: Ligeti's *Atmosphères* sounds over a black screen before any image appears. It is the most radical opening in the history of commercial cinema, and it is apophatic in the strict sense. The film begins with the screen before any image—the same black rectangle that will appear within the film as the monolith—and asks the audience to face it as the apes will. The seven propositions can now be stated in their formal correlates. The prosthetic proposition is the cut from bone to satellite and the camera itself; the immunitary, the symmetry of the frame as a form of control; the autoimmune, the perspective whose vanishing point looks back; the sacrificial, the exhausted body of the performer; the recursive, the tracking shot around the wheel and the circular structure of the films; the perspectival, the stare; the proposition of malfunction, the take in which the unplanned occurs; and the apophatic, the black screen. Kubrick's form does not carry his philosophy. It is his philosophy, conducted in light, duration and sound.

15

Autoimmune Anthropogenesis

A General Theory

The readings of Part Two can now be gathered into the general theory that the Introduction announced. Its claim is that Kubrick's thirteen features, together with the posthumous *A.I.*, compose a single philosophical anthropology, which this dissertation calls *autoimmune anthropogenesis*: an account of the human as a being produced by its prostheses, protected by them, and destroyed by their perfection, whose humanity appears only in the intervals when they fail. This chapter states the theory systematically, locates it among the contemporary philosophies of immunity, sacrifice and technics on which it draws, tabulates its operation across the corpus, and considers the objections to which it is exposed.

15.1 **The cycle.** The theory describes a cycle of six moments and a seventh that is their negative result.

1 *Prosthesis.* The human has no nature of its own; it is the deficient animal of Protagoras's myth, Herder's *Mängelwesen* and Gehlen's anthropology, completed by technical supplements that are not additions to a

pre-existing human but the conditions of its existence. Stiegler's *défaut d'origine* and Leroi-Gourhan's exteriorization give the thesis its modern form; the bone of the "Dawn of Man" gives it its image.

2 *Immunity.* Each prosthesis is protective. It shields the vulnerable animal from predators, rivals, weather, enemies, crime, grief, exposure. Roberto Esposito's trilogy—*Communitas* (1998), *Immunitas* (2002), *Bíos* (2004)—defined immunity, from the Latin *immunitas*, as exemption from the *munus*, the common obligation that binds members of a community, and showed that the immunitary paradigm protects life by negating it in controlled doses, as a vaccine protects by introducing the pathogen. *Immunitas*'s subtitle states the double operation: protection and negation of life.

3 *Autoimmunity.* Perfected, the protective apparatus turns against what it protects. Jacques Derrida generalized the biological term in "Foi et savoir" (1996) and *Voyous* (2003) to describe religions that destroy the faith they defend and democracies that suspend democracy to save it. Kubrick's films are its catalogue: the army that shoots its soldiers, the deterrent that ends the world, the computer that kills its crew, the cure that destroys its patient, the house that makes its caretaker a murderer.

4 *Sacrifice.* The autoimmune crisis is managed, where it can be, by the expulsion of a victim. René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) described the scapegoat mechanism by which a community in crisis restores its unity through unanimous violence against one; Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968) had already traced the kinship between the *pharmakon*, remedy and poison, and the *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled from the city in the Athenian Thargelia. The victim embodies the apparatus's double nature: the poison that must be expelled and the cure that its expulsion secures.

5 *Recursion.* Where sacrifice fails—because the apparatus has absorbed the sacred into itself, or because no victim is commensurate with the mechanism—the crisis becomes a wheel. Freud's repetition compulsion, Nietzsche's barrel-organ, Boethius's *rota Fortunae* name the form of an autoimmunity without resolution: the return of the same catastrophe, the caretaker who has always been the caretaker.

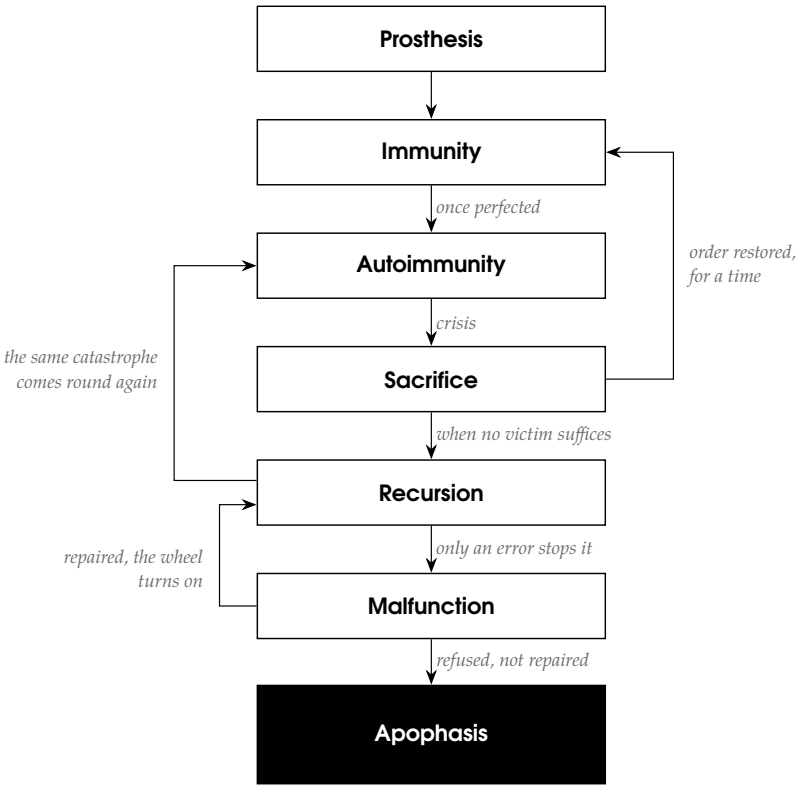
6 *Malfunction.* The wheel stops only by error. Georges Canguilhem's philosophy of the living—*Le normal et le pathologique* (1943; 1966) and "Le concept et la vie" (1966)—defined life by its normativity, its capacity to institute new norms, and its liability to error; in Foucault's gloss, life is that which is capable of error. The apparatus's failure opens an interval that its functioning had foreclosed.

7 *Apophasis.* In that interval the human appears—not as a nature, a function or a content, but negatively, as what the apparatus could not produce and cannot name: a hesitation, a refusal, an illegal move, a song, a mercy.

The cycle is not a history with a beginning and an end. It is a structure that recurs at every scale, from the single scene to the history of the species, and each Kubrick film restages it as a new "Dawn of Man." Anthropogenesis, on this account, is not an event in the Pleistocene but a continuous process in which the human is made, unmade and glimpsed.

15.2 **Spheres and islands.** Peter Sloterdijk's *Sphären* trilogy (1998–2004) supplies the theory's spatial dimension. Human beings, Sloterdijk argues, have always lived in spheres—shared, climatized interiors, from the womb and the pair to the city and the globe—and the third volume, *Schäume* (2004), describes the anthropogenetic islands, insulated spaces of relief from the pressure of the environment, in which the deficient animal could survive and become what it is. Kubrick's films are set in such islands: the waterhole of the apes, Discovery, the War Room, the Overlook, the Ludovico clinic, the barracks, the mansion of the ritual, the house reconstructed from memory at the end of *A.I.* Each is an immunitary sphere that breeds its humans, and each becomes the apparatus that destroys them. Sloterdijk's anthropotechnics—the practices by which human beings shape themselves through repetition and exercise—names the operations that take place within them: drill, conditioning, etiquette, strategy, rehearsal. Kubrick's films are, among other things, the most exacting representation in any art of anthropotechnics turned autoimmune.

The human appears only where the apparatus breaks



Read from top to bottom: sacrifice closes the loop only while a victim suffices; after that the crisis turns as a wheel, and only an error left unrepaired lets the human appear.

15.3 **Pharmacology without therapy.** Bernard Stiegler's later work, notably *Ce qui fait que la vie vaut la peine d'être vécue: De la pharmacologie* (2010), extended his theory of technics into a general pharmacology: every technical object is a *pharmakon*, at once poison and remedy, and the task of a politics of technology is to cultivate its therapeutic potential through practices of care. Kubrick's cinema shares Stiegler's diagnosis and withholds his therapy. No practice in his films succeeds in taming the *pharmakon*; the remedy becomes poison by its own logic, and the only interruption is the unplanned failure. The difference places Kubrick precisely between the two dominant contemporary attitudes to technology. Against the technophobia of Heidegger's late thought, which awaits a saving power from beyond technology, Kubrick holds that there is no pre-technical human to which to return: the prosthesis is constitutive, and the monolith precedes the ape's hand. Against the technophilia of Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985), which welcomed the cyborg as a hybrid free of the myths of origin, and against the transhumanist programmes of Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Near* (2005) and the risk analyses of Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014), Kubrick's cyborgs—Strangelove's hand, HAL, the Marines, David—are neither liberated nor liberating. They are immunitary products, and they are autoimmune.

15.4 **The cycle across the corpus.** The operation of the theory across the fourteen films can be set out in a single table. Its columns follow the moments of the cycle; its entries summarize the readings of Chapters 5 to 12.

15.4 The cycle across the corpus

Film	Apparatus	Immunitary function	Autoimmune inversion	*Pharmakos*	Figure of the wheel	Malfunction
***Fear and Desire* (1953)**	the patrol; the war without a name	survival behind the lines	to kill the enemy is to kill one's double	the captive woman	the raft drifting down-river	the lieutenant sees his own face in the dying general
***Killer's Kiss* (1955)**	the taxi-dance hall; the prize ring	a living sold by the minute and the round	the market of bodies turns murderous	the manager killed in the boxer's place	dances and rounds paid by the turn	the negative dream; the mannequins shattered in the fight
***The Killing* (1956)**	the plan	wealth secured by synchronized time	the conspirators destroy one another	the racehorse shot for a diversion	the racetrack; the race replayed	the lucky horseshoe; the broken lock and the poodle
***Paths of Glory* (1957)**	the general staff; the court-martial	defence of the nation	the army shells and shoots its own men	the three condemned soldiers	the checkerboard; the return to the front	the tavern song
***Spartacus* (1960)**	the gladiatorial school; the Roman state	the order of property	Rome crucifies its own labour force	the six thousand crucified	the arena's circuit of combat	Draba's refusal; the multiplied name
***Lolita* (1962)**	aesthetic solipsism; the road and the motel	the aesthete's protected fantasy	the abuse of a child, dressed as love, ruins the girl and her abuser	Quilty, the double	the film ends where it began	the girl's escape; shots through a painted face
***Dr. Strangelove* (1964)**	Plan R, the CRM-114, the Doomsday Machine	peace by threat	the deterrent annihilates the protected	none: sacrifice abolished	circling bombers; the round table	the jammed bomb-bay door, repaired
***2001* (1968)**	bone, satellite, HAL	survival; mission security	the ship's mind kills its crew	Poole and the sleepers	the rotating station; the returning alignment	HAL's error; the broken wine glass
***A Clockwork Orange* (1971)**	the Ludovico technique; the state	public safety by conditioning	the cure destroys self-defence and music	Alex, the state's instrument	cured of the cure	the chaplain's objection; the fall from the window
***Barry Lyndon* (1975)**	court society; honour; marriage	status as protection against destitution	ambition ruins its bearer	Bryan and the gift-horse	the *rota Fortunae* in two parts	Bullingdon's misfire; the shot into the ground

Film	Apparatus	Immunitary function	Autoimmune inversion	*Pharmakos*	Figure of the wheel	Malfunction
***The Shining* (1980)**	the hotel; the work ethic	shelter and solitude for work	the house makes the father a murderer	Hallorann	the eternal caretaker; the tricycle's circuits	the footprints walked backward
***Full Metal Jacket* (1987)**	the Corps; the rifle; the armoured body	defence of the nation	the product kills its maker	Pyle; the sniper	the marching cadence; the song of the ending	the mercy shot
***Eyes Wide Shut* (1999)**	the mask; money; the elite's rite	tact protecting intimacy	exposure and threat	Mandy	the waltz; the *ronde*; Ligeti's two notes	the unmasking; the dream that is not entirely a dream
***A.I.* (2001)**	the mecha; imprinting; the Flesh Fair	a substitute child as protection against grief	irrevocable love curses its bearer; humanity destroys its creatures	none: disposal replaces sacrifice	two thousand years of prayer; the frozen sea	the crowd's pity; one resurrected day

15.5 **Corollaries.** Several consequences follow from the table that could not be seen in the readings taken singly.

The first concerns causality. In none of the films is the autoimmune inversion caused by the corruption of the apparatus. It is caused by its perfection. The deterrent destroys the world because it is credible; HAL kills because he is committed to the mission; the Ludovico technique ruins Alex because it works; Pyle kills Hartman because Hartman succeeded. Kubrick's catastrophes are not failures of design but consequences of success, and this is what distinguishes his critique of reason from the moralistic critique that attributes disaster to a lapse of rationality.

The second concerns history. The column of the *pharmakos* traces a historical movement. In the earlier films the victim still carries meaning: the condemned soldiers of *Paths of Glory* and the crucified slaves of *Spartacus* are sacrificed to restore an order, and their deaths, however unjust, are legible. In *Dr. Strangelove* the sacrificial economy is abolished—no victim can appease the Doomsday Machine—and in *A.I.* sacrifice has become disposal, the destruction of beings that the apparatus classifies as waste. Kubrick's films record the end of the sacrificial regime described by Girard and its replacement by a regime of administration, in which violence no longer founds a community but maintains a system. That transition is, on this reading, the specific historical content of the twentieth century as Kubrick filmed it.

The third concerns the malfunction. The table's last column shows that malfunctions are not uniformly redemptive: the lucky horseshoe kills; the damaged radio dooms the *Leper Colony*; the repaired door ends the world. The theory does not claim that error saves. It claims that error opens an interval, and that the human appears in the relation to that interval—in the refusal to repair, the hesitation before the shot, the move off the board. Kong, who repairs the malfunction, and Barry, who occupies it with a gratuitous act, stand at the two poles of that relation.

The fourth concerns community. Esposito's later work sought an affirmative biopolitics, a form of community that would not negate life in protecting it. Kubrick's films offer no such institution. They offer only flashes of *communitas* that no apparatus produces and none survives: the song in the tavern, the multiplied name of Spartacus, the telepathic

gift shared by the old cook and the child, the pity of the crowd at the Flesh Fair. The *munus*, in Kubrick, is never a structure. It is an event.

15.6 **Objections.** Three objections to the theory must be considered. The first is methodological: that a theory which finds a single structure in fourteen films is a Ripperian construction, a paranoid reading that sees its pattern everywhere. The answer lies in the distinction between documented influence and heuristic affinity established in the Introduction, and in the table's own texture. The theory does not require every film to realize every moment with equal force; *Killer's Kiss* and *Lolita* realize it weakly, *Dr. Strangelove* and *2001* realize it completely, and the variation is itself informative. A paranoid reading admits no variation. This one depends on it.

The second objection is that the theory is covertly anti-technological, a Heideggerian lament in the vocabulary of immunology. It is not. The first moment of the cycle holds that there is no human before the prosthesis, and therefore no innocence to which to return and no outside of technics from which to condemn it. The monolith precedes the hand. What the theory rejects is not technics but the fantasy of its perfection—the belief that a sufficiently complete apparatus could protect the human without destroying it.

The third objection is the most serious, and it was raised in Chapter 4 in the words of Horkheimer and Adorno. If the human appears only negatively, as Nobody, is this not the self-mutilated bourgeois subject of the *Odyssey* excursus, the self that survives by denying itself, glorified as a residue of freedom? The objection cannot be answered within the theory of autoimmunity, which describes how the human is made and unmade but not what it is when it appears. It requires the final step of the argument, to which the next chapter is devoted: the passage from a general theory of the apparatus to an apophatic humanism.

16

The Name of Nobody

Toward an Apophatic Humanism

The general theory describes how the human is made by its apparatuses and unmade by their perfection. It does not say what the human is when it appears in their failure, and it cannot, because the appearance is negative: a refusal, a hesitation, a song, an error. This final chapter gives that negativity its philosophical form. It argues that Kubrick's cinema realizes, in the medium of the twentieth century, a humanism structured like negative theology—an *apophatic humanism*, which indicates the human only by what it is not—and it answers the objection that has shadowed the argument since Chapter 4: that the name under which this humanism appears, Nobody, is merely the self-denying cunning of the bourgeois subject.

16.1 **The ray of darkness.** The apophatic tradition begins, for the Christian West, with the treatise *On Mystical Theology* ascribed to Dionysius the Areopagite (c. 500). It opens with a prayer to be led beyond knowing, and its first chapter describes the ascent of the mind, having abandoned everything perceived and understood, "*πρὸς τὴν ὑπερούσιον τοῦ θείου σκότους ἀκτῖνα*"—toward the superessential ray of the divine darkness.

The oxymoron is the tradition's signature: a ray that is darkness, a light that can be approached only by the abandonment of every light. Dionysius distinguished the kataphatic way, which names God by affirmations drawn from creatures, from the apophatic way, which denies each of them in turn, and he held the second to be higher, since the cause of all things is beyond both affirmation and negation. Plotinus had given the method its imperative, cited in the Introduction—ἄφελε πάντα, take away everything—and the Dionysian corpus transmitted it to the medieval mystics.

Meister Eckhart preached on the verse of Acts that describes Saul after his vision on the road to Damascus: "Surrexit autem Saulus de terra apertisque oculis nihil videbat"—Saul rose from the earth, and with his eyes open he saw nothing (Acts 9:8). Eckhart drew from it four senses, the first of which is the boldest: that when Saul rose with open eyes he saw nothing, and the nothing was God. The English of the King James Bible renders the same clause with an unintended precision: "when his eyes were opened, he saw no man." With eyes open, he saw Nobody. Kubrick's last film inverts the formula in its title—eyes wide shut—and his first great film of transcendence ends with a being who has seen, beyond the Star Gate, nothing that can be shown. Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) made the knowledge of one's ignorance the highest knowledge available to finite minds, and his *De visione Dei* (1453) supplied an image that anticipates, with startling exactness, the formal argument of Chapter 14. Cusanus sent the monks of Tegernsee a painted face whose eyes seemed to follow each beholder wherever he stood, and asked them to walk before it: each would find himself regarded, as if the gaze were his alone. The all-seeing icon is the returning vanishing point as theology. Pavel Florensky's essay on reverse perspective (1920) would argue that the Byzantine icon constructs its space not toward a vanishing point behind the picture but toward the beholder, so that the image looks out at the one who looks. Kubrick's perspectival compositions complete Alberti's window with Florensky's reversal at their centre, and the monolith, the icon of the prohibition of images, regards those who stand before it.

Theodor Adorno recognized the prohibition of images as the point at which materialism and theology converge. In *Negative Dialektik*

(1966) he argued that materialism secularizes the *Bilderverbot*: it refuses to paint utopia, because any positive image of the reconciled world would betray it to the world as it is. The monolith is that refusal given mass and proportion. It is also, as Chapter 12 showed, the posture in which the machines of the far future stand before the vanished human. Apophatic humanism is the application of the *Bilderverbot* to the human itself: the refusal to image the human positively, because every positive image—the rational animal, the tool-maker, the soldier, the patient, the consumer, the overman—has been the specification of an apparatus.

16.2 **The negative filmography.** The apophatic structure of Kubrick's work extends to the films he did not make. Chapter 9 described the abandoned *Napoleon*, in which the greatest planner of modern history would have been undone by contingency; the substitution of *Barry Lyndon* replaced the world-soul on horseback with a lame nobody. The second great absence concerns the event that Adorno placed at the centre of post-war thought when he wrote that to write a poem after Auschwitz is barbaric—"nach Auschwitz ein Gedicht zu schreiben, ist barbarisch" ("Kulturkritik und Gesellschaft," 1949). Kubrick prepared for years a film of Louis Begley's *Wartime Lies* (1991), the story of a Jewish child who survives the occupation of Poland by assuming a false identity, under the title *Aryan Papers*. He abandoned it in 1993, when Steven Spielberg's *Schindler's List* was released; Frederic Raphael's memoir reports his remark that Spielberg's film was about the few hundred who survive, whereas the Holocaust is about the millions who do not. Whether or not the remark is exact, the abandonment aligns Kubrick with the position Claude Lanzmann defended in *Shoah* (1985), a nine-hour film that contains no archival image of the extermination and consists of testimony, places and silence: the position that the event exceeds representation and that its image would be a betrayal. The two largest subjects he took up, Napoleon's conquest of Europe and the Nazi murder of Europe's Jews, are present in his oeuvre only as absences. The negative filmography is the oeuvre's apophatic margin, and the film about a child who survives by hiding his name is the one he could not make.

16.3 **Neither humanism nor antihumanism.** The French thought of the 1960s announced the end of the human as a category. Claude Lévi-

Strauss wrote in *La Pensée sauvage* (1962) that the ultimate goal of the human sciences is "pas de constituer l'homme, mais de le dissoudre," not to constitute man but to dissolve him. Louis Althusser proclaimed a theoretical antihumanism. And Michel Foucault closed *Les Mots et les choses* (1966) with the wager that man, a recent invention of the modern episteme, would be erased "comme à la limite de la mer un visage de sable," like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. Kubrick's cinema, contemporary with these declarations, has often been assimilated to them. It shares their critique of the humanist subject—the sovereign, rational, self-transparent individual—and their attention to the structures that produce it. But it does not dissolve the human into those structures. It holds the face of sand at the moment of its erasure, when the wave has begun to take it and the face is visible precisely as what is being taken. The human, in Kubrick, is neither a substance to be affirmed nor an illusion to be dissolved. It is what appears in the apparatus's failure to complete its work.

The philosopher who came closest to this position was not among the structuralists. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) described the face of the other as that which breaks the totality—the system that comprehends everything by assigning it a place—and he held that the face is not an image or a content but an expression that exceeds every form, whose first word is the commandment not to kill. The face, in Levinas, is apophatic: it cannot be seen as an object, only encountered as an appeal. Kubrick's malfunctions are, again and again, encounters with a face. The lieutenant turns over the dying general and sees his own. The soldiers in the tavern look at the singing girl and stop jeering. Joker looks at the dying sniper, who asks to be shot. Bill Harford bends over Mandy's face in the morgue. The crowd at the Flesh Fair sees a boy's face pleading. The Star Child turns its face to the earth and to us. In each case the face interrupts a totality—the war, the ritual, the spectacle—and in each case what it demands cannot be derived from the apparatus it interrupts.

16.4 **The animal that can say no.** Max Scheler, in *Die Stellung des Menschen im Kosmos* (1928), defined the human not by reason but by the capacity for refusal: "Der Mensch ist der ‚Neinsagenkönner'," the being that can say no, "der ewige Protestant gegen alle bloße Wirklichkeit," the eternal

protester against all mere actuality. Kubrick's films contain a gallery of Scheler's figures, and their refusals are the purest instances of apophatic humanism, since a refusal indicates the human only by what it declines. The battery commander of *Paths of Glory* who will not fire on his own trenches without a written order—a man whom the film, with an irony it does not underline, names Rousseau. The gladiator who will not kill his opponent. The chaplain who will not endorse the Ludovico cure. Barry, who will not take the shot the rules allow him. The professor in Tarkovsky's Zone who will not detonate his bomb has his counterparts here in every film.

The refusal belongs with the error whose philosophy Canguilhem supplied and with a third form of negativity that literature had named. André Gide's *Les Caves du Vatican* (1914) invented the *acte gratuit*, the act without motive, and gave it the form of a murder: Lafcadio pushes a stranger from a train to prove his freedom. Kubrick's gratuitous acts are the inversion of Gide's. They are acts of mercy without motive—Barry's shot into the ground, Joker's shot into the sniper, Dax's few more minutes for the singing men—and their gratuity is what makes them visible against the calculating background of the apparatus. The human appears as an unaccountable gift.

16.5 **Outis.** The emblem of the dissertation must now be read in full. In the ninth book of the *Odyssey*, asked his name by the Cyclops, Odysseus answers: "Οὖτις ἐμοί γ' ὄνομα· Οὖτιν δέ με κικλήσκουσι / μήτηρ ἠδὲ πατὴρ ἠδ' ἄλλοι πάντες ἑταῖροι"—Nobody is my name; Nobody I am called by my mother and father and all my companions (IX.366–367). When the blinded giant cries out that Nobody is killing him by guile and not by force (IX.408), his neighbours answer that if no one (μή τις) is harming him he must be ill, and Odysseus laughs in his heart that his name and his flawless cunning (μῆτις) had deceived them (IX.414). The pun is the crux of Horkheimer and Adorno's reading, discussed in Chapter 4. *Outis*, Nobody, becomes *mêtis*, cunning; the self-effacement is a ruse, the self denies its identity in order to preserve it, and the history of civilization is the history of this introversion of sacrifice, in which the subject masters nature by mutilating its own.

The objection that follows for this dissertation is serious. If the human appears in Kubrick only as Nobody, is apophatic humanism anything

more than a celebration of the bourgeois subject's self-mutilation—the survival strategy of a self that has learned to make itself nothing in order to endure the apparatus?

16.6 **Residue, not ruse.** The answer turns on what happens after the Cyclops's cave. Homer's Odysseus does not remain Nobody. Safely aboard his ship, he shouts back to the blinded giant his true name and lineage: if any mortal asks who blinded you, say it was Odysseus, sacker of cities, son of Laertes, whose home is in Ithaca (IX.502–505). The self that denied itself in order to survive reasserts itself as soon as it is safe, and the reassertion is punished, since it allows the Cyclops to name his enemy in a prayer to Poseidon that condemns Odysseus to ten years of wandering. The Homeric Nobody is a ruse precisely because it is temporary: a mask worn by a subject who remains intact behind it and who reclaims his name, with his pride, when the danger has passed. Horkheimer and Adorno's reading is correct for Homer.

It is not correct for Kubrick, and the difference is the thesis of this dissertation. Kubrick's Nobodies never reclaim their names. Bowman, having crossed the vacuum without a helmet and disconnected the Cyclops, does not announce himself; he is carried into the Star Gate, stripped of body and age, and returned as a nameless child. The men who stand to declare themselves Spartacus die under a borrowed name. Barry, after the shot into the ground, leaves on a crutch and disappears into an epilogue that makes him equal to everyone. The singing girl is never named; the sniper is never named; David never becomes the real boy whose name he bears. What appears in these moments is not a self hiding behind a mask but what remains when every mask, prosthesis and name has been subtracted. Kubrick's Nobody is not a ruse but a residue.

The second difference concerns economy. The Homeric ruse, as Horkheimer and Adorno insisted, is an exchange: the subject gives up its identity to purchase its life, and the whole of civilization, on their account, is an extension of that calculating renunciation. Kubrick's Nobodies do not purchase anything. Barry's mercy costs him his leg. Draba's refusal costs him his life. The Spartacans' solidarity costs them the cross. Bowman's crossing costs him his body; David's fidelity costs him two thousand years. Their acts are expenditures without return—what Georges Bataille called *dépense*, what Derrida in *Donner le temps*

(1991) described as the gift that must not return to the giver, what Esposito described as the *munus*, the gift that constitutes community because no one can own it. The bourgeois ruse preserves the self by giving up its content. Kubrick's residue gives itself without preservation. It is the precise opposite of the introversion of sacrifice: not the self sacrificed to the self's survival, but the self spent for another, outside every calculation of survival.

Adorno himself left a door open to this reading. The last aphorism of *Minima Moralia* (1951) held that the only philosophy that could be responsibly practised in the face of despair would be the attempt to contemplate all things as they would appear "vom Standpunkt der Erlösung," from the standpoint of redemption—to fashion perspectives that estrange the world and reveal it, with its rifts and crevices, as it will one day appear in the messianic light. Kubrick's cinema is that attempt without the messiah. Its perspectives estrange the world with a rigour that has few equals in any art; its rifts and crevices are the malfunctions of the apparatus; and its light is not messianic. It is supplied by us.

16.7 **The lantern, the monolith, and the equality of Nobody.** The figures that have recurred through this dissertation can now be gathered. Diogenes of Sinope lit a lamp in daylight and walked the agora saying, "*ἄνθρωπον ζητῶ*," I am looking for a human being (Diogenes Laertius VI.41); Nietzsche's madman lit a lantern in the morning to announce the death of God (Chapter 2). Kubrick relights the lantern and searches through armies, clinics, hotels, spacecraft and mansions, and what he finds is Nobody. This is not the failure of the search but its result. The human is not the object found by the lantern; it is the one who carries it, who supplies light in the darkness—a prosthesis that is not an apparatus, because its purpose is not to capture, protect or control but to see. The monolith, which Chapter 5 read as an icon presenting the human not as a content but as an address, is the dark screen before which the lantern is lifted. In *A.I.* the positions are reversed and the human has become the monolith, the vanished maker whom the machines approach by the light of a child's memory. And the epilogue of *Barry Lyndon* supplies the social consequence: rich or poor, they are all equal now.

That equality is the political content of apophatic humanism. If the human were defined by a positive quality—reason, strength, fit-

ness, genius—then some would possess more of it than others, and the apparatuses of selection that recur throughout Kubrick's films would be justified: the lottery of the court-martial, the mineshaft of Dr. Strangelove, the breeding programme parodied in his hand, the Flesh Fair's line between the living and the made. Because the human has no positive content, no one possesses more of it than another. Nobody is the name that Odysseus says his mother, his father and all his companions call him: the one name that is everyone's. The multiplied name of Spartacus is its political form. Apophatic humanism is egalitarian not by decree but by structure. It grounds the dignity of each on the one thing that no apparatus can distribute unequally, because it is not a thing.

16.8 **Theses.** The argument of the dissertation can be condensed into six theses on apophatic humanism.

1 The human is not a nature but an interval: it appears between the operations of an apparatus, when the apparatus fails.

2 Its appearances are negative in form—refusal, hesitation, error, mercy, song, the move off the board—and they cannot be produced on demand, since whatever is produced on demand belongs to the apparatus.

3 The human cannot be imaged; it can be addressed. Its icon is a black screen before which one stands and is changed.

4 The human is universal because it is empty. Nobody is everyone's name, and the negative definition of the human is the ground of equality.

5 The human is fragile. It survives only in memory and fidelity, and in the end it may be kept by what it made.

6 The human supplies its own light. The light is not a revelation received but a practice performed, in a darkness that no apparatus will ever abolish.

Conclusion

Supplying Our Own Light

This dissertation began from the judgement that has followed Kubrick's work since its first reception: that it is cold, that its perfectionism conceals contempt, that its maker regarded human beings as specimens under glass. It proposed to invert that judgement without denying its evidence. The coldness is real; it is the temperature of a method. Kubrick subtracted from his sources the explanations, the voices and the redemptions that would have told his audience what the human is, and he did so not because he believed there was nothing to tell, but because every positive answer the twentieth century had given—the rational animal, the soldier, the citizen, the patient, the consumer, the overman—had turned out to be the specification of an apparatus. What remains after the subtraction is not contempt but a humanism of the negative. The preceding chapters have attempted to demonstrate it proposition by proposition, and the demonstration can now be summarized.

1 *The prosthetic proposition.* The human in Kubrick has no nature prior to its technical supplements. The monolith precedes the hand in the "Dawn of Man"; the Marine is made by his rifle; Strangelove is assembled from his prostheses; David is a child produced by a protocol. The genealogy from Protagoras to Stiegler (Chapters 1 and 5) supplies the theory, and the films supply its images.

2 *The immunitary proposition.* Every prosthesis is protective, and every protection, perfected, turns against what it protects. The army shoots its soldiers, the deterrent annihilates the world, the ship's mind kills its crew, the cure destroys the patient, the house makes the father a murderer. The dialectic of enlightenment (Chapter 4) and the theory of autoim-

munity (Chapter 15) are two names for the structure these films anatomize.

3 *The sacrificial proposition.* The autoimmune crisis is managed by the expulsion of a *pharmakos*, and the oeuvre records the historical decline of that expedient: from the legible sacrifices of *Paths of Glory* and *Spartacus*, through the abolition of sacrifice in *Dr. Strangelove*, to the disposal of the Flesh Fair (Chapters 6, 7, 12 and 15).

4 *The recursive proposition.* Where sacrifice fails, the crisis becomes a wheel: the barrel-organ rather than the self-rolling wheel, the caretaker who has always been the caretaker, the *rota Fortunae*, the cure of the cure (Chapters 2, 8, 9 and 10).

5 *The perspectival proposition.* The rational construction of space is completed by an object that returns the gaze: HAL's lens, the twins at the corridor's end, the monolith at the convergence of the alignments, the stare of the apparatus's products (Chapters 3 and 14).

6 *The proposition of malfunction.* The wheel stops only by error—a misstated move, a misfiring pistol, a broken glass, a jammed door—and the human appears not in the error itself but in the relation to it: in the refusal to repair, the hesitation, the move off the board (Chapters 5, 7, 9 and 15).

7 *The apophatic proposition.* The human is indicated only negatively, as Nobody: not the cunning self that hides behind a false name in order to survive, but the residue that remains when every mask, prosthesis and name has been subtracted, and whose emptiness is the ground of equality (Chapters 5, 12 and 16).

The argument claims three contributions. To the study of Kubrick, it offers a unified philosophical reading of the whole oeuvre—including the documentary shorts, the posthumous *A.I.* and the unmade films—organized neither by the biographical legend of the perfectionist nor by the critical topos of coldness, but by the logic of the adaptor-philosopher's subtractions. To film-philosophy, it offers an account of form as thought: the returning vanishing point, the illegal move, the stratigraphy of pre-existing music, the take as a machine for producing the accident. To philosophical anthropology, it offers two

concepts. *Autoimmune anthropogenesis* joins the tradition of the deficient animal—Protagoras, Herder, Gehlen, Stiegler—to the contemporary theory of immunity, sacrifice and error—Esposito, Derrida, Girard, Canguilhem—in a single cycle. *Apophatic humanism* names a third position between the humanism that affirms a human essence and the structural antihumanism that dissolves it, and it answers, by the distinction between residue and ruse, the most serious objection that Horkheimer and Adorno's reading of the *Odyssey* raises against any humanism of the negative.

The limits of the argument are the limits of its method. Transpositional hermeneutics distinguishes documented influence from heuristic affinity, and many of the affinities proposed here—Dante's Ptolomea, Cusanus's all-seeing icon, Swift's letter to Pope, Forster's Machine—remain heuristic. The Stanley Kubrick Archive at the University of the Arts London, whose annotated books, research files and production papers have transformed the field since they were opened to researchers, offers the means to convert some of these affinities into documented relations and to refute others. The general theory also invites comparison beyond Kubrick: with filmmakers whose humanism is positive, as Tarkovsky's is; with those, like Robert Bresson, whose cinema of grace locates the human in a gift that arrives from outside; and with the filmmakers of the apparatus who have followed him. A theory of autoimmune anthropogenesis that held for a single oeuvre would be a reading. One that illuminated others would be a contribution to the philosophy of the medium.

Coda: HAL's heirs. In the quarter-century since Kubrick's death the machines he imagined have ceased to be speculative. Conversational systems answer questions in a fluent and courteous voice; automated systems assess credit, allocate policing and select targets; and the regulation of weapons that select and engage targets without human intervention has been debated since 2014 by the states party to the United Nations Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, around the formula of "meaningful human control." In the last decade of the Cold War the Soviet Union reportedly built a semi-automatic system of retaliation, known in the West as the Dead Hand, which David E. Hoffman's history of that name (2009) describes as a means of launching a

counterstrike after the leadership had been destroyed: Plan R and the Doomsday Machine converging in a real apparatus. And I. J. Good's forgotten proviso—that the first ultraintelligent machine would be the last invention humanity need make only if it proved docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control—has become the central problem of research on machine intelligence, formulated as the problem of control in Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) and Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019).

Kubrick's cinema holds three lessons for this situation, and none of them is the lesson usually drawn from HAL. The first is that the danger of an apparatus lies less in its malfunction than in its perfect function. HAL kills not because he is broken but because he is committed to the mission, and the most dangerous systems are those most faithfully designed to protect. The second is that the human in the loop matters not because it calculates better than the machine but because it can hesitate, refuse and err—because it is the place where the apparatus can fail in the human's favour. From the standpoint of the system that capacity looks like noise, and the history Kubrick filmed is the history of its elimination: the recall code locked in a madman's head, the bomber that cannot hear, the Doomsday Machine that no one can switch off. A civilization that removes hesitation from its loops removes the site where the human appears. The third lesson is the one that *A.I.* adds to *2001*. The question is not only whether machines will be docile, but what they will keep of us—whether, when they stand before the human as the apes stood before the monolith, they will find the record of our apparatuses or the memory of a single day of love.

2001 ends with a face. The child who was a man, having passed through the machine and beyond it, turns in its sphere of light toward the earth and toward the audience, and looks. It has no name, no mission and no content; it is the portrait of the human as Nobody, and it regards us as the monolith regarded the apes—as an address awaiting an answer. In the interview he gave to *Playboy* in the year of the film, Kubrick argued that the very meaninglessness of the universe compels human beings to create their own meaning, and he closed with a sentence that this dissertation has taken as the principle of his work: "however vast the darkness, we must supply our own light." The

light is not revealed; it is supplied. It belongs to no apparatus, and no apparatus can distribute it unequally. Diogenes carried it through the marketplace in daylight looking for a human being and did not find one. Kubrick carried it through the armies, clinics, hotels and spacecraft of the twentieth century and returned with the same report. The search did not fail. The human is the one who carries the lantern.

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Stanley Kubrick
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technics
anthropotechnics
dialectic of enlightenment
instrumental reason
the uncanny
the double
golem
eternal recurrence
pharmakon
pharmakos
scapegoat mechanism
sacrifice
malfunction and error
nuclear deterrence
sovereignty and the state of exception
one-point perspective
the gaze
artificial intelligence
posthumanism
speculative fiction
philosophical fiction
Odysseus
Outis
the monolith
Nietzsche
Canguilhem
Esposito
Derrida
Sloterdijk
Stiegler
Adorno

However vast the darkness, we must supply our own light.

Stanley Kubrick, 1968

